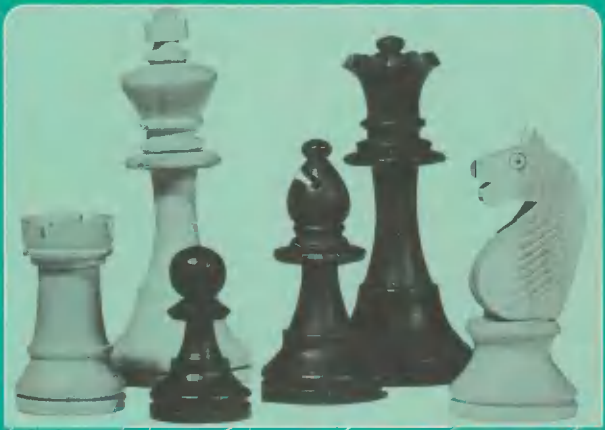
Alexander Kotov

Chess TACTICS



POPULAR

Chess Tactics

Chess Tactics

Alexander Kotov

Translated and edited by
John Littlewood

American Chess Promotion, Macon, Georgia

First published in the United States 1983
© Estate of Alexander Kotov, 1983

ISBN 0 7134 2562 8 (limp)

Printed in Great Britain
for the publishers
American Chess Promotions
3055 General Lee Road
Macon, Georgia 31204

Contents

Preface	vi
Introduction	vii
1 The Combination	1
2 Mating Combinations	6
3 Game Patterns	50
4 Combinations Involving Pawns	56
5 The Genesis of Combinations	84
6 Combinations Exploiting Piece Placings	91
7 Beauty and Imagination	118
8 Tactical Finesses	125
9 Conclusion	137
Translator's Note	142
Index of Players	145

Preface

In order to play chess well, it is vitally important, along with the need to evaluate a position correctly and form suitable plans, to be able to produce accurately calculated combinations when the conditions are right for them. Most combinations consist of a series of forced moves, usually involving a sacrifice, which lead to either material or positional advantage, if not mate. In the present volume we first examine briefly the background and then attempt the difficult task of classifying the vast range of combinations in a way which we hope will prove useful to the reader. By thus pin-pointing the basic elements of the combination and studying its mechanism, we must surely remove some of that unnecessary fear or unquestioning admiration which many players experience when faced with a lengthy and complex combination. If the careful reader can then begin to apply to his own games the lessons in tactics that he acquires, the author's efforts will be amply rewarded.

Alexander Kotov

Introduction

Many grandmasters testify to the profound impression which their first encounter with the game of chess made on them. How romantic and mysterious did the appearance and movements of the various pieces seem to their young gaze! The fleet-footed bishop, sturdily dependable rook, voraciously powerful queen, not forgetting that restless spirit, the fearless knight, nimbly leaping over those foot-soldiers, the humble pawns, mostly cannon-fodder lending support to their officers or preparing to be sacrificed for the greater good, but occasionally, as if by magic, being promoted to the top of the hierarchy! Gradually, and in some respects sadly, theoretical knowledge dispelled the mists of this first impression, revealing the iron logic of strategic ideas and affording a glimpse of the ultimate truth in chess attainable solely via the path of hard work and methodical training.

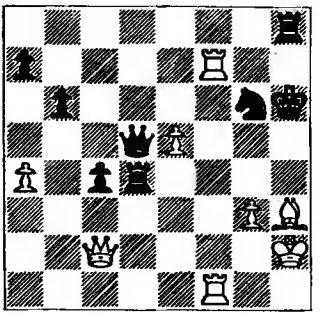
Once a chess-player has acquired elementary knowledge and is ready to test himself in the hard school of practical play, he soon learns to recognize that the three pillars of chess wisdom are: the art of combination, the ability to calculate variations rapidly and accurately, and finally the understanding and creative application of strategic principles. This chess wisdom enables the master to respond pertinently to the two basic questions constantly facing him: what to do and how to do it. The first involves *strategy*, the second *tactics*. Strategic plans can be many and varied, ranging from switching a piece to a strong square to the regrouping of a whole wing, involving decisions about whether to close the centre or when to launch an attack, and so on. The success in carrying out such plans largely depends upon our tactical ability; not only must we be capable of exploiting the means at hand, but we must also be aware of the tactics available to our opponent.

These underlying strategic and tactical possibilities determine the character of the position which can thus be roughly considered as belonging to a certain general type. In some cases it is the strategic aspect which is uppermost, and the calculation of specific variations recedes into the background. In other cases the opposite is true, and the outcome may then hang on a tactical thread, with strategy being of little or no use and combinative resourcefulness at a premium. It is the latter situations which form the subject of this volume, so let us now enter the marvellous world of tactical dangers, hidden traps and razor-sharp positions.

1 The Combination

Logic lies at the heart of chess and is mirrored in principles which have been distilled from centuries of chess thought and play and which serve as a compass to steer a player towards the selection of the appropriate strategy. The first concept a beginner acquires is the different values associated with individual pieces. He learns that a queen is nearly worth two rooks, a minor piece and one or two pawns balance out a rook, bishop and knight are about equal and that a minor piece is equivalent to three pawns. However, he soon realizes that this evaluation is only a guide-line and that, for example, in certain situations a pawn can be worth more than a rook or even a queen. In fact, positions often occur in which a drastic reversal of accepted values takes place, with a player suddenly giving up his queen for a knight or sacrificing his rook for a single pawn, not through an oversight but because in that particular situation it represents the best plan. Of course, such sacrifices are usually short-term, involving a forced sequence of moves which rapidly lead to an advantage for the perpetrator of them. Our first position illustrates this point.

1



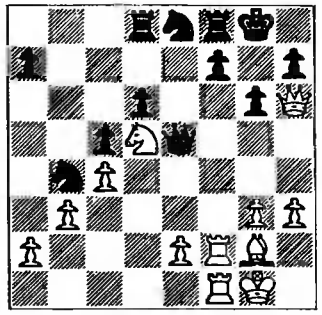
Nezhmetdinov–Kasparian
Riga, 1955

Both kings are in danger, but White to move can exploit the situation before Black can carry out his threat of 1 ... ♖d2+. Whilst there is no doubt that queens are normally far stronger than knights, we are here dealing with a mating set-up in which no sacrifice is too great. The black knight is eliminated, exposing the king to a forced mate as follows: **1 ♕xg6+! ♔xg6 2 ♖1f6+ ♔g5 3 ♖f5+** (the black rook on d4 prevents 3 ♖g7+ ♔h5 4 ♗g4 mate, so White aims to switch his rooks round) **3 ... ♔g6 4 ♖7f6+ ♔h7 5 ♖h5+ ♔g7 6 ♖g5+ ♔h7 7 ♗f5** mate.

It is clear that all these moves were forced, a typical feature of

combinations which makes it easier for the attacker to calculate. The so-called 'quiet' move within a combinative sequence is not met as frequently, for obvious reasons. Consider our next example.

2

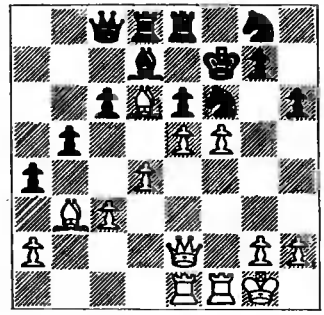


Levenfish–Gotthilf
Leningrad, 1924

First of all, a queen sacrifice exposes the weakness of the f7 pawn, leading to a forced series of moves up to a point. It is here that White had to foresee a couple of quiet moves, admittedly not too difficult to visualize, plus a further sequence ending eventually in mate. Play continued: **1 ♕xf8+! ♔xf8 2 ♖xf7+ ♔g8 3 ♘e7+ ♔h8** (he could of course give up his queen for the knight, but White would then have a clear material advantage. However, in general the attacker must always carefully consider such a defensive possibility) **4 ♖f8+ ♔g7 5 ♖1f7+ ♔h6 6 ♘g8+ ♔g5**. The forced sequence is at an end, since the obvious check with the h pawn would allow ... ♔g4 attacking the pawn on g3. White must have already planned the following final king hunt: **7 ♔h2! ♕xe2 8 h4+ ♔g4 9 ♖7f4+ ♔h5 10 ♔h3! g5 11 g4+** and Black resigned in view of the forcing line **11 ... ♔g6 12 h5+ ♔g7 13 ♖4f7+ ♔h8** when any move of the knight mates him.

We repeat that no sacrifice is too great when our aim is to mate the enemy king. Here is a typical Alekhine combination involving a queen sacrifice, a king hunt and finally a quiet move to complete the kill.

3



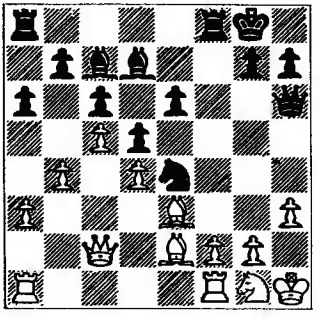
Alekhine–Prat
Simultaneous, Paris, 1913

The black king is clearly in trouble on f7, facing the crossfire of White's pieces, so it is hardly surprising that the end is nigh. **1 ♕h5+!! ♘xh5 2 fe+ ♔g6 3 ♗c2+ ♔g5 4 ♖f5+ ♔g6 5 ♖f6+ ♔g5 6 ♖g6+ ♔h4 7 ♖e4+ ♘f4 8 ♖xf4+ ♔h5 9 g3!** and Black has no way of preventing **10 ♖h4** mate.

The end-product of a sacrifical combination does not necessarily

have to be mate; it could instead lead to a material advantage, or else both ideas are present, as in the following example.

4



Composed position

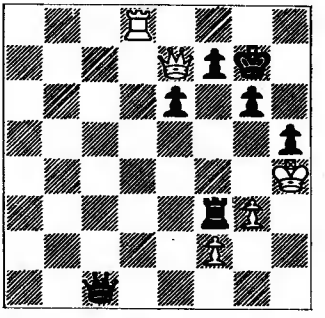
By 1 ... ♕xe3! Black either obtains material superiority or mates as in the game continuation: 2 fe ♘g3+ 3 ♔h2 ♘xf1+ 4 ♔h1 ♘g3+ 5 ♔h2 ♘e4+ 6 g3 (or 6 ♔h1 ♘f2 mate) 6 ... ♖f2+ 7 ♔h1 ♘xg3 mate.

There are also combinations which save the game in desperate situations, the stalemate type being one of the most attractive as well as occurring more often than people imagine (*See Diagram 5*)

White to move appears to have a completely hopeless position, but a surprising sacrifice brings about the draw as follows: **1 ♕f8+ ♔f6 2 ♕h8+ ♔f5 3 g4+! hg 4 ♖d5+! ed 5 ♕c8+! ♕xc8 stalemate.**

Even in the earliest recorded period of chess history the aesthetic

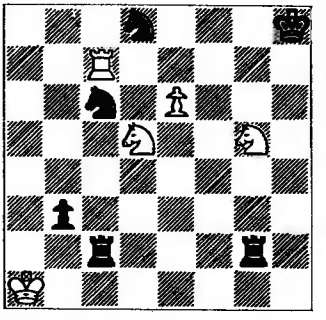
5



Lazdis–Zemitis
Riga, 1936

side of combinations delighted the public who appreciated a startling sacrifice. Here is an example from Persia.

6

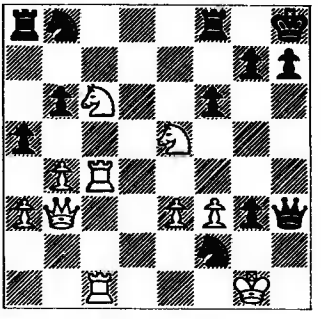


Persian study of the 14th century

1 ♖h7+ ♔g8 2 ♘f6+ ♔f8 3 e7+! ♘xe7 4 ♖f7+! ♘xf7 5 ♘e6 mate.

Combinations such as these were written down to delight later generations of chess-players, and we can all still enjoy a piece of tactical wizardry like the following composed by Stamma, an Arab.

7



18th century study by Stamma

White exploits the weakness of Black's back rank whilst at the same time defending against the threatened mate: 1 ♖h4! ♕xh4 (if 1 ... ♕c8 2 ♘g6 mate; or 1 ... ♕f5 2 ♘e7 wins) 2 ♕g8+! ♔xg8 (of course 2 ... ♖xg8 allows the 'smothered' 3 ♘f7 mate) 3 ♘e7+ ♔h8 4 ♘f7+ ♖xf7 5 ♖c8+ ♖f8 6 ♖xf8 mate.

From the 19th century onwards we have witnessed the greatest upsurge in the development of chess. In the early days combinative skill was the privilege of a few highly talented players, amongst whom the brilliance of Adolf Anderssen and Paul Morphy is legendary. Nowadays, modern chess-teaching methods have brought the basic techniques and understanding of combinations within reach of any keen learner, with the result that we constantly find beautiful tactical finishes even in the games of average club-players. This is all because over the years combinations have been broken down into their basic elements in order to analyse the logical components of the apparent 'magic'. In this way the intimate relationship between positional and tactical factors has been clearly demonstrated, bringing in its train a new and vital approach to all parts of the game.

Motive, aim and means

An experienced player will never look for a combination in certain types of quiet positions, but will rather attempt to regroup his pieces into a more active set-up or to create attackable weaknesses in the enemy position. Then, suddenly, he senses a change in the situation and immediately begins to calculate tactical variations which could bring about new, exciting positions. He risks a sacrifice, ignores normal material considerations and, as if by magic, carries out an effective combination.

Of course, on many occasions this so-called intuitive feeling that a combination is at hand turns out to be illusory or else the player has neither the time nor ability to achieve the desired aim. What concerns us here is the genesis of a combination; what are the positional elements that lead us to suspect the presence of a tactical solution? There are many such prerequisites of a combination, and one of the basic themes of this volume will be to elucidate them. However, for the moment let us be clear about our terminology. We shall refer to these elements as

motive. Consider, for example, Alekhine's combination from diagram 4. Which are the positional factors that alert us to the possibility of a combination? Above all, it is the exposed position of the black king and the harmonious disposition of the white pieces which create the necessary conditions for the forcing series of tactical blows against the enemy king.

In this connection it is interesting to note Alekhine's comment: 'There are positions in which one is duty-bound to combine, since a neglected opportunity rapidly slips out of the grasp of the attacker who is gradually forced onto the defensive and may even end up losing a game he should have won, a fate he thoroughly deserves!' In other words, once we unearth a combinational motive we are obliged to pursue it to its logical conclusion.

The second important part of a combination is the *aim*, in the shape of certain concrete advantages which the resulting final position offers. When a player calculates a simple or complex combination he has to evaluate the end-product, his aim, with the greatest care, because it is on this judgement that the soundness of the combination depends. In the Alekhine position it is easy to see the splendid final mate he had in mind when he gave his well-placed pieces the order to throw everything into the attack on the king.

Last but by no means least, we come to the third vital part of a combination. In order to achieve our aim after we have discovered the motive, we need a concrete series of moves, the *means*. For example, if we look back at diagram 7, the knowledge that 'something was on' would have proved of little use without the brilliant 2 ♕g8+! to bring about the desired aim.

So, motive, aim and means are the three essential ingredients of our combinative pie, but tactical play does not end there. Along with the ability to calculate forcing variations accurately, a player must also be able to recognize in time any unexpected counter from his opponent and cope with the change in the situation, must learn to set traps which are not obvious and constantly unsettle his adversary with tactical threats.

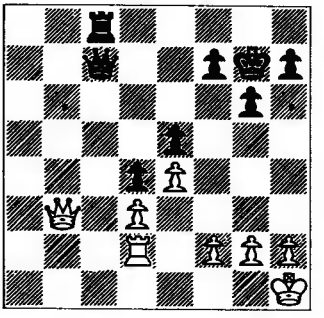
Before we proceed with our examination of the combination, we must again stress the interdependence between strategy and tactics that we hinted at when indicating that it is positional elements which in the first place point to the existence of a possible combination. Indeed, all top-class players of necessity complement their deep strategy with wide-ranging tactical skills.

In order not to break down our material into too many sections, we have simply divided it into three broad groups comprising mating combinations, combinations involving pawns, and finally those that exploit the unfavourable placing of pieces.

2 Mating Combinations

The ultimate goal in every game is of course mate. If we obtain a decisive material advantage, there is usually no difficulty in mating and in fact our opponent often resigns long before this happens. What concerns us here is the mating combination that comes at the conclusion of a concentrated attack on the enemy king. There are many different kinds which we will classify as follows:
Back-rank combinations
Seventh rank combinations
Diagonal combinations
Linear combinations
Exploitation of weak points
Drawing out the enemy king
Demolishing the king's defences
Various other mates.

8



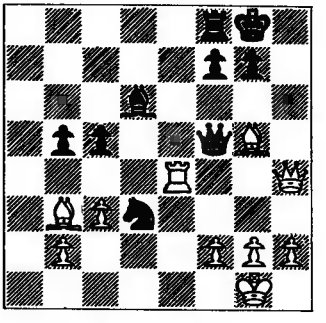
Composed position

Black to move wins by exploiting the weakness of White's back-rank as follows: 1 ... ♕c1+ 2 ♖d1 (after 2 ♕d1 ♖c2!! White is helpless) 2 ... ♖c2! 3 ♖g1 (after the better 3 ♕b1 ♕xb1 4 ♖xb1 ♖xf2 Black wins the ending) 3 ... ♕xg1+! 4 ♔xg1 ♖c1+ followed by mate.

Back-rank combinations

An untouched row of three pawns in front of the king is usually a defensive asset, but it can also be fatal when the back-rank is unprotected. In such cases no sacrifice is too great if we can succeed in penetrating to the back-rank with a major piece giving mate to the king.

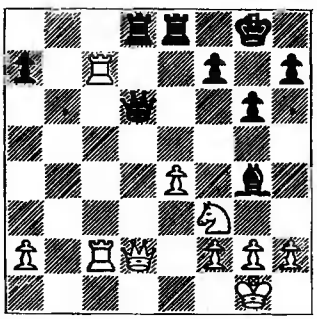
9



Wickmann–Jovčić
postal game, 1955

White's back-rank is clearly weak, but how can Black exploit it? The answer lies in an attractive line-closure theme: **1 ... ♗f4! 2 ♖xf4 ♘xf4 3 ♕xf4 ♕b1+! 4 ♕c1 ♕xc1+ 5 ♗xc1 ♖a8!** the whole point of the combination, since now the bishop must go if White wishes to avoid mate.

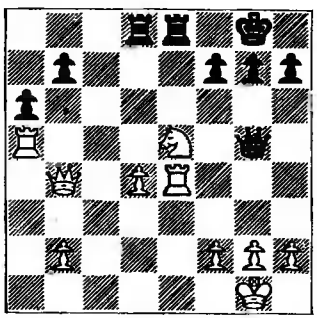
10



Tal–Olafsson
Las Palmas, 1975

By an elegant series of moves Black reveals the hidden weakness of White's back rank: **1 ... ♕f4!! 2 ♖e7!** (the best defence because now 2 ... ♖xd2 3 ♖xe8+ ♔g7 4 ♘xd2 is acceptable to White) **2 ... ♖f8!!** and we have reached a position well worth examining. If now 3 ♕e2 Black wins the rook by 3 ... ♗xf3 4 gf ♕g5+ or here 4 ♕xf3 ♕d6! with the same result. If instead 3 ♕c1 ♗xf3 4 gf ♕xf3 5 ♖d2 ♕g4+ 6 ♔h1 ♕g5! with a fatal double attack. Tal opted for 3 ♕a5 when the game ended after 3 ... ♖d1+ 4 ♘e1 ♕g5! although the beautifully thematic 3 ... ♕g5!! is even more effective, since the queen cannot be captured by the knight or queen without allowing a back-rank mate, and 4 ♖e5 ♕xe5! produces the same situation.

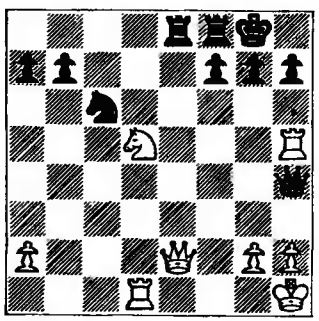
11



Cherepkov–Sazonov
USSR 1968

White's pieces have left the back rank, presumably relying on the ♖e1 retreat, but as is typical in such situations Black can throw a spanner in the works by **1 ... ♖xd4!** If now the rook is captured, 2 ... ♕c1+ mates, so White tried the desperate **2 ♘f3 ♖8xe4!** when he had to admit defeat.

12

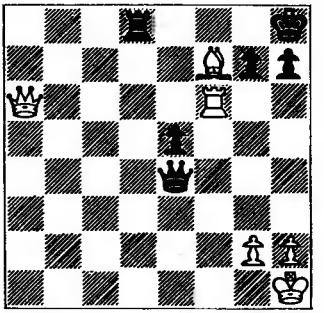


Sampouw–Silalahi
Indonesia, 1971

White appears to stand badly and it is indeed difficult to imagine that he can bring about a back-rank mate in such a position. However, the miracle is achieved as follows: **1 ♕xe8 ♕xh5** (forced) **2 ♘e7+ ♘xe7 3 ♕xf8+! ♔xf8 4 ♖d8** mate.

We have seen how often the deflection theme is linked to the back-rank mate, as for example in diagrams 10 and 11. Here is another clear-cut illustration of this theme.

13

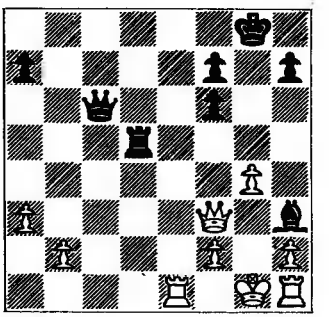


Alden–Lars Nilsson
Swedish League, 1972

Although White is a piece up, his back rank is glaringly weak. Black must simply divert one of White's major pieces from control of the f1 square, which he should have achieved by **1 ... ♕c6!!** with a double attack winning the rook or, if the queen is captured, mating.

Our next example shows an unusual form of deflection combined with a back-rank mate.

14

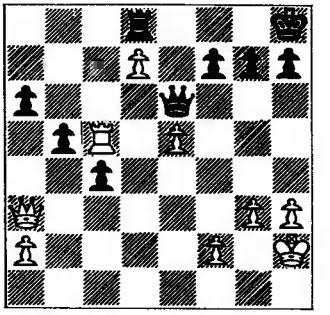


Wexler–Bazan
Mar del Plata, 1960

Once again a single move proves sufficient to force immediate resignation. With **1 ... ♖d1!!** Black leaves three pieces 'en prise' but none of them can be taken without disastrous consequences, as the attentive reader will realize.

Such deflections, usually brought about by a major piece, can lead to interesting situations, as our four following examples show.

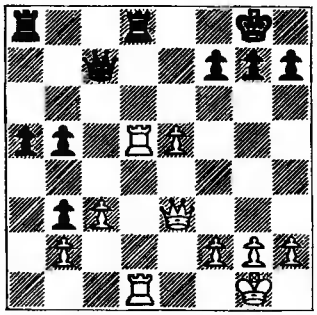
15



Alekhine–Johner
Trinidad, 1939

It seems as if Black has overcome the worst now that he is on the point of capturing the advanced white pawn, but the back-rank weakness again proves fatal after **1 ♖c8! ♖xc8** (or 1 ... ♕xd7 2 ♕f8+!) **2 ♕e7!** a surprising zwischenzug-cum-deflection which wins at once. Both 2 ... ♕xe7 3 dc♕+ mating, and 2 ... ♖g8 3 d8♕ are hopeless for Black.

16

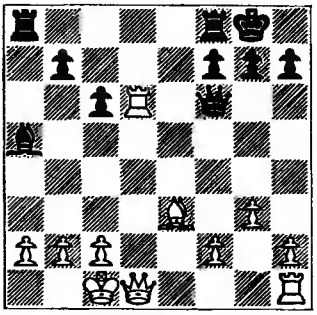


Minić–Honfi
Vrnjačka Banja, 1966

The black queen on c7 and rook on a8 are both protecting the rook on d8, so the move **1 ♕a7!** is startlingly logical, once you have seen it, that is! As the queen cannot be captured either way without allowing mate, Black must try **1 ... ♖dc8** but then **2 ♕xc7 ♖xc7 3 ♖d8+** still mates. (*See Diagram 17*)

White, a pawn up, has just attacked the queen, little suspecting what is

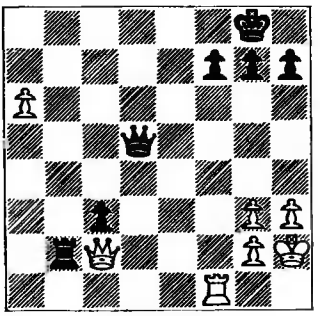
• 17



Chernishev–Ostrovnoi
Stavropol, 1967

about to happen to him. Black, a pawn down, has a brilliant resource which saves the game for him and very nearly wins. Play went: **1 ... ♗d2+!!** The bishop sacrifices itself on a square which is guarded by four white pieces! If now **2 ♖xd2 ♖xa2** the threats of 3 ... ♕xb2 mate and 3 ... ♖a1 mate cannot be parried, whereas both 2 ♔xd2 and 2 ♗xd2 allow 2 ... ♕xd6. The game continued **2 ♕xd2 ♖xa2 3 ♕b4!** (not only maintaining a guard on b2 and his rook but giving the king a flight square whilst keeping the queen under attack. It seems that White is winning again, but . . .) **3 ... ♖fd8! 4 ♔b1** (clearly the queen cannot be captured, in view of 4 ... ♖a1 mate, but also 4 ♖xd8+ ♕xd8 5 ♔b1 ♕a8! wins for Black) **4 ... ♖da8! 5 ♔c1! ♖d8! 6 ♔b1 ♖da8** with a draw by repetition, since neither side can vary with impunity.

18

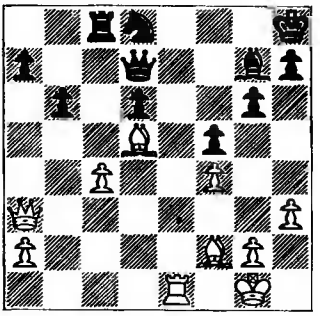


Alapin–N.N.

A highly interesting and complex position has arisen in which White dare not move his queen to, say, a4 without allowing 1 ... ♕xg2 mate, but at the same time Black's back rank is dangerously vulnerable. White's first couple of moves are obviously forced, but then the play becomes subtle and extremely difficult to foresee in advance. Let us follow it carefully: **1 ♖d1! ♕a8!** (1 ... ♖xc2 fails to 2 ♖xd5 ♖d2 3 ♖xd2 cd 4 a7 followed by mate) **2 ♕e4! ♖b8** (clearly the queen cannot be taken, and 2 ... ♕f8 3 ♖a1 ♖b8 4 a7 ♖a8 5 ♕c6 would be hopeless for Black, whilst 2 ... ♕c8 3 ♕c6! wins even more quickly for White. After the text-move it appears that Black is safe, but Alapin comes up with a clever idea) **3 ♖b1!** (threatening 4 ♖xb8+ ♕xb8 5 a7! but also in this line 5 ♕b7! thus giving Black no time to create a loophole for his king. If now 3 ... ♖f8 the threat of back-rank mate again wins for White after 4 ♕xa8 ♖xa8 5 a7!) **3 ... c2 4 ♖xb8+ ♕xb8 5 a7! ♕c8 6 a8♕ c1♕ 7 ♕e8+! Resigns.**

In our examples so far, the defending king has been hemmed in by his own pawns, but of course the attacker's own pawns or pieces can co-operate to form the mating net, as we saw in diagram 14 where the black bishop on h3 was a vital part of the attacking set-up. Here are two further illustrations.

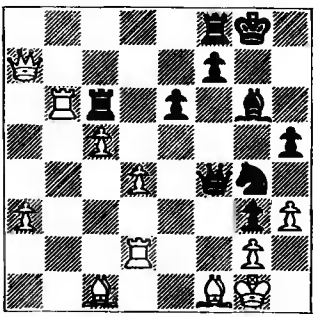
19



Composed position

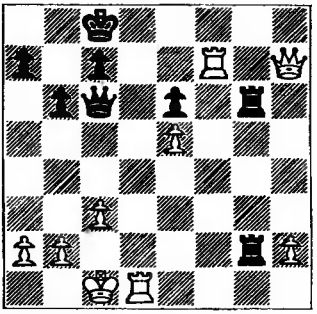
1 ♕xa7! ♕xa7 (a piece had to be given up by 1 ... ♘b7) **2 ♖e8+ ♗f8 3 ♗d4+ ♕g7 4 ♖xf8 mate.**

20



Composed position

23

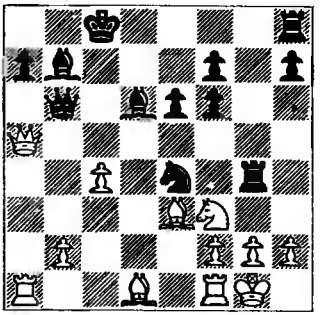


Korchnoi-Chekhover
Leningrad, 1951

Our next example presents an unusual situation in which both sides are trying to exploit a rook positioned on the seventh rank. However, the placing of the white queen proves the decisive factor. Black to move sacrifices a rook by 1 ... ♖xb2?! hoping to mate White after 2 ♔xb2 ♖g2+ 3 ♔b3 ♕b5+ 4 ♔a3 ♕a5+ 5 ♔b3 ♕xa2+ followed by mate in two moves, a typical use of the seventh rank. Unfortunately for Black, however, Korchnoi has planned a surprising refutation with 2 ♖d8+! ♔b7 (Black loses all his pieces after 2 ... ♔xd8 3 ♖f8+) 3 ♖xc7+! ♕xc7 4 ♖d7 and the pin of the queen gives Black no time to save his rook on b2.

The 'battery' of rook on the seventh plus bishop(s) can be extremely effective in an attack on the king, especially when discovered checks are involved. Here are three examples of such attacks.

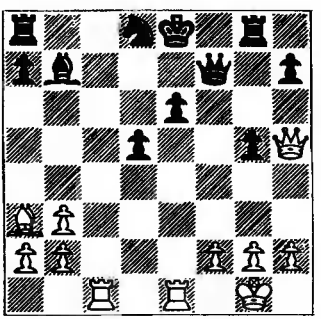
24



Boleslavsky-Ufimtsev
Omsk, 1944

1 ... ♖hg8!! 2 ♘e1 (or 2 ♗xb6 ♖xg2+ 3 ♔h1 ♖xh2+! 4 ♘xh2 ♘xf2 mate) 2 ... ♖xg2+! 3 ♘xg2 ♘d2! (threatening the famous 'staircase' manoeuvre of 4 ... ♖xg2+ 5 ♔h1 ♖xh2+ 6 ♔g1 ♖h1 mate, so again giving White no time to capture the queen, and in fact compelling him to give up his own queen) 4 ♕d5 ♗xd5 5 cd ♕xb2 winning.

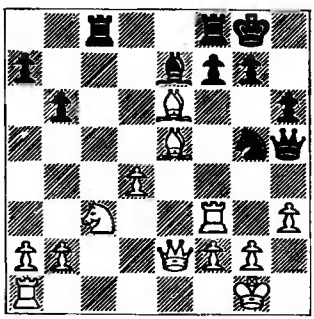
25



Antuanz-Hübner
Munich, 1969

By bringing about a rook + bishop battery, White wins 'only' a pawn, but this is enough in the subsequent ending: 1 ♖c7! ♕xh5 2 ♖e7+ ♔f8 3 ♖xb7+ ♔e8 4 ♖e7+ ♔f8 5 ♖xh7+! (note that White would ruin everything by playing 5 ♖xa7+ ♔e8 6 ♖e7+ ♔f8 7 ♖xh7+? ♖xa3! etc.) 5 ... ♔e8 6 ♖xh5 and White won.

26



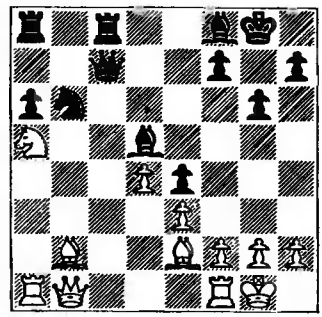
Malich–Litkiewicz
E. Germany, 1967

White wins a piece by 1 ♖xf7! ♕xe2 2 ♖xg7+ ♔h8 3 ♖xe7+ ♕xe5 4 de and Black resigned a few moves later.

Often, the attacker utilises both the seventh and back ranks in his combination, as in the following powerful finishes. (*See Diagram 27*)

1 ... ♕c2! 2 ♗a3 ♗xa3 3 ♖xa3 ♕xe2 4 ♕xb6 ♖ab8 (Botvinnik has cunningly lured two of White's major pieces away from the back rank and now brings his ♕ rook into the game in readiness for the

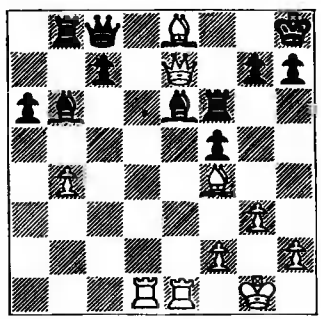
27



Goglidze–Botvinnik
Moscow, 1935

final combination) 5 ♕d6 ♕xf1+! 6 ♔xf1 ♖b1+ 7 ♔e2 ♖c2 mate.

28

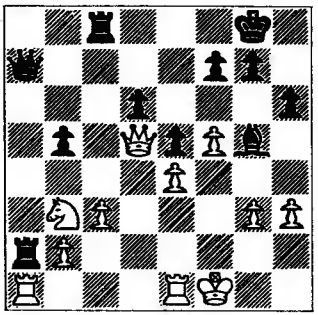


Katalimov–Mnatsakanian
USSR 1959

Here the use of the back two ranks along with three subtle deflections makes this combination particularly instructive: 1 ♖d7! is the first deflection idea, removing the black bishop from the a2–g8 diagonal, so that it cannot later interpose to prevent a back-rank mate. (If Black refuses to capture the rook by playing 1 ... ♖g6!? White has 2 ♕f8+ ♗g8 3 ♗e5 winning.)

After 1 ... ♗xd7 comes the second, even more brilliant, double deflection 2 ♗h6!! If the rook captures, White has 3 ♕f8 mate, so in the game the continuation was 2 ... gf which allowed 3 ♕xf6+ ♔g8 4 ♕f7+ (note how both the defenders of this square have been diverted or removed!) 4 ... ♔h8 5 ♕f8 mate.

29

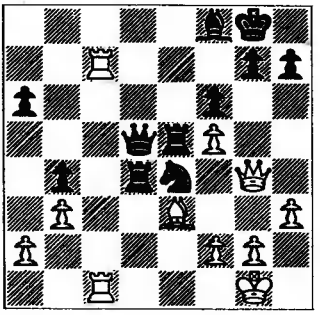


Unzicker–Fischer
Olympiad, 1962

Black exploits the horizontal and vertical actions of his rooks beautifully by a move which forces immediate resignation, 1 ... ♖xc3! Clearly 2 bc allows 2 ... ♕f2 mate, whereas after 2 ♖xa2 ♖f3+ 3 ♔e2 ♖f2+ 4 ♔d3 ♕xa2 5 ♖a1 ♕xb2 6 ♖a8+ ♔h7, mate cannot be prevented. (*See Diagram 30*)

The black bishop is overworked trying to protect the back two ranks, a fact that Bronstein exploits in powerful fashion as follows: 1 ♗xd4 ♕xd4 2 ♖xg7+! ♗xg7 3 ♖c8+ ♔f7 4 ♕h5+ ♔e7 5 ♕e8+ ♔d6 6 ♖c6+ ♔d5 7 ♕d7+

30

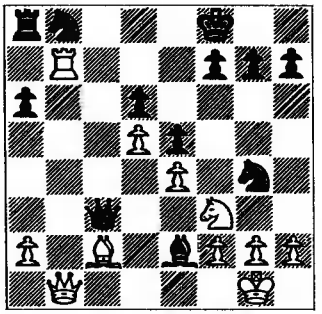


Bronstein–Gligorić
Moscow, 1967

Resigns. Black loses at least his queen.

Our next position occurred at the end of a complicated attack by Keres in which his opponent had failed to foresee White's next move.

31

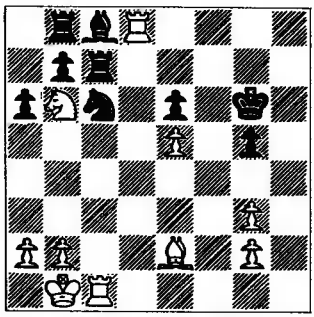


Keres–Raud
Parnu, 1937

1 ♕b6! ♘c6 (mate was threatened on d8, but other defences are insufficient too e.g. 1 ... g6 2 ♕d8+ ♔g7 3 ♖xf7+! ♔xf7 4 ♘g5+ ♔g7 5 ♘e6+ followed by mate; or 1 ... ♕c8 2 ♖c7! ♕e8 3 ♕b7 wins)

2 ♕c7! ♘h6 3 ♕xd6+ ♔g8 4 dc ♔h8 (again he must prevent mate, so cannot pick up the loose bishop) 5 ♖b8+ ♖xb8 6 ♕xb8+ ♘g8 7 c7 ♗b5 8 ♕d8! ♕xc2 9 ♔h1 (an amusing 'echo' of Black's 4th move, but of course 9 h3 would also win) 9 ... f6 10 c8♕ ♕b1+ 11 ♘g1 ♕xa2 12 ♕f8 Resigns.

32

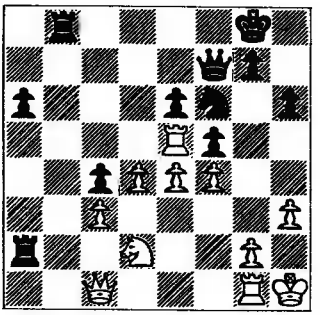


Keres–Panno
Göteborg, 1955

Once again we see Keres at work creating an original mating net at the end of one of a trio of famous games played in the USSR v Argentina match. Black's pieces are all completely tied up on the ♕ side, giving White time to plan an attractive finish as follows: **1 ♗d3+ ♔f7** (1 ... ♔h5 allows 2 ♖c4! threatening mate on h8) **2 ♖h8 ♔e7** (or 2 ... ♔g7 3 ♖h7+) **3 ♗g6! Resigns.** To stop mate he must lose material.

Finally in this section, here is a position in which queen and knight lend excellent support to the two rooks doubled on the seventh rank.

33



Larsen–Najdorf
Olympiad, 1968

1 ... ♖8b2! 2 ♘xc4 ♖c2 3 ♕e3 ♘xe4 4 d5 ed 5 ♘b6 ♖xc3 6 ♕d4 ♕h5! (Black has visualised the final mating position) **7 ♕xd5+ ♔h7 8 ♕xa2 ♖xh3+ 9 gh ♕xh3+ 10 ♕h2 ♘f2 mate.**

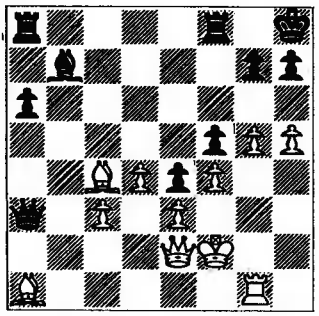
Diagonal combinations

It is clear that such combinations will involve the long-ranging diagonal power of the queen and bishops, but of course these can be supported by other pieces and pawns. When we are attacking the king, it often happens that a certain diagonal assumes a particular importance, so it would appear useful to examine in turn the types of combination which exploit the three main attacking diagonals *a1–h8*, *b1–h7* and *a2–g8*, or any two of these together. It is important to note that, when we refer to these diagonals, we are for convenience looking at them from White's side of the board in an attack against Black's ♔ side, but

of course the concept applies to the h1–a8, g1–a7 and h2–b8 diagonals when White is attacking the ♕ side, and the whole situation is reversed when it is Black who is attacking.

The long dark-squared *a1–h8 diagonal* is very often used to launch an attack against the vulnerable g7 square, the most basic form of which is carried out by the queen supported by the bishop on b2. Such a bishop on an open diagonal can prove a dangerous attacking weapon, especially when Black has no counter to this pressure. Consider the following example:

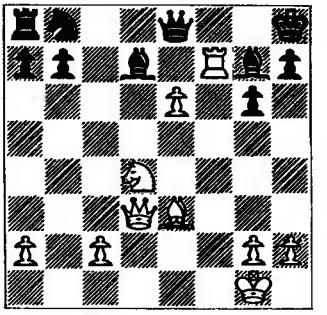
34



Mecking–Souza Mendes
Rio Hondo, 1966

There is obviously no doubt about the strategic necessity for White to advance his c and d pawns and thus open up the long diagonal for his bishop on a1, so all White's efforts are directed towards this aim. **1 h6! g6** (1 ... gh would allow 2 g6! hg 3 ♖xg6 ♔h7 4 ♕h5 and it is all over) **2 ♗e6 ♗c8 3 d5! ♗xe6 4 ♕d2!!** (Black had only taken account of the obvious 4 dxe6 ♖fd8 with counterplay for him down the d file. The game is already decided strategically, so the following play needs little comment) **4 ... ♖f7 5 ♕d4+ ♔g8 6 c4! ♔f8 7 de ♖fa7 8 ♕h8+ ♔e7 9 ♕g7+ ♔xe6 10 ♕f6+ ♔d7 11 ♖d1+ ♔c7 12 ♗e5+ Resigns.** It is mate in two moves.

35



Belyavsky–Kupreichik
Kiev, 1973

White has already sacrificed a piece to reach this position and is prepared to give up another in order to expose the black king to a diagonal attack. Play went: **1 ♘f5!! gf** (or 1 ... ♕xe6 2 ♖xg7 ♕xf5 3 ♗d4! with the deadly battery we have already seen in action) **2 ♗d4! ♕xe6** (if 2 ... ♕xf7 then 3 ef ♘c6 4 ♗xg7+ ♔xg7 5 ♕xd7 wins) **3 ♖f8+ ♕g8 4 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 5 ♕g3 ♔f7 6 ♕xg7+ Resigns.**

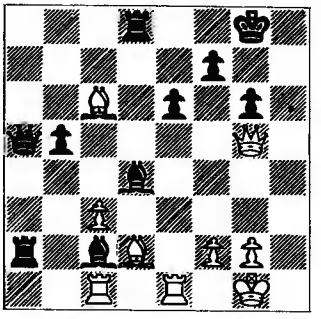
Black is clearly better and has various ways of winning, but the method he uses is both elegant and instructive: 1 ... ♗d3! 2 ♗xd3 (if 2 ♖xd3 then 2 ... ♕f2+ and mate next move) 2 ... ♕e3+! and White is mated after both 3 ♔f1 ♘h2 and 3 ♔h1 ♕e1.

1 ... ♗xf2+ 2 ♔xf2 ♖xd2+ 3 ♔g1 (if 3 ♕xd2 ♗e4 wins for Black) 3 ... ♕xc3 4 ♕xb5 ♕d4+ 5 ♔h1 ♕h4+ 6 ♔g1 ♗e4! (the decisive move, opening up the power of both rooks combined and launching an unstoppable attack against g2) 7 ♕b8+ ♔h7 8 ♗xe4 ♖xg2+! 9 ♗xg2 ♕f2+ 10 ♔h2 ♕xg2 mate.

Seventh rank combinations

This rank has a particular significance strategically and tactically, because the major pieces can often exert great pressure from the flank on enemy pawns and pieces whilst restricting the activity of the king by fixing him to the back rank. When two rooks combine their pressure along this rank, they can prove extremely dangerous, but even one rook supported by other pieces is a force to be reckoned with. An example will make this clear:

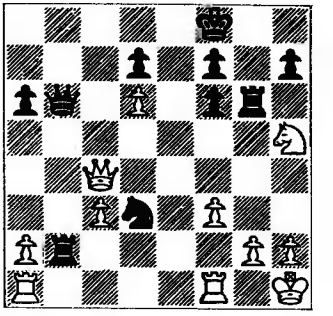
21



Larsen–Korchnoi
Palma de Mallorca, 1968

The well-known mate with two rooks on the seventh rank is brought about neatly in the following position.

22

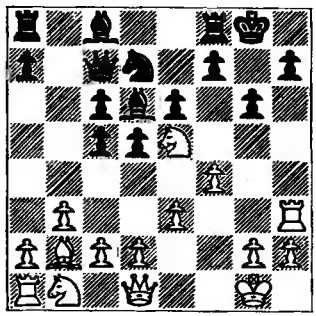


Ilyustchenko–Shushina
USSR 1971

As White is threatening mate in two moves, time is of the essence here, so Black finds a clever way of gaining a vital tempo as follows: 1 ... ♕g1+!! 2 ♔xg1 (2 ♖xg1 ♘f2 mate) 2 ... ♖6xg2+ 3 ♔h1 ♖xh2+ 4 ♔g1 ♖bg2 mate.

When the long diagonal is fully open, as our next group of examples show, many beautiful mating situations arise, with other pieces naturally taking part. Look at the following position:

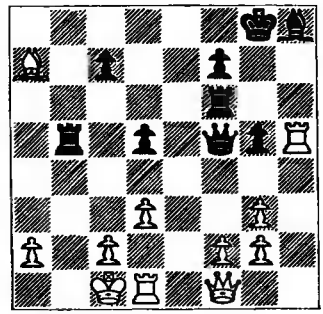
36



Plachetka–Zinn
Dečin, 1974

Perhaps Black was now hoping for the routine 1 ♘g4? threatening 2 ♘h6 mate, to which he could reply 1 ... f6 or 1 ... e5 with good play. However, the startling move 1 ♕h5!! brought about his immediate resignation. Let us consider a few possibilities. White is threatening 2 ♕xh7 mate, so Black has only two defensive tries. If 1 ... gh 2 ♖g3+ ♔h8 3 ♘xf7 mate is conclusive enough, but 1 ... ♘f6 2 ♘g4!! is the real point of the combination. Since now 2 ... ♘xh5 allows 3 ♘h6 mate, Black is forced to play 2 ... gh 3 ♘xf6+ when he has the dubious choice between being mated after 3 ... ♔g7 4 ♘e8+ ♔h6 5 ♗g7+ ♔g6 6 ♖g3+ ♔f5 7 ♖g5+ ♔e4 8 ♘c3, or simply losing material after 3 ... ♔h8 4 ♖xh5 h6 5 ♘xd5+ etc.

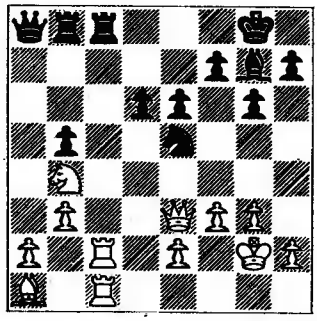
37



Vlk–Duras
Prague, 1899

Black wants to open up the long diagonal for his bishop, whilst at the same time preventing the simplification of the position by 2 ♖xh8+! followed by 3 ♗d4. He succeeds in combining defence and attack in an ingenious sequence of moves in which two gains of time play a decisive role. Play proceeded: 1 ... ♕g4! 2 ♕h1 ♖b1+! 3 ♔xb1 (or 3 ♔d2 ♖xf2+! 4 ♗xf2 ♗c3+! 5 ♔xc3 ♕b4 mate, or here 5 ♔e3 d4 mate) 3 ... ♖b6+! (the point, opening the long diagonal and planning 4 ♗xb6 ♕b4+ 5 ♔c1 ♗b2+ 6 ♔b1 ♗c3+ followed by mate) 4 ♔c1 ♗b2+ 5 ♔b1 ♗c3+ 6 ♔c1 ♖b1+! 7 ♔xb1 ♕b4+ 8 ♔c1 ♕b2 mate.

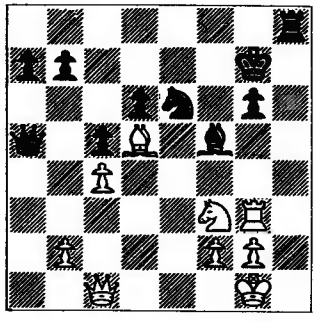
38



Panno–Malich
Munich, 1958

White cleverly uses a zwischenzug to achieve full control of the vital diagonal by **1 ♗xe5! ♖xc2** (Black would like to recapture if it only means losing a pawn, but after 1 ... de 2 ♘c6! he loses the exchange because of the ♘e7+ possibility) **2 ♗xg7! ♖xc1 3 ♗f6 ♔f8** (the threat of 4 ♕h6 forces Black to give back the rook) **4 ♕xc1 ♔e8 5 ♕c7 Resigns.**

39

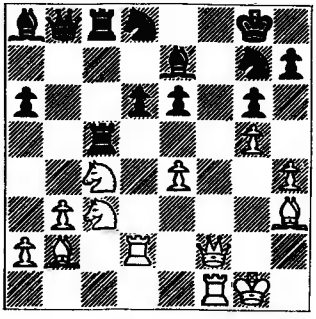


Uhlmann–Ujtumen
Palma de Mallorca, 1970

By **1 b4!!** White guarantees his queen decisive occupation of the long diagonal. If now **1 ... ♕xb4 2 ♗xe6 ♗xe6** (in the game, Black gave up a piece with 2 ... ♕b1) **3 ♕a1+ ♔h7 4 ♘g5+** wins easily.

In our next example, the whole struggle centres around White's attempts to open the long diagonal and Black's failure to prevent this.

40

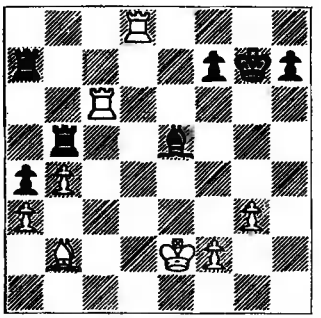


Korchnoi–Garcia
Moscow, 1975

1 ♘d5! ♗xd5 (Black naturally declines the suicidal 1 ... ed 2 ♕d4! ♗f8 3 ♖xf8+ ♔xf8 4 ♕g7+ ♔e8 5 ♗d7 mate) **2 ed e5 3 ♗xc8 ♕xc8 4 ♘xe5! ♘f5** (or 4 ... dxe5 5 d6!) **5 ♘g4 ♘f7 6 ♕e2 ♘xh4 7 ♕xe7 ♕xg4+ 8 ♔h2 Resigns.**

Although the following position is greatly simplified, it nevertheless still represents a striking example of the power of the bishop and is almost a study in its geometric manoeuvring.

41

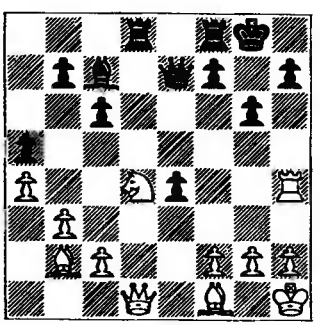


Panno–Bolbochan
Argentina, 1971

1 ♖b8! ♖d5 (the only defence of the bishop) **2 ♖d6! ♗xb2** (Black has no choice, since 2 ... ♖xd6 loses to 3 ♗xe5+ ♖f6 4 ♖b6) **3 ♖xd5 ♗xa3 4 ♖a5 Resigns.**

We have already seen (diagram 36) how effective the knight can be when used in conjunction with the bishop in a mating attack. Here is another impressive illustration of this theme.

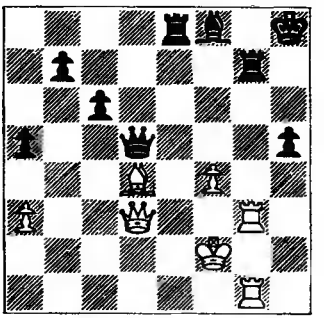
42



Vukovich–N.N.
composed?

White first threatens to mate after **1 ♘f5!** either on h6 or e7, but the reply **1 ... ♕xh4** appears to refute this idea, until we see the extraordinary tactical coup **2 ♕h5!!** to which there is clearly no defence.

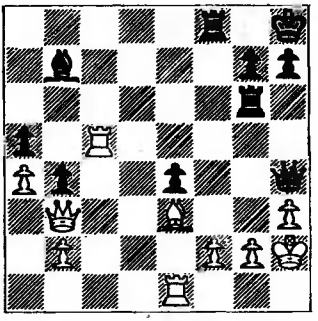
43



Miszto–Kloza
Poland, 1955

We are back with the deadly bishop + rook battery. Black has based his defensive hopes on **1 ... ♗c5** pinning White's dangerous bishop and apparently solving all his problems. However, White can provide himself with the vital tempo required to force mate, by sacrificing his queen as follows: **2 ♕h7+!! ♔xh7 3 ♖xg7+ ♔h8 4 ♖g8+ ♔h7 5 ♖1g7+ ♔h6 6 ♖g6+ ♔h7 7 ♖8g7+ ♔h8 8 ♖h6** mate.

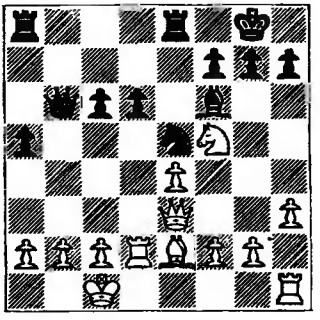
44



Schmid–Rossolimo
Heidelberg, 1949

In his hey-day, Rossolimo produced some highly artistic combinations, and this one is no exception. White appears to have successfully blockaded the e pan, thus excluding the black bishop from the attack. However, appearances can be deceptive, as Black now demonstrates: 1 ... ♖xg2+! 2 ♔xg2 ♖xf2+! 3 ♗xf2 e3+ and White resigned in view of the possible continuation 4 ♖d5 ♕xf2+ 5 ♔h1 ♕xe1+ 6 ♔h2 ♗xd5 7 ♕xd5 ♕d2+ etc., or, if you are sadistically inclined here, 6 ... ♕f2+ 7 ♔h1 e2 and 8 ... e1♕+ mating.

45

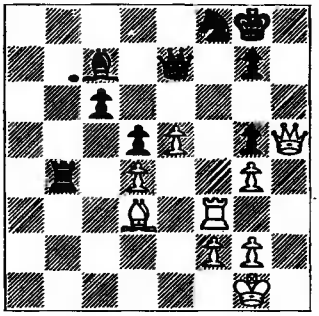


Polies–Krementsky
USSR 1973

King hunts are always intriguing, not to say amusing, spectacles and are normally reasonably easy to calculate, especially when no 'quiet' moves are involved. In this position, Black has to visualise three or four distinct mating set-ups, with the main line being the longest sequence to work out following the queen sacrifice. 1 ... ♕xb2+!! 2 ♔xb2 ♘d3+ 3 ♔a3 (3 ♔b3 ♖eb8+ 4 ♔c4 ♘b2 mate; or here 4 ♔a4 ♖b4+ 5 ♔a3 ♗b2 mate) 3 ... ♗b2+ 4 ♔a4 ♖e4+! (the key move, since now 5 ♕xe4 allows 5 ... ♘c5 mate) 5 c4 ♖xc4+ 6 ♔b3 ♖c3+ 7 ♔a4 ♖a3 mate.

The *b1–h7 diagonal* is equally important in a ♔ side attack and once again it is the queen supported by the bishop which puts pressure on the h7 square. Here is a typical example:

46

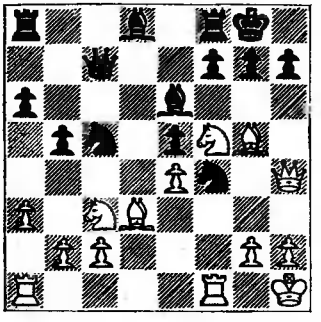


Geller–Novotelnov
Moscow, 1951

Since the knight is guarding the h7 square, we first remove it by an exchange sacrifice, then follow this

up with a decoy sacrifice leading to mate; 1 ♖xf8+! ♔xf8 (1 ... ♕xf8 would allow the usual 2 ♗h7+ ♔h8 3 ♗g6+ and 4 ♕h7 mate) 2 ♕h8+ ♔f7 3 ♗g6+! ♔xg6 (or 3 ... ♔e6 4 ♕c8+ ♕d7 5 ♗f5+ etc.) 4 ♕h5 mate.

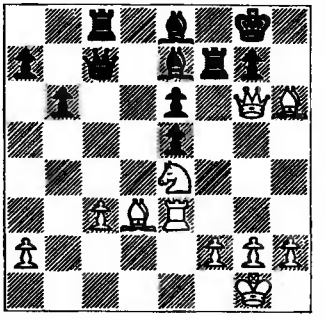
47



Ravinsky–Ilivitsky
Riga, 1952

Occasionally, the diagonal may seem impossible to open, as in our next position, but White manages to achieve it by means of a subtle sequence of moves. Play went: 1 ♘xg7! ♔xg7 2 ♖xf4! ef (White has thus cleared a path for the advance of the e pawn, profiting from the fact that 2 ... ♘xd3 loses to 3 ♕h6+ ♔g8 4 ♘d5! ♗xd5 5 ♗f6! ♗xf6 6 ♖g4+ followed by mate) 3 ♕h6+ ♔g8 4 ♗f6! ♗xf6 5 e5! ♘xd3 6 ef and mate is forced after the 'spite' checks 6 ... ♘f2+ 7 ♔g1 ♘h3+ 8 ♔f1 ♗c4+ 9 ♘e2 ♗xe2+ 10 ♔e1!

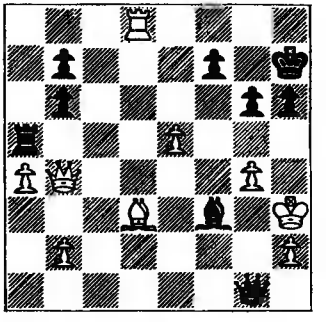
48



Engels
Consultation game, 1943

Yet again a queen sacrifice gives White time to produce a series of checks leading to a forced mate. 1 ♕h7+!! ♔xh7 2 ♘f6+ ♔h8 (or 2 ... ♔xh6 3 ♖h3+ ♔g5 4 ♖g3+ ♔h6 5 ♖g6 mate; or here 4 ... ♔f4 5 ♘h5 mate) 3 ♗xg7+! ♔xg7 (3 ... ♖xg7 allows mate in three) 4 ♖g3+ ♔xf6 (or 4 ... ♔h6 5 ♖g6 mate; or 4 ... ♔f8 5 ♖g8 mate) 5 ♖g6 mate. A 'pure' one, following the sacrifice of queen, bishop and knight in rapid succession.

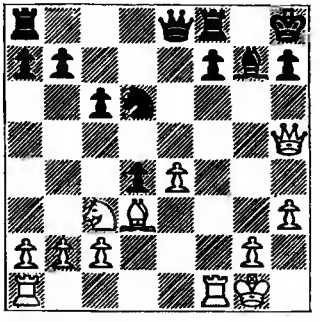
49



Forintos–Tomović
Budapest v. Belgrade, 1957

White's king is about to be mated, but he manages to open up the b1–h7 diagonal and produce an attractive mating position, all with gain of tempo, as follows: 1 ♖h8+! ♔xh8 2 ♕f8+ ♔h7 3 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 4 ♕f8+ ♔h7 5 ♗xg6+! ♔xg6 6 ♕g8 mate.

50

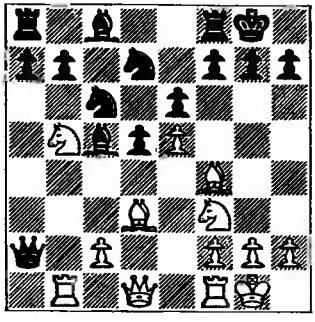


Fischer–Benko
US Championship, 1963/4

The obvious 1 e5 would be refuted by 1 ... f5! so Fischer produced the following problem-like finish: 1 ♖f6!! ♔g8 (both 1 ... ♗xf6 and 1 ... dc are answered by 2 e5 winning at once) 2 e5 h6 3 ♘e2! not even giving Black the chance of 3 ♖xd6 ♕xe5! Since now 3 ... ♘b5 4 ♕f5 and 3 ... ♗xf6 4 ♕xh6 are hopeless, Black resigned.

To close this action, here are two examples of the most common sacrifice on the b1–h7 diagonal, Bxh7+, which is usually possible when the attacker has extra pieces at his disposal and the defender has neither ... ♘f6 nor ... ♘f8 available to defend the h7 square. Our two illustrations come from opening theory.

51

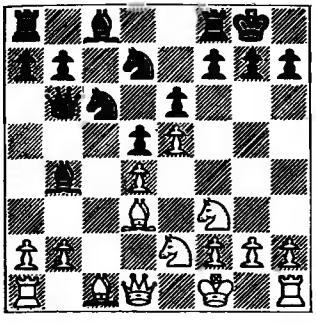


Opening analysis

At the moment most of Black's pieces, and in particular his queen, are hardly in a position to defend the ♔ side, so it is not surprising that White's attack is easy to carry out. Play goes: 1 ♗xh7+! ♔xh7 2 ♘g5+ ♔g6 (the alternative 2 ... ♔g8 allows 3 ♕h5 ♖d8 4 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 5 ♕h5+ followed by mate in four moves) 3 ♕d3+ f5 4 ♕g3 (a typical continuation, threatening 5 ♘xe6#) 4 ... ♖g8 5 ♘e4+! ♔f7 6 ♘ed6+ ♗xd6 7 ♘xd6+ ♔e7 8 ♕g5+ ♔f8 9 ♕g6 winning. (*See Diagram 52*)

In this position, after the sacrifice Black retreats his king because White's queen cannot reach h5 with an immediate win. However, White still finds a way of exploiting his advantage on the ♔ side as follows: 1 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 2 ♘g5+ ♔g8 3 ♕d3 ♖e8 (or 3 ... f5 4 ♕h3 ♖e8 5 ♕h5! wins) 4 ♕h7+ ♔f8 5 ♕h8+ ♔e7

52

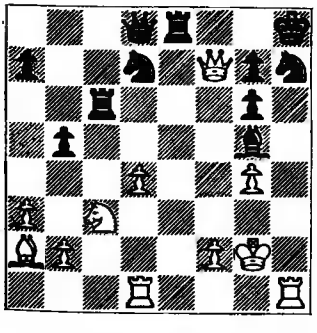


Opening analysis

6 ♕xg7 ♔d8 7 ♕xf7 ♘f8 8 h4! and this powerful pawn supported by the rook and queen proves decisive.

The *a2–g8 diagonal* is of vital importance in many attacks on the king. Often in the very opening stages the 'Achilles heel' of the black position, the f7 square, is the scene of a minor piece sacrifice, or else greatly restricted in its movements by the presence of White's ♔ bishop along this diagonal. We begin with an example of the latter.

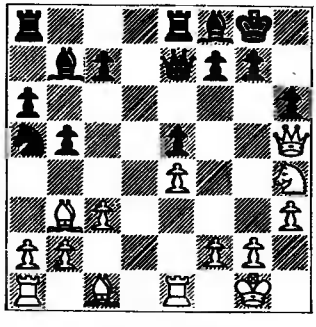
53



Lochmer–Kärner
1940

The white bishop lurking on a2 controls the important f7 and g8 squares, allowing the following decisive combination: 1 ♖xh7+! ♔xh7 2 ♖h1+ ♗h6 3 ♖xh6+! ♔xh6 4 ♕f4+! (the key move which White had to visualize in advance. If now 4 ... ♔h7 White has 5 ♕h2+ followed by mate) 4 ... g5 5 ♕h2+ ♔g6 6 ♕h5+ ♔f6 7 ♕f7 mate. Profitable co-operation between queen and bishop.

54

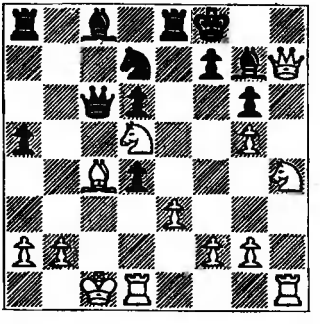


Geller–Portisch
Moscow, 1967

The white bishop on b3 is under attack, but before it can be driven away White cleverly exploits the weakness of f7 and the fact that the black f pawn is pinned, allowing use of the g6 square. He begins with the surprise move **1 ♗g5!!** which is possible because Black cannot play either 1 ... ♕xg5 2 ♕xf7+ ♔h7 3 ♕g8 mate, or 1 ... hg 2 ♘g6! with mate to follow on h8. This means that the queen is forced to move to the d file, thus allowing White to lure the bishop on f8 away from the defence of the h6 square

and defence of his king. The following finish is now readily understandable: 1 ... ♕d7 2 ♖ad1 ♗d6 3 ♗xh6! gh (or 3 ... ♘xb3 4 ♗xg7! ♔xg7 5 ♘f5+ winning) 4 ♕g6+ ♔f8 5 ♕f6! (threatening 6 ♘g6+ ♔g8 7 ♕h8 mate) 5 ... ♔g8 6 ♖e3 Resigns.

55

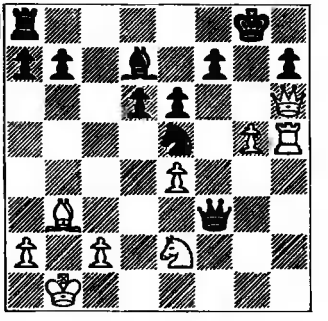


Jerostrom–Bergman
Ljusdal, 1950

The white bishop is under attack and pinned, yet White finds a clever way of bringing it into action by means of two sacrifices as follows: 1 ♘xg6+! gf 2 ♕g8+!! ♔xg8 3 ♘e7+ ♔f8 4 ♘xg6 mate.

We next see the present World Champion at work, exploiting a bishop on b3 which is only apparently ineffectual.

56



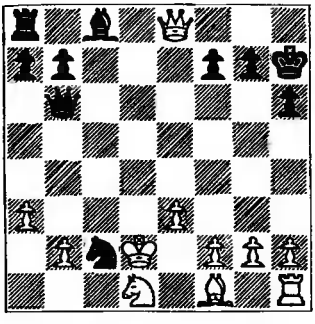
Karpov–Gik
Moscow University Ch, 1968

If White immediately plays to win the black rook, his own rook can then be captured. This partly explains the first surprising move 1 g6! since if now 1 ... fg 2 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 3 ♕h8+ ♔e7 4 ♖h7+ ♘f7 White can play 5 ♕xa8 because his own rook is safe. As 1 ... hxg6 allows 2 ♕h8 mate, Black must play 1 ... ♘xg6, but after 2 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 3 ♖f5! we see the point of the whole combination. 3 ... exf5 would reveal the power of White's bishop (4 ♕xf7 mate) so Black gave up his queen by 3 ... ♕xb3+ 4 ab ef only to lose quickly after 5 ♘f4 ♖d8 . 6 ♕h6+ ♔e8 7 ♘xg6 fg 8 ♕xg6+ etc.

When *two* of these diagonals are used in the mating attack, the enemy king finds itself under tremendous pressure. Let us look at attacks along the *b1–h7 and a1–h8*

diagonals (g1–a7 and h1–a8 for ♕ side play) whether utilised by Black or White.

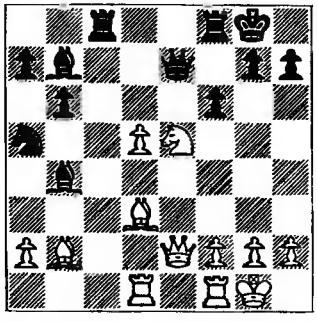
57



Vaganian–Planinc
Hastings, 1974/5

After a beautifully timed attack against the white king, Black now produces the final combination beginning with a typical rook sacrifice to divert the enemy queen whilst guarding his knight and preventing ♗d3+. Play continued: 1 ... ♗f5! 2 ♕xa8 ♕d6+ 3 ♔c1 (after 3 ♔c3 which is a better defence, Black has 3 ... ♕xd1 4 ♗c4! ♘e1! 5 ♖xe1! ♕xe1+ with a winning end-game. Presumably, Vaganian missed Black's next crushing move) 3 ... ♘a1!! 4 ♕xb7 (against 4 b4 Kotov gives 4 ... ♕c6+ 5 ♔b2 ♕c2+ 6 ♔xa1 ♕b1 mate, but White has the better 5 ♔d2 here, so 4 ... ♘b3+! 5 ♔b2 ♕d2+ 6 ♔xb3 ♕c2 mate is the correct sequence. Translator's note) 4 ... ♕c7+! and White resigned instead of allowing 5 ♕xc7 ♘b3 mate.

58

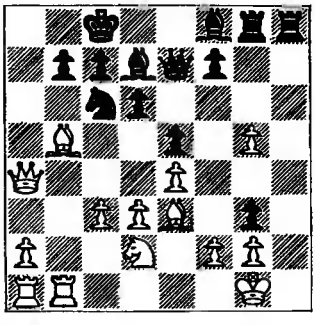


Keres–Geller
Moscow, 1962

1 ♕h5! g6 (forced, but now White can expose the black king to a tremendous attack) 2 ♘xg6! hg 3 ♗xg6 ♕g7 4 ♖d3 (the key to the combination) 4 ... ♗d6 5 f4! ♕h8 6 ♕g4 ♗c5+ 7 ♔h1 ♖c7 8 ♗h7+! (an extraordinarily powerful move which begins the final king hunt) 8 ... ♔f7 9 ♕e6+ ♔g7 10 ♖g3+ Resigns.

Now for an attack on the ♕ side.

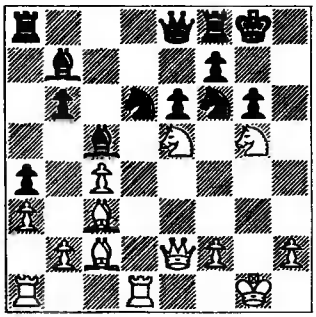
59



Gereben–Troianescu
Sopot, 1951

1 ♕a8+ ♘b8 2 ♕xb7+!! ♔xb7 3 ♗xd7+ ♔a8 4 ♖xb8+! ♔xb8 5 ♖b1+ ♔a8 6 ♗c6 mate.

60

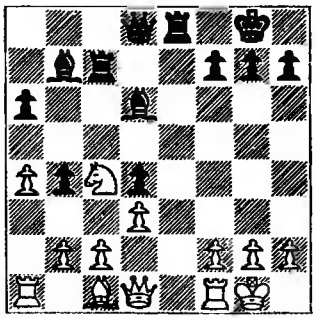


Hecht–Keene
Clare Benedict Teams, Brunnen 1966

The basis of this combination is the fact that, without the white knight on e5 and the black knight on f6, White would win immediately by 1 ♕h5!! gh 2 ♗h7 mate, where the two bishops on the long diagonals really come into their own. If the reader keeps this point in mind, the game continuation needs no further explanation: 1 ♘d7! ♕xd7 2 ♗xf6 ♕c6 3 ♖d5! ed 4 ♕h5! ♗xf2+ 5 ♔xf2 ♘e4+ 6 ♘xe4 gh 7 ♖g1+ ♔h7 8 ♘c5+ Resigns.

The famous two bishops sacrifice exploits these two diagonals. Here is one of many examples of such a sacrifice.

61

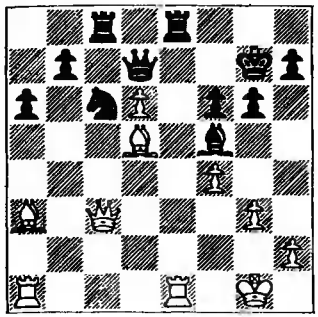


Kirilov–Furman
USSR, 1949

1 ... ♗xh2+! 2 ♔xh2 ♕h4+ 3 ♔g1 ♗xg2! (thus Black has completely demolished the white king's position, but at the cost of his two powerful bishops, so it is essential to have enough material available to finish the job of mating the king. In the present position it is once again a rook that comes into the attack via the third rank) 4 ♔xg2 ♖c6 5 ♗f4 (or 5 ♕f3 ♖g6+ 6 ♕g3 ♖e2! 7 ♕xg6 fg 8 ♗d2 ♖xd2 9 ♘xd2 ♕g5+ with advantage to Black) 5 ... ♕xf4 6 ♖h1 ♖f6! 7 ♖h2 ♖g6+ and White resigned since after 8 ♔h1 ♖e1+! it is mate in two moves.

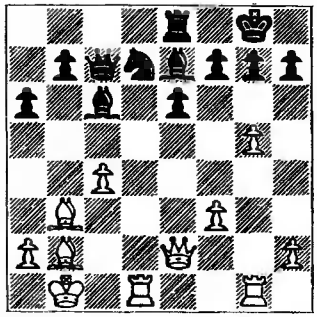
Equally powerful attacks can be launched along the *a2–g8 and a1–h8 diagonals*. Here is a clear-cut example, involving a queen sacrifice.

62



Gadia–Mendes
Sao Paulo, 1967

63



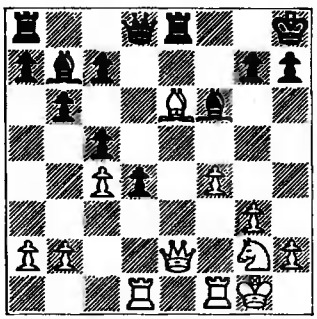
Ostojić–Sofrevski
Skopje, 1969

1 ♕xf6+! ♔xf6 2 ♗b2+ ♘e5 3 ♖xe5 ♗e6 4 ♖xe6+ ♔f5 (4 ... ♔f7 allows 5 ♖e7+! ♔f8 6 ♗g7 mate) **5 ♖f6+ ♔g4 6 ♖f1 ♖e3** (so far it was fairly easy to see that the black king would end up on g4 in a clearly vulnerable position, but White must have relied on his intuition for the next difficult stage of the game in which Black must give up more material to prevent mate.) **7 ♗d4 ♖ce8 8 ♗xe3 ♖xe3 9 ♔f2 ♕g7 10 h3+!! ♔h5** (if 10 ... ♔xh3 White has 11 ♖h1+ and 12 ♖h4 mate) **11 ♔xe3 ♕xf6 12 ♗f3+ ♔h6 13 ♖d1 ♕c3+ 14 ♔f2 ♕c5+ 15 ♔g2 ♕c2+ 16 ♔h1 ♕f5 17 d7 Resigns.** (*See Diagram 63*)

Just before Black can successfully blockade the white c pawn by placing a minor piece on c5 which would then shut out the bishop on b3, White seizes his chance of opening up attacking lines even at the cost of material. Play went: **1 g6!! hg 2 ♖xg6 ♗f6** (our main theme appears after 2 ... fg 3 ♕xe6+ ♔h8 4 ♕h3+ ♔g8 5 c5+ followed by mate, or here 3 ... ♔f8 4 c5 with a forced mate on f7 or g8) **3 ♖xd7! ♗xd7 4 ♖xf6! e5** (or 4 ... gf 5 ♗xf6 with 6 ♕g2+ to follow) **5 ♕g2 ♕c5 6 ♖h6 ♗f5+ 7 ♔a1 ♕b4 8 ♕g1** and White won.

In our next example Keres sacrifices his queen and a pawn for a rook and bishop, but his two powerful bishops are more than sufficient compensation, exerting tremendous pressure aiong the diagonals.

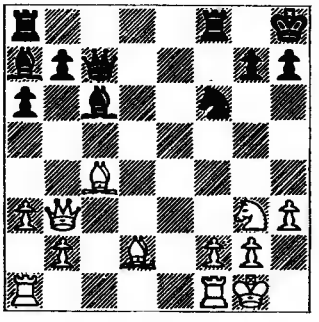
64



Euwe–Keres
Match, 1939

1 ... d3! 2 ♖xd3 ♕xd3! 3 ♕xd3 ♗d4+ 4 ♖f2 ♖xe6 (Keres has no intention of giving up his key bishop for a mere rook) 5 ♔f1 ♖ae8! 6 f5 ♖e5 7 f6 gf 8 ♖d2 ♗c8! (temporarily switching diagonals) 9 ♘f4 ♖e3 10 ♕b1 ♖f3+ 11 ♔g2 ♖xf4! 12 gf ♖g8+ 13 ♔f3 ♗g4+ and White resigned because, if he does not want to lose his queen after 14 ♔g3 ♗f5+, he must accept the mate by 14 ♔e4 ♖e8+ 15 ♔d3 ♗f5 or here 15 ♔d5 ♗f3 mate, a fitting conclusion which illustrates our theme to perfection.

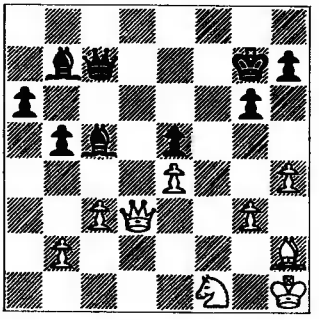
65



Saigin–Vistaneckis
Correspondence, 1969

The black bishop lurking on a7 is pinning the pawn on f2, which means that the knight on g3 is guarded only by the white queen, a factor which explains the coming combination: 1 ... ♘g4! 2 hg ♖f3! 3 ♘f5 (of course, 3 gf ♕xg3+ wins easily) 3 ... ♖xb3 4 ♗xb3 ♕b6 5 Resigns.

66

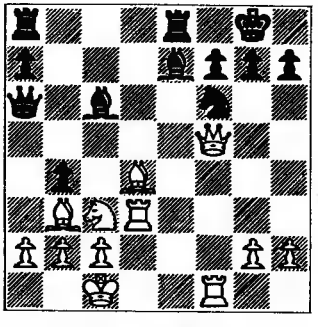


Alexeyev–Razuvayev
Moscow, 1969

Clearly the e4 square is White's Achilles heel, so it is merely a case of deflecting the white queen from the protection of this point: 1 ... ♕d8! 2 ♕f3 ♕d1! 3 ♔g2 ♕c2+ 4 ♔h3 ♗xe4 and White resigned.

Attacks against the Sicilian Defence often involve these two vital diagonals, with beautiful finishes being the order of the day. Our next example is no exception.

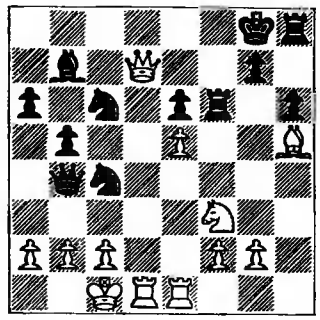
67



Tukmakov–Minkov
USSR, 1969

1 ♖g3! ♗d7 (or 1 ... bc 2 ♗xf6 g6 3 ♖xg6+! forcing a quick mate) 2 ♖xg7+! ♔xg7 3 ♕g5+ ♔f8 4 ♕h6+ ♔g8 5 ♖f3! ♗g4 6 ♕g5+ ♔f8 7 ♕xg4! (the point, since now after 7 ... ♘xg4 White has 8 ♖xf7+ ♔g8 9 ♖g7+ ♔h8 10 ♖g8 mate) 7 ... bc 8 ♕h5! Resigns. The only way to prevent mate is to give up the queen by 8 ... ♕e6 but after 9 ♗xe6 fe 10 ♗xf6 Black's position is hopeless.

68



Goban–Schmidt
Budapest, 1950

1 ♕e8+! ♔h7 2 ♘g5+! hg 3 ♗g6+! ♖xg6 4 ♖h1+ ♖h6 5 ♖xh6+ gh (or 5 ... ♔xh6 6 ♖h1 mate) 6 ♕f7 mate.

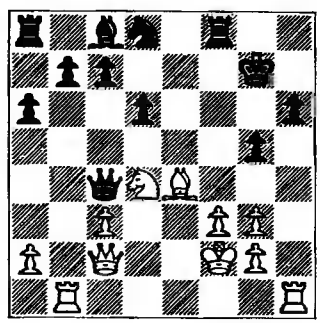
Linear combinations

Open files are the highways along which the major pieces move or down which they exert pressure on the enemy position. The problem is to create such open files in the first place. Let us examine the type of attack which results from the exploitation of the three main attacking files on the kingside, the h, g and f files.

The opening of the *h file* against the enemy king is one of the most common and effective methods of launching a kingside attack, and chess literature abounds in examples of sacrificial combinations linked with opening or exploiting this file. Let us begin with a position in which White needs a forced continuation because Black is threatening to mate him.

In our next example White opens up the file completely by a typical sacrifice of one rook to make way for the other which will then control the important h7 square.

69

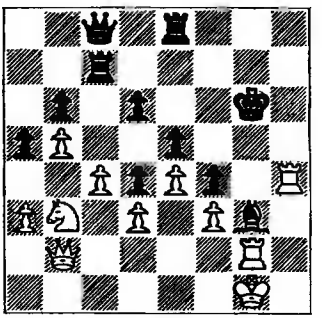


Balashov–Iliashov
USSR, 1974

1 ♖xh6! ♔xh6 2 ♖h1+ ♔g7 3 ♗d5! (another sacrifice clears the way for the decisive entry of the queen) 3 ... ♕xd5 4 ♕h7+ ♔f6 5 ♖h6+ ♔e5 6 ♕g7+ followed by mate next move.

Now let us give Black a chance for a change! In the following position Adorjan sacrifices his queen because he sees that the subsequent command of the h file linked with the tremendous power of the bishop on g3 and the passed f pawn is enough to guarantee him a comfortable win.

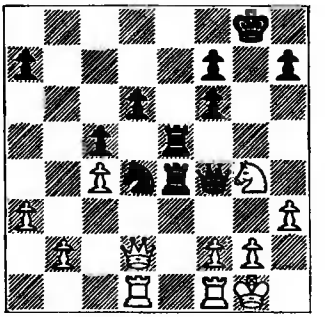
70



Masić–Adorjan
Sombor, 1972

1 ... ♖h8 2 ♖g4+ ♕xg4!! 3 fg ♖ch7 4 ♔f1 (or 4 ♖xg3 ♖h1+ 5 ♔f2 fg+ 6 ♔f3 ♖8h2 7 ♘d2 g2 wins) 4 ... ♖h1+ 5 ♖g1 (or 5 ♔e2 ♖8h2) 5 ... ♖8h2 and White resigned, since both 6 ♕xh2 ♖xh2 7 ♖g2 ♖h3 8 ♘d2 ♗h4 and 6 ♕d2 a4!! 7 ♖xh1 ♖xh1+ 8 ♔e2 ♖h2+ 9 ♔d1 ab 10 ♕b4 f3 would be hopeless for him.

71

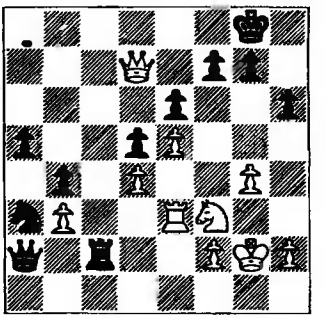


Kamishev–Sokolsky
Leningrad, 1936

Here we have a classic mating position with rook and knight brought about neatly as follows: 1 ... ♘e2+ 2 ♔h1 ♕xg4! 3 hg ♖h5+! 4 gh ♖h4 mate.

The coordination of queen and rook often produces interesting mating finishes. In our next position it looks all up with White until he conjures up a devastating combination.

72

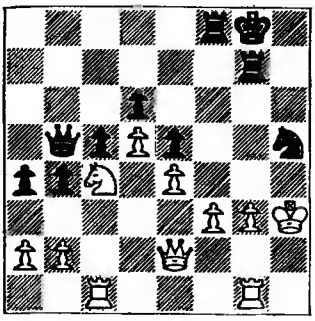


Golzov–Moiseyev
USSR, 1971

1 ♕e8+ ♔h7 2 ♘g5+! hg 3 ♖h3+ ♔g6 4 ♖h6+!! ♔xh6 (or 4 ... gh

5 ♕g8 mate) 5 ♕h8+ ♔g6 6 ♕h5 mate.

73



Westin–Karlsson
Sweden, 1973

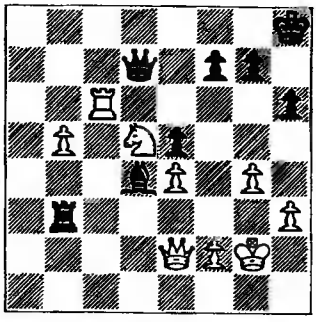
Black cleverly utilizes the open h file by a startling first move (note that with his rook on g6 the simple 1 ... ♖f7 would have won at once) to clear the way for his rook (on f8): 1 ... ♔f7!! 2 ♘xd6+ ♔e7 3 ♕xb5 ♘f4+! 4 gf ♖h8 mate.

Once again the queen and rook produce an attack out of the blue which must have shaken Black who probably felt he was doing quite well in our next position. (*See Diagram 74*).

White exploits the a and h files as well as the back rank, making four of the five moves with his queen, to win as follows: 1 ♕a2! ♖b2 2 ♕a8+ ♔h7 3 ♖xh6+!! ♔xh6 (or 3 ... gh 4 ♘f6+ winning the queen) 4 ♕h8+ ♔g6 5 ♕h5 mate.

We complete our treatment of the h file with two brilliant combinations in which the rook and

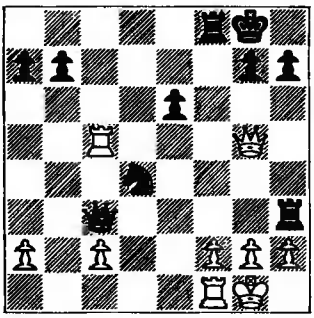
74



Kuzmin–Grigorian
USSR, 1972

knight mate again appears along with other fascinating elements, giving each an individuality despite the obvious common factors such as the queen sacrifice on the same square.

75

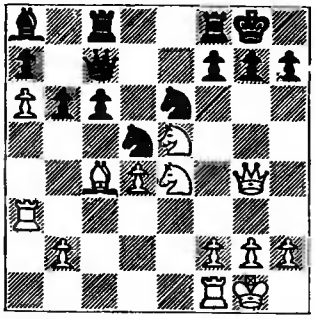


Lewitsky–Marshall
Breslau, 1912

After the stunning 1 ... ♕g3!! White felt compelled to resign, since if he captures the queen with either pawn he is mated by ♘e2+, whereas if he plays 2 ♕xg3 ♘e2+ 3 ♔h1 ♘xg3+ 4 ♔g1 ♘e2+ 5 ♔h1 ♖c3 he is a piece down for no compensation.

Finally, if 2 ♕e5 to stop ... ♕xh2 mate, then 2 ... ♘f3+ or 2 ... ♘e2+ force mate next move.

76



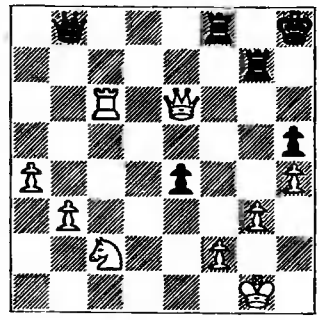
Rossolimo–Reissmann
Puerto Rico, 1967

After **1 ♗xd5! cd 2 ♘f6+ ♔h8** White, surely with the Marshall finish in mind, played **3 ♕g6!** since now 3 ... fg would allow 4 ♘xg6+ hg 5 ♖h3 mate. So Black tried to defend along the diagonal by 3 ... ♕c2 to no avail because White had 4 ♖h3! ♕xg6 5 ♘xg6+ fg 6 ♖xh7 mate, a triumph for the h file.

The next most important line on the ♔ side for attacking purposes is the *g file*, for which three examples will suffice. (*See Diagram 77*)

The situation is two-edged, so Black has to produce a series of forcing moves as follows: **1 ... ♖xg3+! 2 ♔f1** (after 2 fg ♕xg3+ mates next move) **2 ... ♖xf2+! 3 ♔e1** (or 3 ♔xf2 ♕f4+ followed by mate in three moves) **3 ... ♖g1+**

77

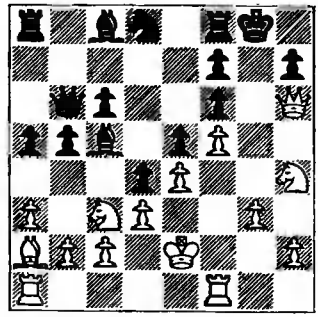


Gheorghiu–Korchnoi
Palma de Mallorca, 1968

4 ♔xf2 ♕g3+ 5 ♔e2 ♕f3+ and mate next move.

It is often difficult for the rook to reach the g file. Here is an example of one cunning way of doing this.

78



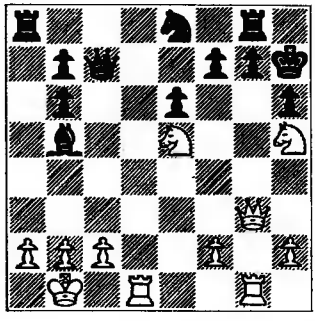
Alexander–Marshall
Cambridge, 1928

First of all, a sacrifice to keep the a7–g1 diagonal closed, **1 ♘a4 ba,** and then **2 ♖f4! ef 3 gf** and Black resigned because mate cannot be prevented. Note that move order is all-important here, as can be

seen in the line 1 ♖f4? ef 2 ♘a4 f3+! 3 ♘xf3 ♕a7 4 ♘g5 fg 5 f6 ♘e6 6 ♗xe6 fe and g7 is defended.

Finally, the g file is exploited in powerful fashion in our next example, once the black queen has been deflected from the guard of the f7 square.

79

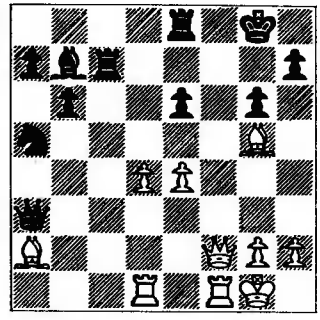


Horvath–Eperjesi
Hungary, 1971

1 ♖d7! ♗xd7 2 ♕xg7+! ♖xg7 3 ♖xg7+ ♘xg7 4 ♘f6+ ♔h8 5 ♘xf7 mate.

The *f file* is so important for attacking purposes that many openings (the King's Gambit, for example) are designed specifically to open this file and thus exert pressure on the f7 square. Once again, three examples should suffice to illustrate the power of the major pieces controlling the file.

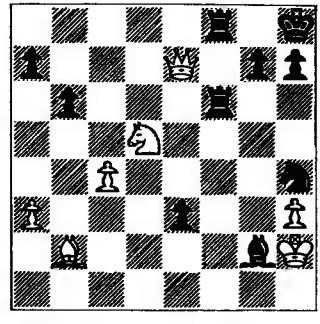
80



Furman–Panno
Madrid, 1973

As the black queen has to maintain its guard on f8 to prevent ♗xe6+ followed by ♕f8+ and mate in two moves, White can play 1 ♖d3! gaining time to treble his major pieces on the f file if need be. If now 1 ... ♕b4, White's ♔♗ is no longer attacked so he can play 2 ♕f6 ♗c8 3 ♗f4! ♖f7? 4 ♕xf7+! winning a whole rook. So Black played 1 ... ♕d6 only to lose after 2 ♗f4 ♕e7 3 ♗xc7 ♗a6 4 ♗d6! since now 4 ... ♕d7 allows 5 ♕f6! ♗xd3 6 ♗e5 ♗xf1 7 ♕h8+ ♔f7 8 ♕g7 mate.

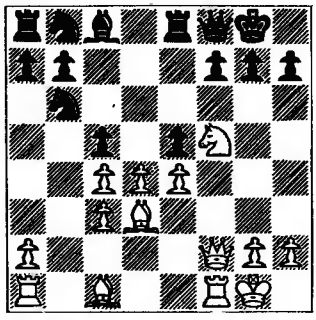
81



Moiseyev–Sokolsky
1951

1 ... ♘f3+! 2 ♔xg2 ♘e1+ 3 ♔h2 (or 3 ♔g3 ♖g6+ 4 ♔h4 ♘f3+ 5 ♔h5 ♖f5+ followed by mate) 3 ... ♖f2+ 4 ♔h1 (or 4 ♔g3 ♖g2+ 5 ♔h4 ♘f3+ mating) 4 ... ♖f1+ 5 ♔h2 ♘f3+ 6 ♔g3 ♖g1 mate.

82



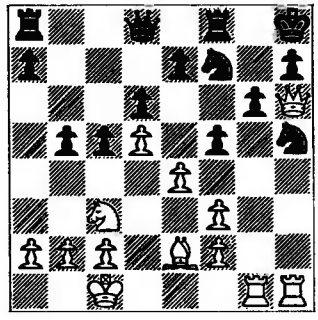
P. Johner–L. Steiner
Berlin, 1928

Here the f7 pawn proves a fatal weakness. Play went: 1 ♘h6+! ♔h8 (or 1 ....gh 2 ♗xh6! when Black either loses his queen or is mated) 2 ♘xf7+ ♔g8 3 ♕g3 ♕e7 4 ♘h6+ ♔h8 5 ♖f7 Resigns.

Of course, the attack is often launched down *two files*, so let us conclude this section with a few examples of such attacks. (*See Diagram 83*)

By a pretty queen sacrifice White immediately opens up the g and h files, after which Black must return even more material to prevent mate. Play went: 1 ♕xg6!! hg 2 ♖xg6 ♘h6 3 ♖xh5 ♖f7 4 ♖6xh6+ ♔g7 5 ♖h7+ ♔g8 (or 5 ... ♔f6 6 ♖5h6+ and 7 ♖xf7 with a rapid

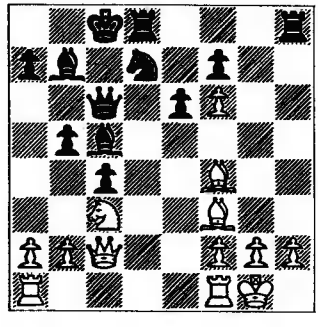
83



Planinc–Marangunić
Novi Travnik, 1969

mate) 6 ♖h8+ ♔g7 7 ♖5h7+ ♔g6 8 ef+ ♖xf5 9 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 10 ♗d3 and Black resigned a few moves later.

84



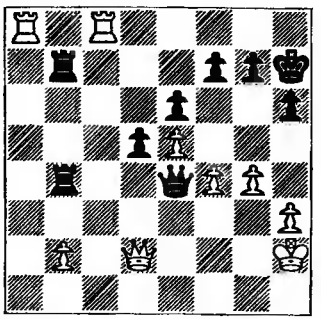
Johansson–Ekenberg
Sweden, 1974

The two open files in conjunction with the two powerful bishops prove too much for the white king, as follows: 1 ... ♕xf3! 2 gf ♖dg8+ 3 ♗g3 (or 3 ♔h1 ♗xf3 mate) 3 ... ♖xg3+! (the pin of the f pawn makes this possible) 4 hg ♗xf3 and

White resigned, since he cannot prevent mate on h1.

The author himself was the victim of a cunning mating attack which utilized the g and h files from the back door, so to speak.

85



Bernstein–Kotov
Groningen, 1946

1 ♖h8+ ♔g6 2 f5+! ef 3 ♕xh6+! gh 4 ♖ag8 mate.

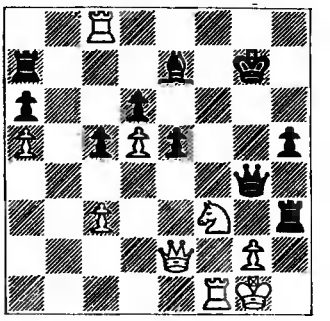
In our final example, the World Champion produced a neat piece of coordination utilising three edge files to crown his previous positional strategy. (*See Diagram 86*)

1 ♘xe5! ♕xe2 2 ♖f7+ ♔h6 3 ♖h8+ ♔g5 4 ♖g8+ ♔h4 (or 4 ... ♔h6 5 ♖g6 mate) **5 ♘g6+ ♔g5 6 ♘xe7+ ♔h4 7 ♘f5 mate.**

Exploitation of weak points

Many combinations are based on the exploitation of a weak point in the enemy camp by directing our attack against it until the defender

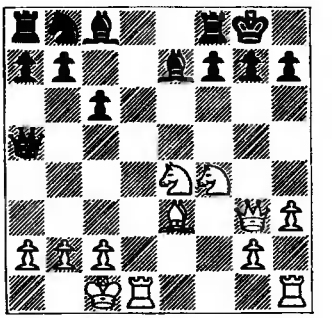
86



Karpov–Soldos
Hungary, 1973

is compelled to give way. If there are no such weaknesses, it is our task to create them by the pressure of our pieces. Clearly, this theme forms part of every game, so we restrict ourselves here to presenting a few clear-cut examples of the final stages of the exploitation.

87

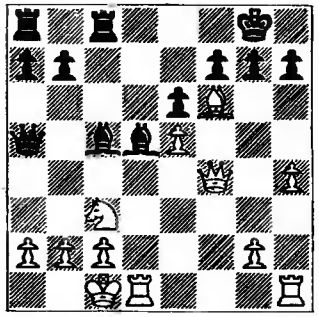


Mabbs–F. Alexander
London, 1961

All White's pieces except the ♔♖ are to be involved in a direct attack on the king and in particular on the g7 pawn. If this pawn advances, then the black squares f6 and h6

become weak and therefore available for occupation by White's pieces. However, at the moment the black queen is guarding vital squares on the fifth rank, so the first task is to shut her out of the game, when the attack can proceed without any undue problems. Play continued: **1 ♖d5!! cd 2 ♘h5 g6 3 ♘hf6+ ♗xf6 4 ♘xf6+ ♔g7 5 ♕e5! ♔h8** (the threat was mate in two by a discovered check by the knight on e8 or h5) **6 ♗h6 ♘c6 7 ♗g7+! ♔xg7 8 ♘e8+ ♔h6 9 ♕f4+ 9 ... g5 10 ♕f6+ ♔h5 11 ♘g7+ ♔h4 12 ♕f2 mate.**

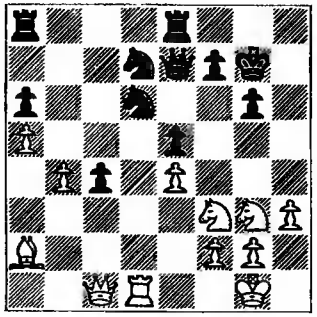
88



Spassky–Korensky
Sochi, 1973

Once again g7 is the target, and a sacrifice on this square reveals the weakness of the black squares around the king. **1 ♗xg7! ♔xg7 2 ♕f6+ ♔f8 3 ♖hf1 ♖c7 4 ♘xd5 exd5 5 e6!** (note that if Black's king had gone to g8 on move 2 then White would now have ♖d3 and ♖g3+ winning) **5 ... ♕xa2** (what else is there? If Black guards his e8 square by 5 ... ♕a4 to prevent the game continuation, whilst himself threatening 6 ... ♗e3+ and 7 ... ♕xc2+, White can exploit the weakness of d5 by **6 e7+ ♔g8 7 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 8 ♕f6+ ♔g8 9 ♕g5+ ♔h8 10 ♕e5+ ♔g8 11 ♕xd5+** followed by **12 ♕e5+** and **13 ♖d8+** mating) **6 e7+! ♔g8** (capturing on e7 allows **7 ♕h8** mate, and **6 ... ♔e8** allows mate in three moves) **7 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 8 e8♕+ ♖xe8 9 ♕xe8+ ♔g7 10 ♕e5+! ♔g8 11 ♕g5+ Resigns.** Black's rook falls with check, followed by a rapid mate.

89

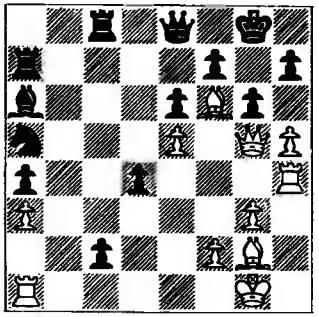


Karpov–Spassky
USSR 3 Teams, 1973

Black's slightly weakened ♔ side in conjunction with his clear weakness on the d file give White a won position. He now concludes the game with **1 ♕g5!** exploiting the fact that Black cannot capture without losing a piece. If **1 ... ♘f6 2 ♖xd6** wins at once, and if **1 ... ♔f8 2 ♕h6+ ♔g8 3 ♘g5 ♘f8** (3 ... ♘f6 4 ♖xd6 ♕xd6 5 ♗xc4 ♖a7 6 ♕xg6+ ♔f8 7 ♕h6+ ♔g8 8 ♘f5 wins) **4 ♘h5! gh 5 ♖xd6 ♖ac8 6 ♖f6** wins. Play continued: **1 ... f6**

2 ♕g4 (the best move, although 2 ♕d2 is also possible now, since after 2 ... ♖ad8 3 ♕xd6 ♘f8 White can capture the queen with check, something he could not do in the original position!) 2 ... ♔h7 (the threat was 3 ♖xd6) 3 ♘h4! and Spassky resigned because the knight fork on f5 proves fatal after both 3 ... ♖g8 4 ♖xd6 ♕xd6 5 ♘hf5! gf 6 ♕h5+ ♔g7 and 3 ... ♘f8 4 ♘xg6 ♘xg6 5 ♕h5+ ♔g7 6 ♖xd6 ♕xd6. A nice finish by the World Champion.

90

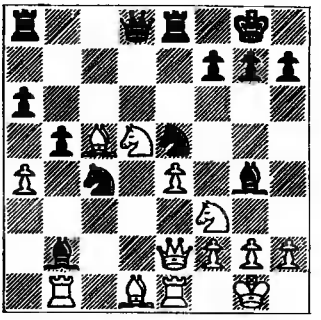


Fischer–Miagmasuren
Sousse, 1967

Black has a glaring weakness of the black squares around his king, but at first sight it seems difficult for White to exploit this before Black's material superiority prevails. However, it has all been carefully planned by Fischer who now forces mate by 1 ♕h6! ♕f8 2 ♕xh7+! ♔xh7 3 hg+ ♔xg6 4 ♗e4 mate.

The late Keres was a master of the attack on the king, and our next example shows him skilfully combining the theme of a king's side weakness (doubled f pawns) with other factors in the position.

91

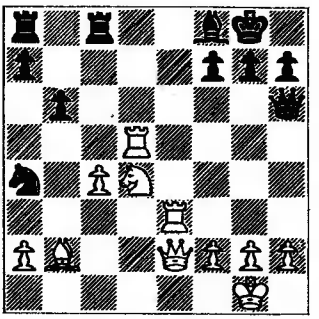


Rantanen–Keres
Tallinn, 1975

On the basis that the threat (of doubling pawns) is stronger than the execution, he first plays the useful 1 ... ♖e6! as a prelude to the coming attack on the king. If now White plays 2 ♕c2 to get out of the pin (2 ♕f1 allows a later ... ♘d2) Black has prepared the cunning 2 ... ♗xf3! 3 ♗xf3 (he must guard the back rank, since 3 gf ♖c8! 4 ♘e7+ ♖xe7 5 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 6 ♖xb2 fails to 6 ... ♖c6! 7 ♖b3 ♕g5+ 8 ♔h1 ♖g6 forcing mate) 3 ... ♗a3! 4 ♗d4 ♘xf3+ 5 gf ♗d6! threatening both 6 ... ♘a3 and also 6 ... ♕h4 with a powerful attack. And so, after 1 ... ♖e6! the main line runs 2 ♖xb2 ♘xf3+ 3 gf ♗h3! 4 ♔h1 (in the game, White tried 3 ♘e3 which leaves the bishop on c5 to its fate after ... ♕g5+) 4 ... ♘xb2 5 ♕xb2 (or 5 ♘e7+ ♖xe7 6 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 7 ♕xb2 b4 with a winning

end-game for Black) 5 ... ♕xd5! 6 ♖g1 ♗g2+! (a move Black must have planned from the start of his fine combination) 7 ♔xg2 ♖g6+ 8 ♔h1 ♖xg1+ 9 ♔xg1 ♕xd1+ and Black wins.

92



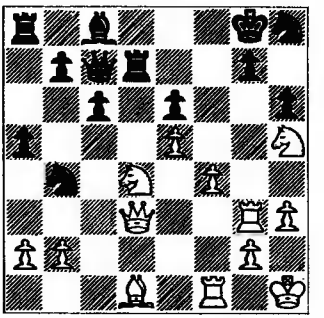
Spassky–Langeweg
Sochi, 1966

All White's pieces are ready to launch an assault on the black king and in particular on the g7 square. There is no way that this attack can be contained, since most of Black's pieces are off-side. Play went: 1 ♘f5 ♕c6 2 ♗xg7! ♕xd5 (desperation, but the bishop cannot be captured in view of 3 ♘e7+ winning the queen, and 2 ... ♕xc4 loses to 3 ♖g3! ♕xe2 4 ♘h6 mate) 3 ♘h6+! ♔xg7 4 ♕g4+ Resigns. Black has the choice between 4 ... ♔h8 5 ♕g8 mate or 4 ... ♔xh6 5 ♖h3+ followed by mate.

Drawing out the enemy king

If by sacrifices we can entice the king into the open, away from the protection offered him by his pawns and pieces, it is often (but not always!) possible to find a way to mate him. One must always be on the look-out for such an opportunity, so here are a few examples of this type of sacrificial attack.

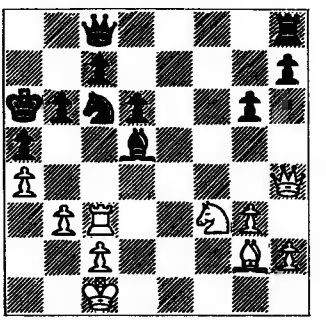
93



Alekhine–West
Portsmouth, 1923

1 ♕h7+!! ♔xh7 2 ♖xg7+! ♖xg7 3 ♘f6+ ♔g6 4 ♗h5 mate. A splendid illustration of our theme. Note the forcing nature of the moves, although as we have seen it is occasionally possible to introduce 'quiet' moves once the king is in the centre.

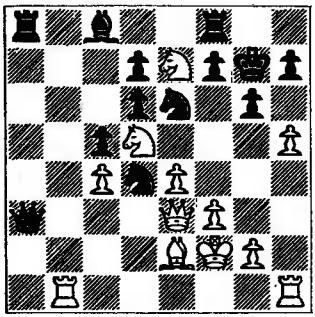
94



Kasparian–Manvelian
Erevan, 1936

Here is a delightful king hunt concluding with a quiet move. After 1 ♖xc6! ♗xc6 2 ♕c4+ ♔b7 3 ♕xc6+!! ♔xc6 4 ♘e5+ ♔c5 5 ♘d3+ ♔d4 White plays 6 ♔d2! when, despite his great material advantage, Black has no way of preventing 7 c3 mate.

95

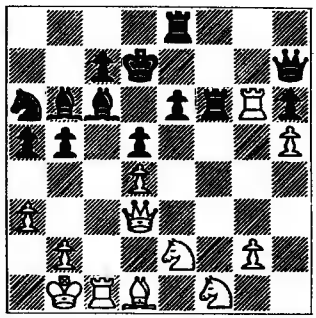


P. Schmidt–K. Richter
Germany c. 1940's

1 ♕h6+!! ♔xh6 (or 1 ... ♔h8 2 ♕xh7+ ♔xh7 3 hg+ ♔g7 4 ♖h7 mate) 2 hg+ ♔g5 3 ♖h5+! (the point) 3 ... ♔xh5 4 f4+ ♘xe2 (or 4 ... ♕f3+ 5 ♗xf3+ ♘xf3 6 ♖h1+ ♔g4 7 gf mate, or here 6 ... ♘h4! 7 ♘f6+ ♔h6 8 ♖xh4+ ♔g7 9 ♘e8+! ♖xe8 10 ♖xh7+ and 11 ♖xf7 mate) 5 ♘f6+ ♔h6 6 ♖h1+ ♔g7 7 ♘e8+! ♖xe8 8 ♖xh7+ ♔f6 9 ♖xf7 mate. (*See Diagram 96*)

1 ♖xc6! ♔xc6 2 ♕xb5+! ♔xb5 3 ♗a4+! ♔c4 (3 ... ♔xa4 4 ♘c3+ ♔b3 5 ♘d2 mate is the short alternative) 4 b3+ ♔d3 5 ♗b5+ ♔e4 6 ♖g4+ ♔f5 7 ♘e3 mate, a long variation to calculate but

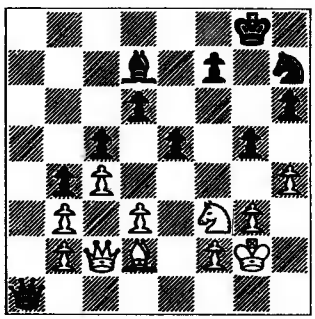
96



Tietz–Römisch
Carlsbad, 1898

fairly easy because all Black's moves are forced. Note, however, the chance factor of the black rook on f6 blocking the king in the final mating position! (Such speculation is always fascinating, but of course one may also argue that if there had been a black pawn on b6 instead of a bishop White could have won more quickly with 4 ♔c2! ♘b4+ 5 ♔d2 followed by 6 b3 mate, impossible in the given position because of 4 ... ♗xd4! etc. Translator's note)

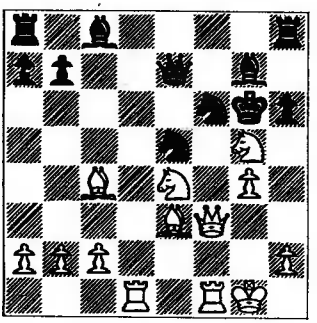
97



Vasyukov–Yevseyev
Moscow, 1975

The passive placing of White's pieces gives Vasyukov the chance to produce an original mating combination with limited material, as follows: **1 ... ♗h3+! 2 ♔xh3** (or 2 ♔h2 ♕f1 3 ♘e1 ♗d7 wins) **2 ... ♕f1+ 3 ♔g4** (or 3 ♔h2 ♘f6! 4 ♘g1 ♘g4+ 5 ♔h1 ♕xf2 mating) **3 ... ♘f6+ 4 ♔f5 ♕h3+ 5 ♔xf6 ♕e6 mate.**

98



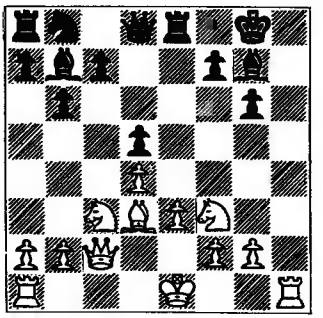
Begun–Maryakin
USSR, 1967

A critical position has been reached in which Black's king is clearly in danger whilst at the same time White has two of his pieces under attack. However, the final combination once again reveals that material considerations are unimportant when there is a mate in prospect. It is interesting to note how many queen sacrifices we have seen so far. Of course, the forcing nature of a sacrifice of such a powerful piece is obvious, but from a psychological point of view a defender is less likely to take account of this sacrifice, whereas he is constantly on the watch for the sacrifice of a minor piece. Play from the diagram went: **1 ♕f5+! ♗xf5 2 gf+ ♔h5 3 ♘g3+ ♔h4 4 ♖f4+ ♘fg4** (or 4 ... ♔xg5 5 h4 mate, or 4 ... ♘eg4 5 ♘f3+ ♔h3 6 ♗f1 mate) **5 ♖xg4+ ♘xg4 6 ♘f3+ ♔h3 7 ♗f1 mate.**

Demolishing the king's defences

Sacrifices to smash open the enemy king's position by removing his defensive wall of pawns represent a common feature of mating attacks which we have already seen as part of our previously quoted combinations. However, since it is such an important element, it seems worthwhile to examine in this section various methods of carrying out such demolition of the enemy stronghold. Let us begin with a clear-cut example from a specialist in the attack on the king, the late Frank Marshall.

99

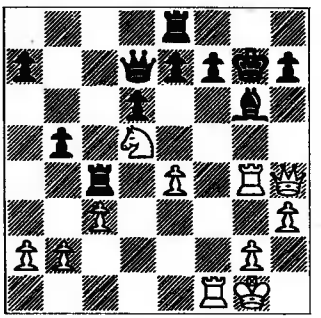


Marshall–Burn
Ostend, 1905

The black king's sole defenders are the two pawns and the bishop

on g7, and he is also behind in development. White on the other hand has not only nearly completed his development but also has an open file for his rook on h1. There is little doubt about the outcome and Marshall plunges in immediately with 1 ♗xg6! gf 2 ♕xg6 ♘d7 (he would of course like to play his queen to f6 but his rook on e8 would then be unprotected) 3 ♘g5 ♕f6 4 ♖h8+! ♔xh8 5 ♕h7 mate.

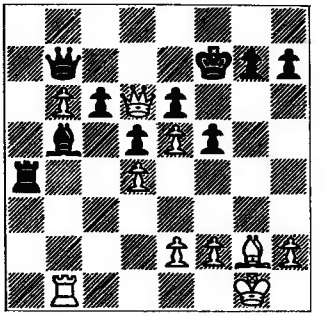
100



Ragozin–Veresov
Moscow, 1945

The sacrifice of both the white rooks smashes open Black's position and allows White to force mate or win of the queen as follows: 1 ♖xg6+! fg (1 ... ♔xg6 2 ♖f6+ would lead to the game continuation, since 2 ... ef 3 ♕xf6+ ♔h5 4 ♘f4 mate is the only alternative.) 2 ♖f7+! ♔xf7 3 ♕xh7+ ♔e6 (or 3 ... ♔f8 4 ♘f4 mating) 4 ♕xg6+ ♔e5 5 ♕g7+ ♔xe4 (or 5 ... ♔e6 6 ♘f4 mate) 6 ♘f6+ ef 7 ♕xd7 and White's material advantage ensured the win.

101

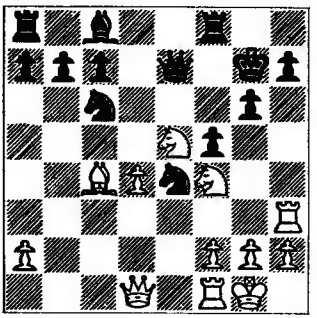


Portisch–Radulov
Budapest, 1969

Here we have a much more subtle form of breakthrough, involving a number of seemingly unrelated factors and typical of the Rubinstein-like style of Portisch. Clearly, the main theme is to try to remove the impregnable-looking pawn barrier across the central files, but there is also the possible use of the passed b pawn (at the moment 1 ♕c7+? ♕xc7 2 bc loses to 2 ... ♖a8 picking up the pawn) or the seemingly remote chance of exploiting the open g file or the possibility of the e pawn becoming passed and taking part in a mating attack. Let us now witness the masterly fashion in which all this is integrated into a winning combination: 1 e4!! ♕xb6 (Black immediately captures the potentially dangerous pawn. If 1 ... fe 2 ♗h3! wins, because 2 ... ♕c8 loses to 3 ♗xe6+ ♕xe6 4 ♕xe6+ ♔xe6 5 b7 and the pawn queens. However, the real beauty of the combination is seen in the variation 1 ... de 2 d5! ed 3 ♗h3! g6 4

♕f6+ ♔g8 5 ♗xf5! gf 6 ♔h1 ♗e2 7 ♖g1+ ♗g4 8 ♕xf5 winning) 2 ef ♕a7 (or 2 ... ef 3 ♗xd5+ ♔e8 4 ♖xb5! etc.) 3 ♕xe6+ ♔f8 4 ♗xd5 cd 5 ♖xb5 ♖xd4 6 ♕c8+ Resigns.

102

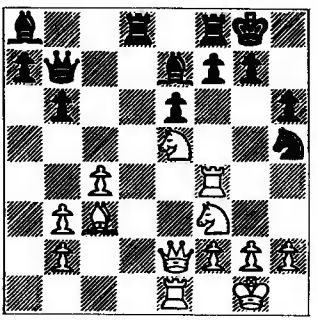


Karpov–Enevoldsen
Skopje, 1972

Here we have an unusual case of two possible ways of smashing up the black king's position. With the benefit of hindsight, we can now assert that the most effective method would have been 1 ♖xh7+!! ♔xh7 2 ♘4xg6 ♕d6 (2 ... ♘xe5 3 ♘xe7 ♘xc4 4 ♕h5+ ♔g7 6 ♕g6+ ♔h8 7 ♕h6 mate) 3 ♘xf8+ ♔g7 (or 3 ... ♕xf8 4 ♕h5+ ♕h6 5 ♗g8+ ♔g7 6 ♕f7+ ♔h8 7 ♘g6+ winning) 4 ♕h5 ♘xe5 5 ♕h7+ ♔xf8 7 de! ♕d7 7 ♕g8+ ♔e7 8 ♕f7+ ♔d8 9 ♕f8+ ♕e8 10 ♖d1+ ♗d7 11 ♕xf5 winning.

Karpov's method was equally plausible and it was difficult to see at this stage that Black would have some defensive chances with an exposed king and no material compensation. Play continued from the diagram: 1 ♘fxg6! hg 2 ♘xg6 ♕f6 (of course, 2 ... ♔xg6 allows mate in two moves) 3 ♘xf8 ♔xf8 4 ♖h7 ♘e7 (not the best defence which was 4 ... ♘g5! 5 ♖h5 ♗e6 6 ♗xe6! ♘xe6 7 d5 ♖d8 8 ♕b3 ♘ed4 9 ♕xb7 ♖xd5 10 ♕xc7 when White's attack continues) 5 ♖e1 ♕g6 6 ♖f7+ ♕xf7 7 ♗xf7 ♔xf7 8 ♕h5+ ♔f8 9 ♕h6+ ♔f7 10 ♕h7+ Resigns.

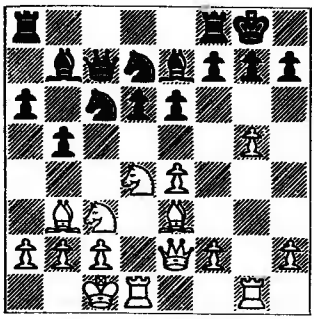
103



Kopilov–Timofiyev
Corres, 1969

White won in the following interesting way: 1 ♖xf7! ♖xf7 (1 ... ♘f4! would have offered more chances) 2 ♘xf7 ♔xf7 3 ♕xe6+ ♔f8 4 ♘h4! (this is perhaps the move Black missed; as 4 ... ♗xh4 5 ♗b4+ wins at once for White, Black is forced to guard g6 with his knight, thus weakening g7) 4 ... ♘f4 5 ♗xg7+! ♔e8 (or 5 ... ♔xg7 6 ♘f5+ wins) 6 ♕g4 ♔f7 7 ♕xf4+ ♔xg7 8 ♖xe7+ Resigns.

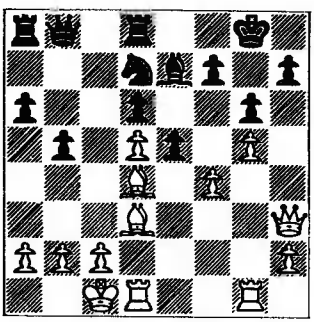
104



Goncharov–Strasduns
USSR, 1969

We are hardly out of the opening phase before White launches a winning attack in spectacular fashion, completely eliminating all four black ♔ side pawns within six moves and thus exposing the king to a forced mate. Play went: **1 g6! hg 2 ♘xe6! fe 3 ♗xe6+ ♔h8** (or 3 ... ♖f7 4 ♘d5 ♕d8 5 ♖xg6 ♘ce5 6 ♖xg7+ ♔xg7 7 ♖g1+ with a rapid mate) **4 ♖xg6 ♖f7** (or 4 ... ♘f6 5 ♖xf6! and 6 ♕h5+ wins) **5 ♕h5+ ♔g8 6 ♖xg7+!** and Black resigned because he is mated in two moves.

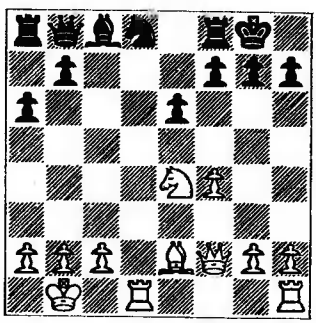
105



Suetin–Jimenez
Havana, 1969

Once again the object is to smash up the pawn barrier protecting the enemy king, whatever this may cost in terms of material, since at the moment Black's major pieces are completely out of play and need time to come to the aid of the king, time which White will make every effort to deny them. Leaving his bishop on d4, Suetin continued: **1 f5!! ed 2 fg hg 3 ♗xg6! ♘f8** (after 3 ... fxg6 4 ♕e6+ White wins the bishop whilst maintaining his attack) **4 ♗xf7+! ♔xf7 5 g6+ ♔g7 6 ♖df1 ♗f6 7 ♖xf6!** Resigns. It is mate in a few moves.

106

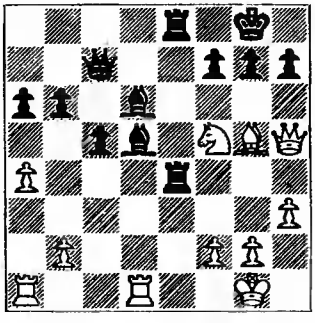


Kupreichik–Babev
Dresden, 1969

Once again the black pieces are poorly placed for defensive purposes, so White wastes no time in beginning his mating attack, exploiting in particular the weakness of the dark squares in the black camp. Play went: **1 ♘f6+!** gf (if 1 ... ♔h8 then 2 ♕c5! wins at once) **2 ♕g3+ ♔h8 3 ♕h4! ♔g7 4 ♖d3 ♖e8** (if Black tries to pro-

tect his h pawn with 4 ... ♖h8, he loses to 5 ♖g3+ ♔f8 6 ♕xf6 forking the knight and rook) 5 ♖h3 h5 6 ♗xh5 ♖g8 7 ♖g3+ ♔f8 8 ♕xf6 and Black resigned, since he is completely lost after 8 ... ♖xg3 9 ♕xd8+ ♔g7 10 hg followed by 11 ♗f3.

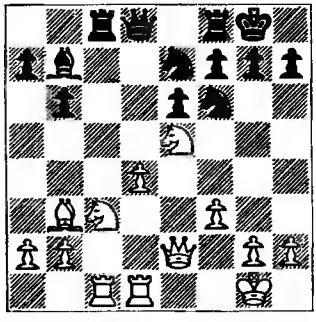
107



Portisch–Radulov
Olympiad, 1974

Another complicated piece of play from Portisch, necessarily so because he is attempting to break down an unweakened king position with limited material at his command and with only a temporary lack of coordination of the black pieces to help him. The first idea is easy enough to see, 1 ♘xg7! breaking open the king side pawns, since if now 1 ... ♔xg7 then 2 ♕h6+ and 3 ♗f6 forces mate. However, it is not so easy to visualize the possibilities if Black declines the offer and sets up a pin along the fourth rank. So, after 1 ♘xg7!, play continued 1 ... ♖8e5! 2 f4! ♖xf4 (if 2 ... ♖e2 then simply 3 fe wins) 3 ♘e8!! ♕c6 (or 3 ... ♖xe8 4 ♗xf4 ♗xf4 5 ♕xd5 winning material) 4 ♘xd6 f6 (4 ... ♕xd6 allows 5 ♗xf4 winning, but the most tenacious defence is offered by 4 ... h6! when White planned 5 ♘c8! with tremendous complications which should turn out in his favour, e.g. 5 ... hg 6 ♘e7+ ♖xe7 7 ♕xg5+ etc.) 5 ♖e1!! and Black had to admit defeat. One finish might be: 5 ... ♖xg5 6 ♖e8+ ♔g7 7 ♖e7+ ♔f8 8 ♖f7+! followed by mate.

108

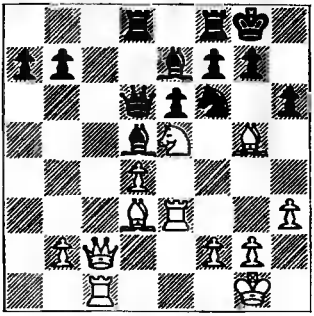


Botvinnik–Batuyev
Leningrad, 1931

A typical isolated ♕ pawn position, with the knight on e5 supported by the bishop on b3 exerting pressure on the f7 pawn. More often than not, it is the threat of capturing on f7 which hangs over Black rather than the actual realisation of it, but here Botvinnik played 1 ♘xf7! immediately gaining two pawns for the piece and

pinning the black rook in unpleasant fashion. Play continued: **1 ... ♖xf7 2 ♕xe6 ♕f8** (2 ... ♘ed5 loses to 3 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 4 ♗xd5 ♗xd5 5 ♖xc8) **3 ♘e4 ♖xc1 4 ♖xc1 ♘fd5 5 ♘d6 ♗a8 6 ♖e1! g6 7 ♘xf7 ♕xf7 8 ♕xe7 Resigns.**

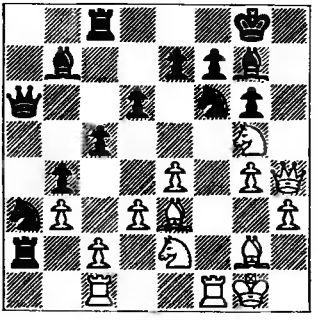
109



Bakulin–Sokolov
Moscow, 1973

All of White's pieces are available for an attack on the king, so despite the solidity of the black position the weakness of his pawn on h6 is enough to lead to his downfall. All of the following play is well worth careful attention, since it is a model of such an attack: **1 ♗xh6! gh 2 ♖g3+ ♔h8 3 ♕d2 ♘g8 4 ♖xg8+! ♔xg8 5 ♕xh6 f5** (the only way to prevent mate in two, but now the other rook comes into the game with decisive effect) **6 ♕g6+ ♔h8 7 ♖c3! ♖f6** (the threat was 8 ♕h5+ followed by 9 ♗xf5 and 10 ♖g3+) **8 ♕h5+ ♔g7 9 ♗xf5! ♖g8** (or 9 ... ♖xf5 10 ♖g3+ ♖g5 11 ♖xg5+ ♗xg5 12 ♕f7+ followed by mate) **10 ♖g3+ ♔f8 11 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 12 ♕h7+ Resigns.**

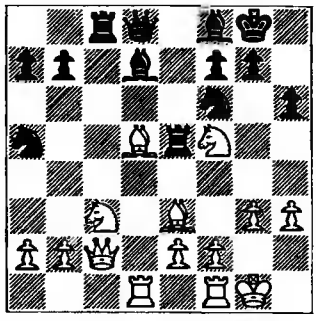
110



Spassky–Geller
Match, 1968

Another typical attacking situation, where White has banked everything on a ♔ side assault. He has already succeeded in opening up the f file and eliminating Black's h pawn, all a pointer to his next obvious sacrifice. The interest lies mainly in the well-calculated follow-up after the preliminary **1 ♖xf6! ef 2 ♕h7+ ♔f8.** With threats against his c pawn then d pawn, White plays **3 ♘xf7! ♖xc2** (after 3 ... ♔xf7 4 ♗h6 ♖g8 5 ♘f4 ♖xc2 6 ♖f1 White has a winning attack) **4 ♗h6! ♖xc1+** (or 4 ... ♖xe2 5 ♕xg7+ ♔e8 6 ♘g5! fg 7 ♗xg5 mating) **5 ♘xc1 ♔xf7 6 ♕xg7+ ♔e8 7 g5 f5 8 ♕xg6+ ♔d7 9 ♕f7+ ♔c6 10 ef+ Resigns.** After the exchange of queens White's f pawn is too strong.

111



Tal–Stean
Moscow, 1975

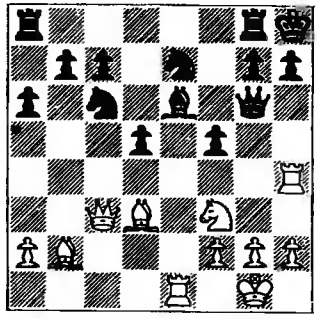
Very rarely does Tal neglect an opportunity to open up the position of the enemy king, so he now takes advantage of the temporary displacement of the knight on a5 and the pin of the bishop on d7 to launch a winning sacrificial attack as follows: 1 ♘xh6+! gh 2 ♕g6+ ♔h8 (2 ... ♗g7 would only lose time, as we see later) 3 ♗xf7 ♖c6 (to protect his knight on f6 against the threat of ♖xd7, the knight having to remain where it is in order to prevent ♕g8 mate. For example, the tempting 3 ... ♘c6 guarding d4 would immediately lose material to 4 ♗xh6 ♗xh6 5 ♖xd7! since now 5 ... ♕xd7 allows 6 ♕xf6+ ♗g7 7 ♕h4+ followed by mate) 4 ♖d5! ♕e7 (if 4 ... ♖xd5 5 ♘xd5 ♗g7 6 ♗xh6 ♗xh6 7 ♕xh6+ ♘h7 8 ♗g6 ♕g8 9 ♘e7 wins material) 5 ♗d4! ♘c4 6 f4 and as Black cannot play 6 ... ♖xd5 7 ♕g8 mate, he lost in a few moves.

Various other mates

Many of the mates we have seen so far are the result of a planned attack on the king in which the king's position is shattered by a sacrifice or piece superiority prevailed. However, there are times when a mate appears out of a clear blue sky, unexpected and occasionally irrational, or at least depending to a great extent on the power of the player's imagination.

Each piece has the potential for inflicting mate, so long as we are aware of its particular characteristics and how it can be fully utilised in conjunction with other pieces. Consider, for example, the devious knight which can perhaps produce more surprises than any other piece.

112

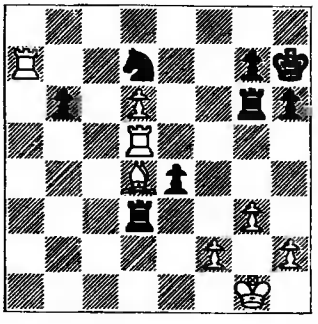


Composed position

The so-called 'smothered' mate is peculiar to the knight. White here plays 1 ♖xe6! ♕xe6 2 ♘g5 ♕g6

3 ♖xh7+! ♕xh7 4 ♘f7 mate. Simple, isn't it?

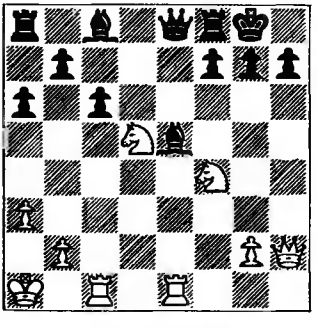
113



Alekhine–Bogoljubow
Match, 1929

Here is a splendid piece of imaginative play. Black's 1 ... ♘f6! seems at first sight ridiculous, because White can now queen his d pawn. However, Bogoljubov would then have (after 2 d7) 2 ... ♘xd5 3 d8♕ ♖d1+ 4 ♔g2 ♘f4 mate!

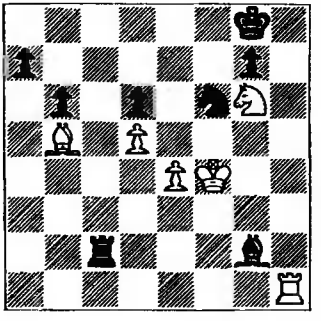
114



Composed position

A mate with two knights which Morphy once achieved with the black pieces. By 1 ♖xe5! ♕xe5 2 ♘g6! White wins material, since 2 ... ♕xh2 allows 3 ♘de7 mate. Note that if 2 ... ♕xd5 White does not even bother to win the queen, because he has 3 ♘e7+ ♔h8 4 ♕xh7+! ♔xh7 5 ♖h1+ forcing mate.

115

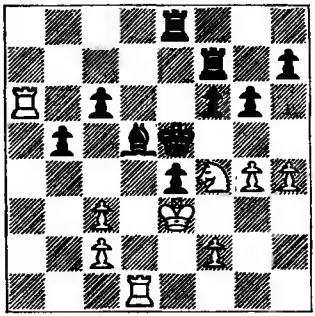


Bondarevsky–Ufimtsev
Leningrad, 1936

After 1 ♖h8+ ♔f7 White would like to advance his king, but on both f5 and g5 he will be checked away. The neat deflection sacrifice 2 ♗e8+! ♘xe8 solves the problem, since now 3 ♔g5! is possible, followed by mate on f8. It would be interesting to know how far ahead White visualised the final combination.

A surprise mate by the humble pawn is always guaranteed to provide aesthetic pleasure, as in our next example.

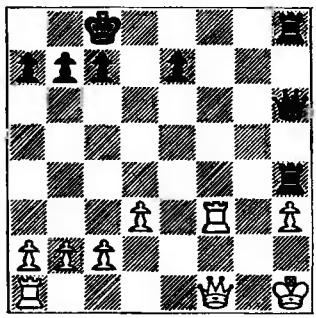
116



Opočensky–Hromadka
Koscian, 1931

First, the sixth rank is cleared by 1 ♖xd5+! cd, then the knight is sacrificed both to clear the f4 square and at the same time deflect the black e pawn: 2 ♘d3+! ed, and finally we have 3 f4 mate!

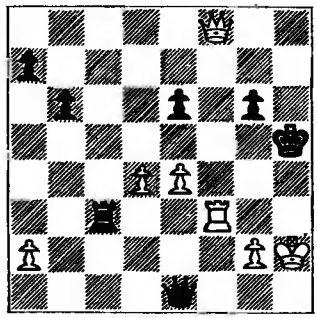
117



Ströbel–Balshan
Dresden, 1969

It is now the turn of the major pieces, when the placing of the respective kings is of the utmost importance. Here, for instance, White's pawns are no weaker than Black's, and in addition he is a pawn up, but his king is much more vulnerable, as the following play shows: 1 ... ♕c6! 2 ♕g2 (2 ... ♖xh3+ was threatened and if 2 ♔g1 Black has 2 ... ♖g8+ 3 ♔h2 ♕d6+ 4 ♔h1 ♖g3! 5 ♖xg3 ♕xg3 6 ♕f8+ ♔d7 7 ♕f5+ ♔d6! winning) 2 ... ♖xh3+! 3 ♖xh3 ♖xh3+ 4 ♔g1 ♕c5+ 5 ♔f1 (5 ♕f2 ♖h1+!) 5 ... ♖h5! 6 ♕g4+ ♔d8 7 ♕g8+ ♔d7 8 ♕g4+ ♖f5+! (but not 8 ... e6 9 ♕g7+ ♔c6 10 ♕g2+ ♔b6 11 ♕g1 exchanging queens) 9 ♔e1 ♕e3+ 10 ♔d1 e6 11 ♕g7+ ♔d6 12 ♕g2 ♖f2! and White resigned.

118

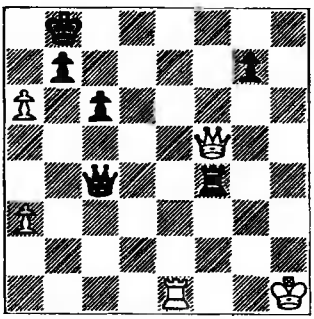


Najdorf–Tal
Belgrade, 1970

Once again, Black's king is more exposed than White's, and in addition it is White to move, a vital factor as the interesting finish reveals: 1 ♕h8+ ♔g5 (1 ... ♔g4 2 ♕h3+ wins the rook) 2 ♕e5+ ♔h6 3 ♕f4+! ♔h7 (or 3 ... g5 4 ♕f8+ ♔h7 5 ♕e7+ followed by mate in a few moves) 4 ♖f1! ♕e2 (or 4 ... ♕e3 5 ♕h4+ ♔g7 6 ♖f4! with 7 ♕e7+ and 8 ♖h4+ to follow) 5 ♕f7+ ♔h6 6 ♕f8+ ♔h5 7 ♖f4! ♕e1 (there is nothing better,

because White was threatening 8 ♕h8+ ♔g5 9 ♕h4 mate) 8 ♕h8+ ♔g5 9 ♕e5+ ♔h6 10 ♖g4 and Tal finally had to admit defeat, being unable to defend against the double threats of 11 ♕h8 mate and 11 ♕g5+.

119



Kots–N.N.

Both kings are in danger, but White has the move and wins as follows: 1 ♖e8+ ♔a7 (or 1 ... ♔c7 2 ♕a5+ b6 3 ♕e5+ ♔d7 4 ♕e7 mate) 2 ♖a8+! ♔b6 (2 ... ♔xa8 allows mate in two) 3 ♕a5+!! ♔xa5 4 ab+ ♔b5 5 b8♕+ ♔c5 6 ♖a5+ Resigns. Heavy loss of material cannot be avoided.

Summing up, we can state that such finishes with the major pieces alone are bordering on end-game play, but the power of the queen and rook combined is so strong that, given any weaknesses in the position of the kings, mating attacks can and should be launched, or should at least form part of the general strategic plan of queening passed pawns. We must never lose sight of the fact that mating the enemy king remains our ultimate goal.

3 Game Patterns

This chapter may seem like a digression from our main theme, but it is clearly important for us to identify and locate the genesis of a combination, so it is surely worthwhile to view it within the context of a whole game. Although it is often difficult to differentiate between strategic and positional play on the one hand and tactical and combinative play on the other, we can broadly divide games into certain patterns, depending on the nature of the struggle. We can distinguish between the player who is bold, imaginative and sometimes even reckless and the player who thinks primarily of his own safety or prefers to deal with the concrete reality of a position rather than speculate on remote chances. The character of a player determines his chess style which in turn has an undoubted influence on the type of game he produces.

Our first game example is won by that iron logician Botvinnik with his computer-like control of events. Positional considerations are uppermost, with unclear tactical complications ruled out, the whole game being an example of a methodical exploitation of strategic weaknesses in the enemy camp.

Stolberg-Botvinnik
12th USSR Championship, 1940

1	d4	♘f6
2	c4	e6
3	♘c3	♗b4
4	e3	0-0
5	♗d3	d5
6	♘e2	c5
7	0-0	♘c6
8	cd	ed
9	a3	cd
10	ed	

The Nimzo-Indian Defence has already resulted in a position with fixed pawns in the centre, a sure sign that we are in for a dour positional struggle for strong-points in the centre rather than a sharp tactical skirmish. It is most instructive to see how Botvinnik gradually takes over the key points to achieve a clear positional advantage.

10	...	♗d6
11	h3	

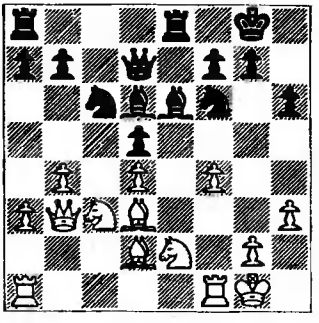
An unnecessary and time-wasting move which allows Black to gain the upper hand in the centre. 11 ♗f4 was best, with even chances.

11	...	h6
12	b4	

Again a pointless move, allowing Black to seize the initiative. 12 ♗c2 would have still given White some say in the central struggle.

12	...	♖e8
13	♕b3	♗e6
14	♗d2	♕d7!
15	f4?	

120



A serious strategic error, permanently weakening the e4 square and his king position. He should play 15 ♘a4 which would at least fit in with his previous moves, whilst at the same time preventing a possible 15 ... ♗xh3 16 gh ♕xh3? because of 17 ♗h7+.

15	...	♗f5!

Black immediately fastens on the weakness, taking advantage of the fact that the knight on e2 is loose in some lines and White cannot play 16 ♘xd5 ♘xd5! nor 16 ♗xf5 ♕xf5 17 g4? ♕d3!

16	♕c2	♗e4!
17	b5	♗xd3!
18	♕xd3	♘a5
19	♘g3	

Now White has given Black the opportunity to occupy the other weak square on c4. Note that 19 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 20 ♗xa5 fails to 20 ... ♖e3, yet another weak square created by 15 f4?

19	...	♘c4
20	♗c1	♖ac8
21	♖a2	♗f8
22	a4	♗b4
23	♘d1	♘e4

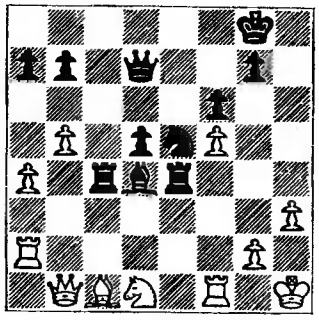
Black's pieces dominate the board.

24	f5	♘xg3
25	♕xg3	♗d6
26	♕f3	♗e7
27	♕g3	♗f6
28	♗xh6	♗xd4+
29	♔h1	f6!

Now the e5 square is in Black's hands, giving him complete control of the vital central points.

30	♗c1	♖e4
31	♕d3	♘e5
32	♕b1	♖c4

121



All White's pieces have been driven back, and it is only now that Botvinnik heads for the final attack on the king, when a combination will represent the culmination of the whole positional struggle.

33	a5	♗c5
34	b6	a6
35	♘b2	♖c3
36	♗d2	♖b3

37	♕c2	♕b5
38	♖c1	♗f8
39	♖d1	♖e2
40	♕c1	♖xh3+!
41	gh	d4!

and White resigned, since mate is forced.

Contrast the above with the following game:

Belavenets–Lisvitsin
10th USSR Championship, 1937

1	d4	♘f6
2	♘f3	d5
3	c4	♗f5

Within the space of a few moves, it is clear that Black is trying to complicate the situation. White accepts the challenge, so we immediately plunge into a complex situation.

4	♕b3	♘c6!
5	♘c3	e5?

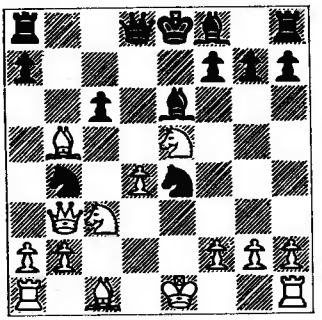
In his eagerness to join battle, Black oversteps the mark, whereas he could achieve equality with 5 ... dxc4 6 ♕xc4 e6 etc.

6	cd!	♘b4
7	e4!	♘xe4
8	♗b5+	c6
9	dc	bc
10	♘xe5	♗e6

(*See Diagram 122*)

We have arrived in ten moves at a critical position which demands an immediate tactical solution, because, unlike the Botvinnik game, there can be no question now of quiet positional play. White finds an elegant way of exchanging material to reach a won ending.

122



11	♘xc6!	♕b6
12	♘xb4+	♕xb5
13	♕xe6+	fe
14	♘xb5	♗xb4+
15	♔e2	♔d7
16	f3	♘f6
17	♘c3	

and Black resigned a few moves later.

So, two very contrasting games. Now for our third type of game in which up to a certain point matters proceed in quiet positional style, until suddenly there is an explosion of tactics involving a lengthy and tricky combination, the outcome of which decides the game.

Averbakh–Kotov
Zürich, 1953

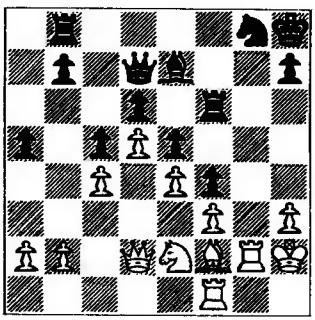
1 d4 ♘f6 2 c4 d6 3 ♘f3 ♘bd7 4 ♘c3 e5 5 e4 ♗e7 6 ♗e2 0-0 7 0-0 c6 8 ♕c2 ♖e8 9 ♖d1 ♗f8 10 ♖b1 a5 11 d5 ♘c5 12 ♗e3 ♕c7 13 h3 ♗d7 14 ♖bc1 g6 15 ♘d2 ♖ab8 16 ♘b3

An Old-Indian Defence has given rise to slow manoeuvring on both sides to improve the placing of their

pieces, the d5 move indicating the eventual strategic plans to be followed, with White hoping to attack on the queen's wing and Black to counter on the other side. With my next two moves I manage to hold back White's attack for some time, so that I can begin action on the king's wing.

16 ... ♘xb3 17 ♕xb3 c5 18 ♔h2 ♔h8 19 ♕c2 ♘g8 20 ♗g4 ♘h6 21 ♗xd7 ♕xd7 22 ♕d2 ♘g8 23 g4 f5 24 f3 ♗e7 25 ♖g1 ♖f8 26 ♖cf1 ♖f7 27 gf gf 28 ♖g2 f4! 29 ♗f2 ♖f6 30 ♘e2

123



So far the game has proceeded in similar fashion to our first example, with slow strategic manoeuvring being the order of the day. Suddenly, however, seemingly out of the blue, a quiet positional game is turned into a highly-charged tactical situation beginning with Black's next move which drags the white king into a mating net.

30	...	♕xh3+!!
31	♔xh3	♖h6+
32	♔g4	♘f6+
33	♔f5	♘d7

Black has seen a winning method but, in his excitement, fails to recognize an even quicker way beginning 33 ... ♘g4! after which White could resign immediately.

34	♖g5!	♖f8+
35	♔g4	♘f6+
36	♔f5	♘g8+

Black repeats moves to gain time on the clock.

37	♔g4	♘f6+
38	♔f5	♘xd5+
39	♔g4	♘f6+
40	♔f5	♘g8+
41	♔g4	♘f6+
42	♔f5	♘g8+
43	♔g4	♗xg5

Finally concrete mating theats appear. If now 44 ♘g3 ♗e7 45 ♘h5 ♘f6+ 46 ♘xf6 ♖fxf6 followed by mate in three moves. Or 44 ♖h1 ♖xh1 45 ♔xg5 ♖h6! and again mate cannot be prevented.

44	♔xg5	♖f7!
45	♗h4	♖g6+
46	♔h5	♖fg7
47	♗g5	♖xg5+
48	♔h4	♘f6
49	♘g3	♖xg3
50	♕xd6	♖3g6
51	♕b8+	♖g8

and White resigned.

We conclude this section with a justly famous game which illustrates to perfection the close link which necessarily exists between tactics on the one hand and the strategy that gives rise to them, on the other.

Réti–Alekhine
Baden-Baden, 1925

1	g3	e5
2	♘f3	e4
3	♘d4	d5
4	d3	exd3
5	♕xd3	♘f6
6	♗g2	♗b4+
7	♗d2	♗xd2+
8	♘xd2	0-0
9	c4!	

White has handled the opening in original fashion and ensured himself a small but sure advantage in the centre. We next witness a phase of positional manoeuvring with White building up an attack on the ♕ wing whilst Black aims for some compensation on the other side.

9	...	♘a6
10	cd	♘b4
11	♕c4	♘bxd5
12	♘2b3	c6
13	0-0	♖e8
14	♖fd1	♗g4
15	♖d2	♕c8
16	♘c5	♗h3!

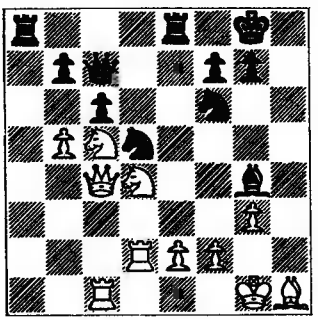
A pawn sacrifice which White declines to accept, since 17 ♗xh3 ♕xh3 18 ♘xb7 ♘g4 gives Black a dangerous attack.

17	♗f3	♗g4
18	♗g2	♗h3
19	♗f3	♗g4

Alekhine seems quite happy to settle for a draw by repetition, in view of White's ♕ side pressure, but is at the same time prepared to throw everything into the attack, should Réti decline the offer.

20	♗h1	h5!
21	b4	a6
22	♖ac1	h4
23	a4	hg
24	hg	♕c7!
25	b5	ab
26	ab	

124



The critical moment has arrived. Alekhine realizes that his pieces have attained their maximum effectiveness, so he must launch an immediate attack before his position on the queen's wing collapses. Tactics are now the order of the day in the following splendid combinative finish which Alekhine himself rates as one of his best achievements.

23	...	♖e3!!

This rook will remain 'en prise' for six moves! Clearly, it cannot be captured without allowing 27 ... ♕xg3+ 28 ♗g2 ♘xe3 mating. Perhaps White's best chance is now 27 ♔h2, but it was not easy to see that, even with queens off, Black's pieces attack continues unabated.

27	♘f3	cb
28	♕xb5	♘c3!

4 Combinations Involving Pawns

The pawn, as the smallest fighting unit, is not only more expendable than other pieces but is also devastatingly effective in guarding vital squares, driving away enemy pieces or producing the piece-winning fork. The pawn structure can very often dictate the strategy to be followed by both sides, whether they form pawn majorities which can produce a winning passed pawn, or create chains of pawns blocking each other and lending the game a slow, positional character. The fact that a pawn captures diagonally allows it to open up the lines for the pieces. In fact, André Philidor's assertion that the pawns are the soul of chess may sound a little grandiose, but we can state unequivocally that they are certainly the backbone!

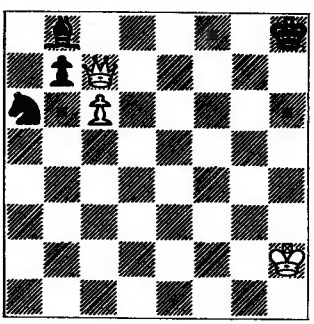
However, this does not conclude the story of the versatile pawn, since in addition it has the unique power of being able to promote to another piece once it reaches the eighth rank. This factor can bring about a complete reversal of values in certain situations, leading to startling combinative possibilities often linked with sacrifices.

Pawns are especially effective advancing together in a pawn mass, driving back enemy pieces or heading for promotion. It is well known, for example, that a rook is usually helpless against two connected passed pawns on the sixth rank.

Finally, apart from being good defenders of their own king position, pawns can prove invaluable in attacks on the enemy king, creating strong-points or opening lines for the attacking pieces. Let us now consider all these aspects of the pawn in greater detail.

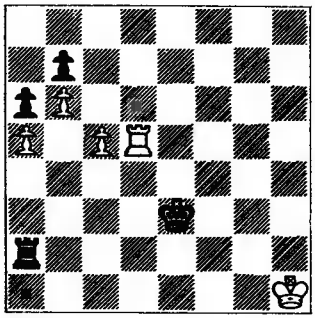
It takes five or six moves for a pawn to reach the eighth rank, and there are normally many obstacles in its path which make such a trip distinctly hazardous. Caissa created the sacrifice as a means of removing obstacles, and our next three examples are typical ways of forcing a pawn through to the queening square.

127



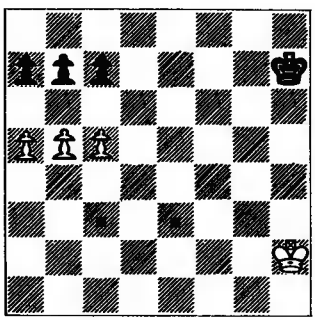
White plays 1 ♕xb8+ ♘xb8 2 c7 and the knight is helpless against the advance of the pawn.

128



After the obvious 1 c6 bc White has the clever 2 ♖b5! cb 3 b7 and the black pawn on b5 stops the rook defending by ... ♖b2.

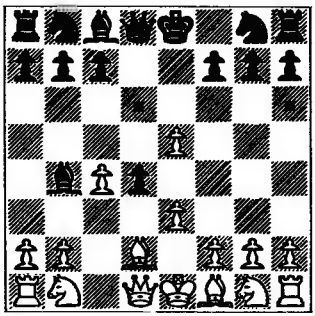
129



A famous example of an unusual breakthrough with three pawns facing three pawns. Note that this brilliant combination only works because the defending king is too far away. White sacrifices two pawns to free a path for the other, as follows: 1 b6 ab 2 c6! bc 3 a6 and this pawn queens; or here 1 ... cb 2 a6! with a similar finish.

It is of course rare to see a pawn promotion during the early stages of a game, but there are enough examples in chess literature to make it worth our while to examine the mechanics of such unusual promotions. Consider the position arising after the following opening moves of the Albin Counter-gambit: 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e5 3 de d4 4 e3? ♗b4+ 5 ♗d2

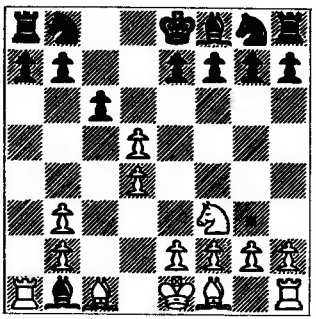
130



Because of a promoting combination, Black can now give up a piece by 5 ... de! 6 ♗xb4? (it is essential to play the positionally bad 6 fe) 6 ... ef+ 7 ♔e2 fg♘+! and White cannot capture the knight in view of 8 ... ♗g4+ winning the queen, whereas 8 ♔e1 ♕h4+ leaves Black with a material plus.

In the game Schlechter–Perlis (Carlsbad, 1911), after the moves 1 d4 d5 2 c4 c6 3 ♘f3 ♗f5 4 ♕b3 ♕b6 5 cd ♕xb3 6 ab ♗xb1

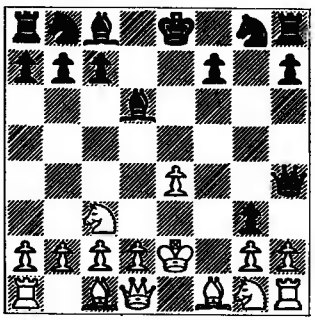
131



Black expected the routine recapture of the bishop, with a rapid draw, but White had other ideas! He played 7 dc! ♗e4 (preventing 8 cb and saving his bishop, but he should have settled for the loss of a pawn instead) 8 ♖xa7! ♖xa7 9 c7 and there was no way to stop this pawn queening.

A similar idea can be found in our next game, Napopov–Rasdobarin (Krasnojarsk, 1969), which went: 1 f4 e5 2 fe d6 3 ed ♗xd6 4 ♘f3 g5 5 e4? g4 6 ♘g1 ♕h4+ 7 ♔e2 g3 8 ♘c3 (not 8 h3?? ♕xe4 mate)

132



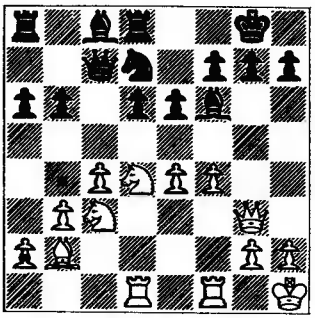
Black simply plays 8 ... ♕xh2! 9 ♖xh2 gh 10 ♘f3 h1♕ and White is a whole rook down.

In our next two examples, the pawn only reaches the seventh rank, but this proves amply sufficient.

Alekhine–Sämisch
Berlin, 1923

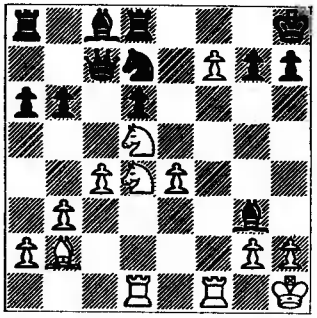
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗e2 e6 4 0-0 d6 5 d4 cd 6 ♘xd4 ♘f6 7 ♗f3 ♘e5 8 c4! ♘xf3+ 9 ♕xf3 ♗e7 10 ♘c3 0-0 11 b3 ♘d7 12 ♗b2 ♗f6 13 ♖ad1 a6 14 ♕g3 ♕c7 15 ♔h1 ♖d8 16 f4 b6

133



Alekhine now conceives the original plan of sacrificing his queen in order to obtain a powerful passed pawn on the seventh rank supported by a tremendous knight on d5. Play continued: 17 f5! ♗e5 18 fe! ♗xg3 19 ef+ ♔h8 20 ♘d5! arriving at a position which deserves another diagram.

134



Sämisch now resigned, a correct decision, as the following analysis shows:

a) **20** ... ♕b8 21 ♘c6 ♗e5 22 ♗xe5 de 23 ♘xb8 ♖xb8 24 ♘c7! ♖f8 25 ♘e6 followed by 26 ♘xf8 and 27 ♖d8 when the white pawn queens.

b) **20** ... ♕a7 21 ♘c6 ♗e5 22 ♗xe5 de 23 ♘xa7 ♖xa7 24 ♘xb6 ♖f8 25 ♘xc8 ♖xc8 26 ♖xd7 and 27 f8♕+ winning.

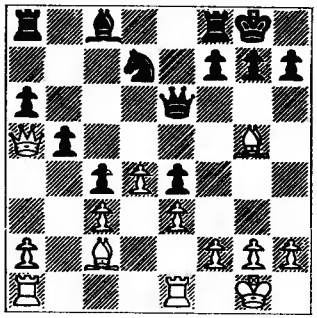
c) **20** ... ♕b7 21 ♘e6 ♗e5 22 ♘xd8 threatening mate and the queen.

d) **20** ... ♕c5 21 ♘e6 ♗e5 22 ♗xe5 de 23 ♘xc5 bc 24 ♘c7 ♖b8 25 ♘e8! winning.

The following position gives rise to one of Capablanca's finest achievements, a classic illustration of the pawn promotion theme. (*See Diagram 135*)

Play went: **17 a4! ♕d5** (hoping to gain defensive time by attacking the loose bishop on g5, but White has a brilliant refutation to hand) **18 ab! ♕xg5 19 ♗xe4! ♖b8** (the first point appears, for if instead 19 ... ♖a7 White has 20 b6! ♕xa5

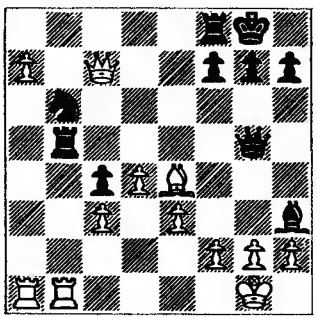
135



Capablanca–Spielmann
New York, 1927

21 ba ♕xa1 22 ♖xa1 ♘b6 23 a8♕ ♘xa8 24 ♗xa8 winning) **20 ba! ♖b5 21 ♕c7 ♘b6 22 a7 ♗h3 23 ♖eb1!**

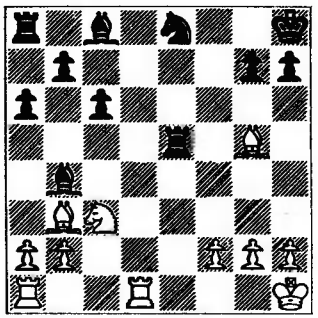
136



The culmination of the pressure down the a and b files, after which there is no defence. The game ended: **23 ... ♖xb1+ 24 ♖xb1 f5 25 ♗f3 f4 26 ef Resigns.**

Tartakower referred to pawns which managed to slip through the enemy defences as 'quicksilver'. Here are a few examples of such heroic foot-soldiers.

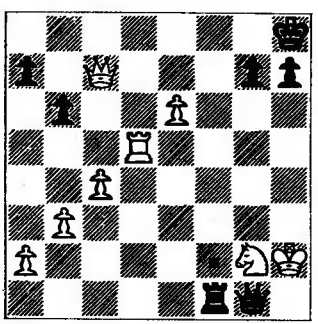
137



Broschait–N.N.
1939

A rapid glance at the position tells us that Black has problems with his back rank. However, the immediate 1 ♖d8 fails to 1 ... ♗a5, so White plans a dramatic advance of his f pawn, thus giving Black no time to consolidate. Play continued: **1 f4 ♖e3 2 f5 ♖e5 3 ♖d8! ♗a5** (forced, as we have seen, but the point of the pawn advance is now revealed) **4 f6! ♗xd8** (of course, 4 ... gf allows 5 ♗xf6 mate) **5 f7 Resigns.**

138

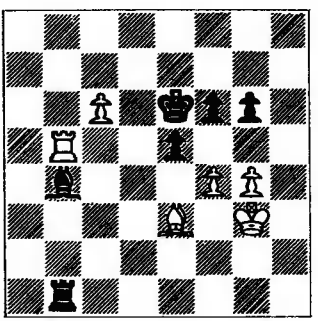


Danielsson–Nilsson
Stockholm, 1952

It looks as though there is no way for White to prevent the draw by perpetual check, but he can force a win cleverly as follows: **1 ♔h3! ♖f3+ 2 ♕g3! ♖xg3+ 3 ♔xg3 h5** (mate was threatened) **4 ♖xh5+ ♔g8 5 ♖h8+ ♔xh8 6 e7** and Black resigned because there is no way of stopping the pawn. Note that an immediate 5 e7 would have allowed 5 ... ♔f7, and if earlier 4 e7 then 4 ... h4+! causes problems, although 5 ♔f3! would probably win in the long run.

Composers of studies have had a field day with the promotion theme, and our next combination could well have been a study, if it were not for the fact that it was played in a game by Vidmar.

139

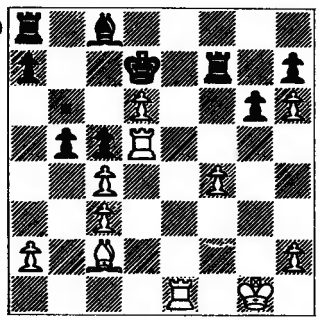


White clearly has the advantage, with a strong passed pawn and a pin on the bishop, but Black is threatening ... ♗e1+ and his king is seemingly well placed to stop the pawn. However, it is all settled by a splendid combination, as follows: **1 f5+! gf 2 gf+ ♔d6** (forced to prevent c7) **3 ♖xb4!**

♖xb4 4 ♗c5+! ♔xc5 5 c7 and Black's king blocks the c file, which means the pawn must queen.

Once pawns are advanced, a player must be on the watch for sacrificial possibilities. Here is an attractive combination which shows White well aware of this fact.

140

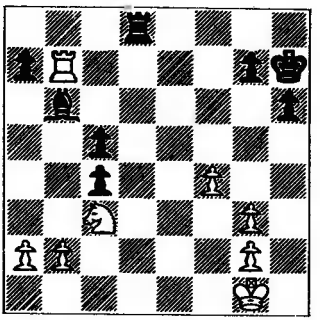


Bouzi–Philippe
Belgium, 1972

Although White's pieces are fully active, Black is on the point of consolidating, so now is the time to strike. Play proceeded: 1 ♗xg6! hg 2 ♖e7+! ♖xe7 3 de+ ♔xe7 (note how everything is forced, but it now seems that White has miscalculated, since he cannot advance his pawn immediately, in view of a bishop move. However . . .) 4 ♖d8! ♔xd8 5 h7 compels Black's resignation.

Our next example is even more incredible, arising as it does from a greatly simplified position in which one might be forgiven for thinking White hardly stands worse.

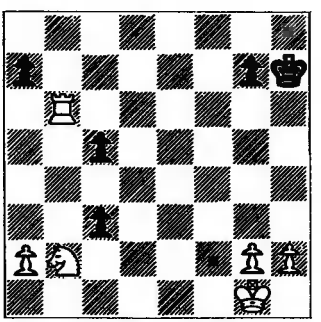
141



Tulkowski–Wojciewski
Poznan, 1931

First comes the natural 1 ... ♖d2 2 ♘a4 when it appears that neither side can make real progress, until Black produces the thunderbolt 2 ... ♖xb2!! 3 ♘xb2 c3. White is aware of the problems and replies 4 ♖xb6! (if 4 ♘d3 c4+ 5 ♖xb6 cd! and the rook is helpless against the two connected passed pawns on the sixth rank, whereas if now 4 ... ab 5 ♘d3 wins for White).

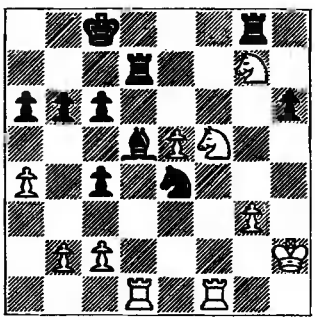
142



Wojciewski, however, has a surprise in store, with 4 ... c4! when the knight cannot capture the pawn without blocking the c file, so White is forced to play 5 ♖b4! to be able to cope with the advance of the pawn or the capture of the knight. Such a rook is clearly vulnerable, and 5 ... a5! gives us a unique case of two pieces helpless against a doubled and isolated passed pawn. After 6 ♘a4 ab White resigned. A veritable 'tour de force'!

Alekhine was perhaps the finest exponent of the power of the passed pawn, many of his greatest combinations being linked to this theme. Here are two examples from his 1934 match against Boguljubov.

143

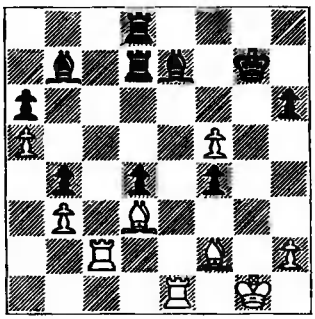


Alekhine–Bogoljubow

After 1 e6 ♖dxg7 2 ♘xg7 ♖xg7 3 ♖xd5! cd 4 ♖f8+ ♔c7 5 ♖f7+ Black had to admit defeat, since his rook is lost.

In the second example, Alekhine had been under some pressure for a long time, and now had the opportunity to produce a startling combination based on that innocent-looking pawn on f5.

144

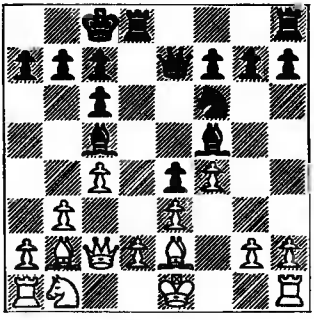


Alekhine–Bogoljubow

1 ♖xe7+! ♖xe7 2 ♗h4 ♔f7 (the point is that Black is threatened with f6+, so cannot play the natural 2 ... ♖dd7, whilst 2 ... ♖ed7 allows 3 ♗xd8 ♖xd8 4 ♖c7+ winning the bishop) 3 ♗xe7 ♔xe7 4 ♖c7+ ♖d7 5 f6+ ♔e8 6 ♗g6+ (White's pieces come magically to life, all with gain of time) 6 ... ♔d8 7 f7 ♔xc7 8 f8♕ f3 9 ♕xb4 ♖d6 10 ♗d3 Resigns.

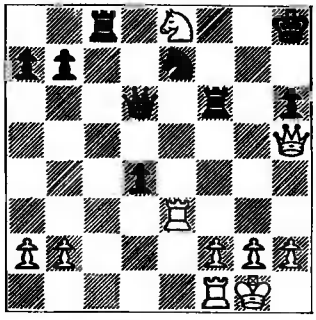
Once a pawn reaches the seventh rank, it must be remembered that it has the potential strength of a queen, given certain circumstances. This is the theme of our next few examples.

145



Larsen–Spassky
Belgrade, 1970

146

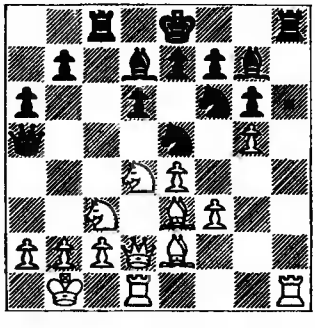


Browne–Tarjan
Los Angeles, 1969

It is difficult to believe that the black pawn on h7 will be on g2 in six moves time, but Spassky has planned a brilliant combination involving the deadly advance of this pawn. Play went: 1 ... ♘g4! 2 g3 h5! (threatening to open up the h file before White has time to castle long and thus forcing the coming play) 3 h3 h4!! 4 hg hg 5 ♖g1 (or 5 ♖xh8 ♖xh8 6 gf ♖h1+ 7 ♗f1 g2 winning at once) 5 ... ♖h1!! (a beautiful and original concept, sacrificing a whole rook simply to advance the g pawn one square further, but of course time is of the essence in this situation) 6 ♖xh1 (the variation 6 ♔f1 ♖xg1+ 7 ♔xg1 ♕h4! shows the pawn linking with the queen in a mating attack) 6 ... g2 7 ♖f1 (or 7 ♖g1 ♕h4+ 8 ♔d1 ♕h1) 7 ... ♕h4+ 8 ♔d1 gf♕+ and Larsen resigned, not wishing to drink the bitter cup to the dregs by allowing the finish 9 ♗xf1 ♗xg4+ 10 ♔c1 ♕e1+ 11 ♕d1 ♕xd1 mate.

1 ... de! 2 ♘xd6 ef+ 3 ♔h1 (of course, 3 ♖xf2 ♖c1+ is hopeless, but now Black cleverly exploits the weakness of the back rank) 3 ... ♖c1! 4 ♕e8+ ♘g8 5 ♕e2 (White has temporarily set up a defence, but now the powerful passed pawn comes into its own) 5 ... ♖xf1+ 6 ♕xf1 ♖xd6 7 g3 ♖f6 8 ♔g2 ♘e7! 9 ♔h3 ♘d5 10 b3 ♘e3 11 Resigns. Tal is yet another skilful manager of advanced pawns, as can be seen in the following example from a simultaneous exhibition.

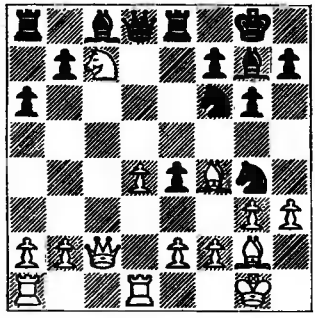
147



Black had to move his attacked knight, but felt he could first interpose 1 ... ♖xh1 missing the point 2 gf! ♖xd1+ 3 ♘xd1! gaining time by attacking the black queen. After 3 ... ♕xd2 4 fg the threat of 5 g8♕ mate forces a massive gain of material.

Less forcing and therefore far more difficult to calculate, is our next example, involving extremely bold play by Black who appears to be giving up a great deal of material for the chance of obtaining a passed pawn on f2.

148

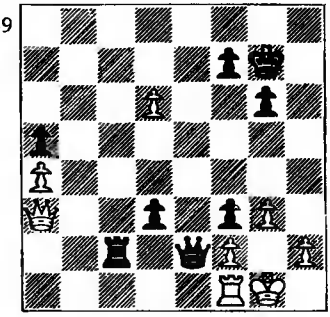


Nezhmetdinov–Timofiyev
USSR, 1969

1 ... e3! 2 hg ef+ 3 ♔f1 (if the pawn is captured, Black has 3 ... ♘xg4+ followed by 4 ... g5 with an easier attack than in the game) 3 ... ♘xg4 4 ♘xe8 ♕xe8 5 ♕b3 h6! 6 ♗xb7 g5! (Black is prepared to go the whole hog) 7 ♗xa8 gf 8 gf ♗e6! (placing the white pieces in awkward situations by forcing the queen to block her own bishop) 9 ♕b7 ♗c4 10 ♕e4 ♕d8 11 ♔g2 f5! 12 ♕c6 (not of course 12 ♕xf5 ♘xe3+) 12 ... ♔h7 13 ♔f3 (leads to mate, but White is lost in any case) 13 ... f1♕+ 14 ♖xf1 ♕h4! and White resigned, because there is no way of preventing mate.

Our final example of the theme is unusual in that there is a passed d pawn on both sides.

149

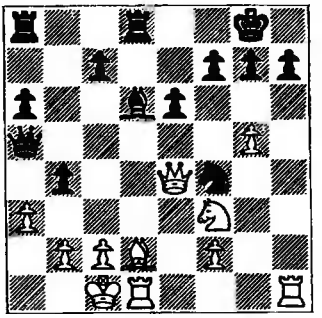


Ermenkov-Sax
Warsaw, 1970

After 1 d7 ♕xf1+ 2 ♔xf1 d2 3 ♕xf3! ♖c1+ Black thinks he has solved the problem, until the startling 4 ♕d1!! puts matters into perspective. Black resigns in view of the continuation 4 ... ♖xd1+ 5 ♔e2 ♖b1 6 d8♕ d1♕+ 7 ♕xd1 ♖xd1 8 ♔xd1 with a won pawn ending.

Now for a couple of examples in which the main role is played by a mating attack, although the passed pawn is naturally involved.

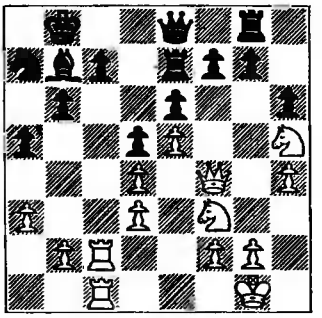
150



Krüger–Schwarzschild

At first sight it appears madness for Black to go into the line 1 ... ba 2 ♗xa5 a2 3 ♕a4, when the pawn is prevented from queening, but the incredibly powerful move 3 ... ♗a3!! puts everything into perspective, since White has no way of preventing both 4 ... ♘e2 mate and 4 ... a1(♕) mate. If 4 c3 a1(♕)+ and 5 ... ♕xb2 mate follows. In our next splendid mating attack, White sacrifices a knight and a rook in order to smash up the enemy king's position whilst creating a passed f pawn which wreaks havoc.

151



Dely–Csom
Budapest, 1966

1 ♘f6! gf 2 ef ♖d7 3 ♖xc7! e5! 4 ♘xe5 ♖xc7 5 ♖xc7 ♔xc7 6 ♘xf7+ ♔d7 (or 6 ... ♔c6 7 ♕c1+ ♔d7 8 ♘e5+ wins) 7 ♘e5+ ♔e6 8 f7 ♕f8 9 fg♕+ ♕xg8 10 ♕xh6+ ♔e7 11 ♕xb6 ♕b8 12 h5 ♘c8 13 ♘c6+ ♔f7 14 ♕xb7+ Resigns.

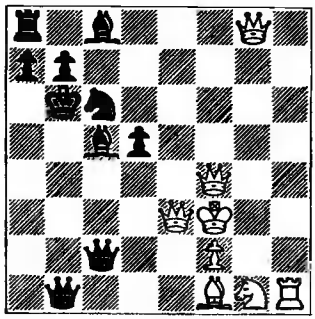
Of course, there are times when more than one promotion takes place, giving us situations which border on the fantastic. We shall soon meet positions containing as many as three, four or even five queens, obviously creating forces which are extremely difficult to control, especially for the defence. In such cases it is vital for a player to obtain the initiative.

To show how this kind of situation arises in the first place, let us begin by quoting all the moves leading to the critical position in a friendly game won by Alekhine.

Alekhine–N.N.
Moscow, 1915

1 e4 e6 2 d4 d5 3 ♘c3 ♘f6 4 ♗g5 ♗b4 5 e5 h6 6 ef hg 7 fg ♖g8 8 h4 gh 9 ♕g4 ♗e7 10 g3 c5 11 gh cd 12 h5! dc 13 h6 cb 14 ♖b1 ♕a5+ 15 ♔e2 ♕xa2 16 h7 ♕xb1 17 hg♕+ ♔d7 18 ♕xf7 ♕xc2+ 19 ♔f3 ♘c6 20 ♕gxe6+ ♔c7 21 ♕f4+ ♔b6 22 ♕ee3+ ♗c5 23 g8♕ b1♕

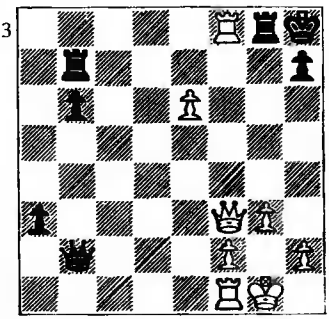
152



In this extraordinary position, with five queens on the board, the most piquant factor is that it is a relatively 'quiet' move by a rook, 24 ♖h6!! which finishes Black off. White threatens 25 ♕d8 mate, and if 24 ... ♕xf1 then 25 ♕b4+! ♕b5 26 ♕d8+ ♔a6 27 ♕ea3+ leads to mate next move. When I first analysed this position, I had reservations about Alekhine's claims for 24 ♖h6, examining in particular the reply 24 ... ♗g4+! when White cannot capture the bishop with his king or his queen on e3. However, I became finally convinced that the great man was right, after considering the following variations: 24 ... ♗g4+! 25 ♕gxg4! ♕xf1 26 ♕b4+ ♕b5 (or 26 ... ♔a6 27 ♕ea3+) 27 ♕xb5+ (the simplest) 27 ... ♔xb5 28 ♕e2+ winning. Or if 25 ... ♗xe3 26 ♕xe3+ ♔a5 (after 26 ... ♕c5 27 ♕xc5+ ♔xc5 28 ♕g2 White's extra piece should prove decisive) 27 ♕a3+ ♔b6 28 ♕d4+ ♔c7 29 ♕d6+ followed by mate in two moves.

The variations which could have arisen from the following position are equally complex and exciting.

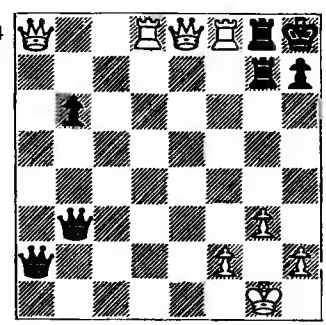
153



Kotov–Matanović
Stockholm, 1952

In the actual game, Black played 1 ... ♖a7 and after 2 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 3 ♕d5! was compelled to resign. However, after the best defence 1 ... ♖g7! we have 2 ♖d1! a2 (or 2 ... ♖xf8 3 ♕xf8+ ♖g8 4 e7! wins) 3 e7 a1♕ (if 3 ... ♖xe7 4 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 5 ♖d8+ ♔g7 6 ♕f8+ ♔g6 7 ♖d6+ White mates quickly) 4 e8♕ ♕1a2 5 ♖d8 ♕ab3 6 ♕a8–♕2a2

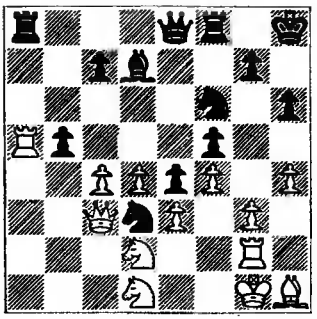
154



There are now eight major pieces on the board, all of which could be exchanged, leading to an easily won end-game for White! However, there is an even simpler win by 7 ♖xg8+ ♖xg8 (7 ... ♕xg8 8 ♕xa2) 8 ♕e5 mate.

We cannot resist quoting the following magnificent example of an unusual queen promotion from one of Alekhine's finest games, even though it does not quite fit into the present category of multiple promotions.

155

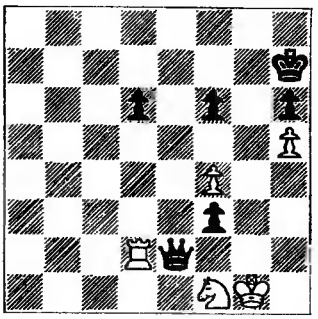


Boguljubow–Alekhine
Hastings, 1922

Black offers two rooks, the last one with check, in order to take advantage of the congestion of White's king side pieces and the weakness of the back rank.

Play went 1 ... b4!! 2 ♖xa8 (or 2 ♕a1 ♖xa5 3 ♕xa5 ♕a8! 4 ♕xa8 ♖xa8 and the black rook penetrates to great effect) 2 ... bc 3 ♖xe8 c2! 4 ♖xf8+ ♔h7 5 ♘f2 c1♕+ 6 ♘f1 (what a tangle of pieces which White can hardly hope to unravel in time!) 6 ... ♘e1! 7 ♖h2 ♕xc4 (threatening to mate after ... ♗b5 and thus forcing White to give up the exchange, which signifies the beginning of the end) 8 ♖b8 ♗b5 9 ♖xb5 ♕xb5 10 g4 ♘f3+ 11 ♗xf3 ef 12 gf ♕e2! (creating a zugzwang position in which no white piece dare move without material loss and in which pawn moves soon run out, a logical end to Black's original combination) 13 d5 ♔g8 14 h5 ♔h7! 15 e4 ♘xe4 16 ♘xe4 ♕xe4 17 d6 cd 18 f6 gf 19 ♖d2 ♕e2!

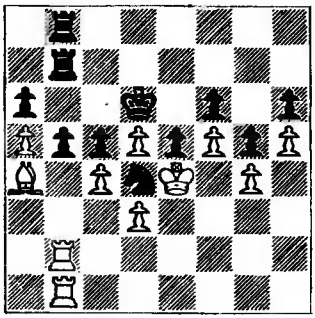
156



Confirming the fatal zugzwang and echoing in amusing fashion the plight of a knight placed on the back rank, as we saw after Black's third move. The rook cannot leave the rank without allowing ... ♕g2 mate and the king cannot move without allowing ... ♕xf1+, so White had to play 20 ♖xe2 fe 21 ♔f2 ef♕+ 22 ♔xf1 with a lost pawn ending.

Our next example, despite errors on both sides, is unusual enough to merit quoting. No fewer than five queens make their appearance on the stage, but never more than two at any one time!

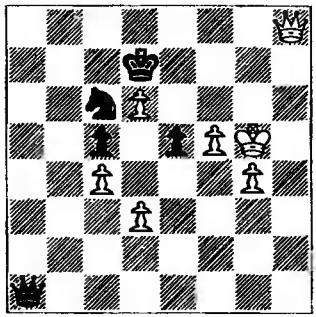
157



Konopleva–Shmitke
USSR, 1968

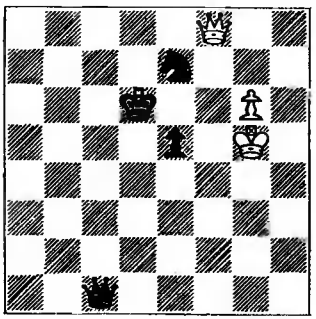
First of all, Black unexpectedly sacrifices the exchange with 1 ... ba! 2 ♖xb7 ♖xb7 3 ♖xb7 a3! creating a passed pawn that will cost White a rook. The question is whether the white king can succeed in penetrating into the enemy position to attack the black pawns, so he first drives the black king back: 4 ♖b6+ ♔d7 5 ♖b7+ ♔c8 6 ♖b1 ♘c2! 7 d6! a2 8 ♖c1 a1♕? (Black is in too much of a hurry to promote his pawn. After 8 ... ♔d7! 9 ♔d5 a1♕ 10 ♖xa1 ♘xa1 11 ♔xc5 ♘b3+! Black would win comfortably, but then we would not have had the opportunity of witnessing the following fascinating play!) 9 ♖xa1 ♘xa1 10 ♔d5 ♘b3 11 ♔e6 ♘xa5 12 ♔xf6 ♘c6 13 ♔g7 a5 14 ♔xh6 a4 15 ♔xg5 a3 16 h6 a2 17 h7 a1♕ 18 h8♕+ ♔d7

158



New queens have appeared, much to Black's displeasure, since his opponent can easily force a draw. However, White now decides to play for a win! 19 ♕g7+ ♔xd6 20 f6 ♕d4 21 ♔h4 (or 21 f7 ♕f4+ 22 ♔h5 ♕h2+ 23 ♔g6? ♘e7+ 24 ♔f6 ♕f4 mate) 21 ... ♕e3 22 ♕f8+ ♔e6 23 g5 ♕xd3 24 ♕g8+ ♔d6 25 ♕d5+? (the losing move; he could have drawn with 25 ♕f8+) 25 ... ♕xd5 26 cd ♘b4! (the knight can return via d5 to stop the dangerous pawns) 27 ♔g4 ♘xd5 28 ♔f5 c4 29 g6 ♘e7+! 30 ♔g5 c3 31 f7 c2 32 f8♕ c1♕+

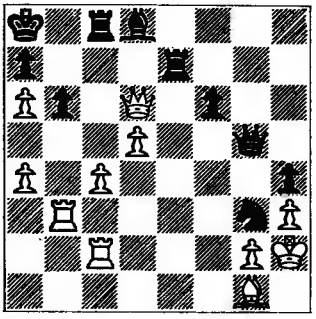
159



The final curtain call from the queens, because now, after 33 ♔h5 ♕h1+, White must resign, the simplest finish being 34 ♔g4 ♕g2+ 35 ♔h5 ♕xg6+ (or even 35 ... ♕h3+ 36 ♔g5 ♕h4+!) 36 ♔h4 ♕h6+! exchanging queens with an easy win.

Yet another Alekhine position we cannot resist quoting is the following:

160



Alekhine–Hofmeister
Petrograd, 1917

A highly complex position in which White is hoping to obtain enough for the sacrificed piece by advancing his queen side pawns. Of course, Black is not without counter-play, as we shall see, and it was clearly impossible at this stage to visualize all the complicated ramifications of Alekhine's 1 c5! which parries both of Black's immediate threats of 1 ... ♘e4 and 1 ... ♘f1+. White can now answer the former with (1 ... ♘e4) 2 cb! ♘xd6 3 b7+ ♖xb7 4 ab+ ♘xb7 5 ♖xc8 mate. However, Black has a better defence with 2 ... ♕xg2+!! 3 ♖xg2 ♘xd6 4 b7+ ♘xb7 5 ab+ ♖xb7 6 ♖xb7 ♔xb7 7 ♖g7+ ♖c7 8 ♖g4! f5 9 ♖b4+ ♔a8 10 ♖f4 with the better ending to White. After 1 ... ♘f1+ 2 ♔h1 ♘g3+ the perpetual check is stopped by 3 ♖xg3 ♕xg3 4 cb! ♖xc2 5 ♕xd8+ ♕b8 6 ♕xe7 ab 7 ♕xf6 with material advantage, or here 4 ... ♖ec7 5 ♖xc7 or 4 ... ♖b8 5 b7+ or finally 4 ... ♕xd6 5 ♖xc8+ ♕b8 6 b7+ ♖xb7 7 ab+ ♔xb7 8 ♖xb8+ ♔xb8 9 ♗f2 when White has a won ending. We advise the reader to have a close look at these variations in order to sharpen their combinative powers, and at the same time examine 1 ... ♖e2! which would have ensured Black the better game. Now let us return to the game!

1	c5!	b5?
2	ab	♘e4

Better than 2 ... ♘f1+ 3 ♔h1 ♘g3+ 4 ♖xg3 ♕xg3 5 b6! ab 6 cb! ♕xd6 7 ♖xc8+ ♕b8 8 b7+ ♖xb7 9 ab+ ♔xb7 10 ♖xb8+ with an easily won ending for White. Or here 5 ... ♕xd6 6 cd ♖xc2 7 de ♗xe7 8 b7+ ♔b8 9 ♗h2+ ♖c7 10 ♗f4 ♗c5 11 g3 hg 12 h4 ♗d4 13 ♗xc7+ ♔xc7 14 d6+ ♔b8 15 d7 ♗b6 16 h5 etc., winning. Note that now the defence 2 ... ♖e2 fails to 3 ♖xe2 ♘xe2 4 b6!

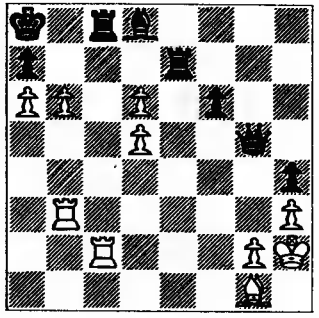
3	b6!	♘xd6

Now that there is no longer a pawn on the a file, the defence 3 ... ab 4 cb ♕xg2+ fails to 5 ♖xg2 ♘xd6 6 b7+ ♘xb7 7 ab+ ♖xb7 8 ♖a2+! ♔b8 9 ♗a7+ ♔a8 (or 9 ... ♔c7

10 ♖c2+ ♔d6 11 ♖xc8 ♖xb3 12 ♖xd8+ with a piece up) 10 ♖ba3! and White must win.

4 cd

161



An incredible position has arisen, in which Black has a huge material plus but White's pawns are far more dangerous. The following brief analysis should convince any sceptical reader that Black's position is really lost:

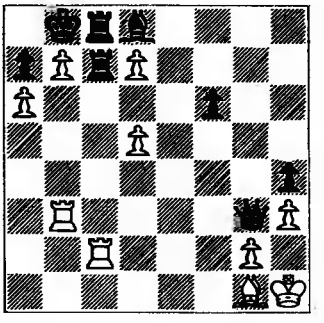
a) 4 ... ♖xc2 5 b7+ and mate in three moves.

c) 4 ... ab 5 ♖xc8+ ♔a7 6 de ♗xe7 7 ♗xb6+ ♔xa6 8 ♖a8+ ♔b7 9 ♗e3+ wins.

d) 4 ... ♗c7! 5 b7+ ♔b8 6 dc+ ♖exc7 (6 ... ♖cxc7 7 ♗xa7+) 7 ♖xc7 ♔xc7 8 ♖c3+ wins, or if here 7 ... ♕e5+ 8 ♔h1 ♕xc7 then 9 ♗h2 is a deadly pin.

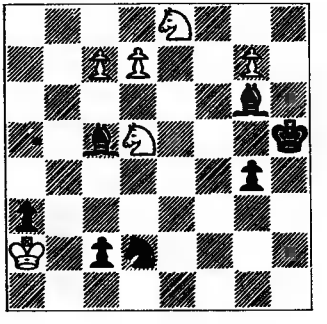
4	...	♖ec7!
5	b7+	♔b8
6	d7!!	♕g3+
7	♔h1	

162



In this fantastic position Black had to admit defeat. Only a chess magician of the calibre of an Alekhine or a Tal could have conjured up such a brilliant sequence. With pawns, however, everything is possible, as can be seen in the following entertaining study by Korolkov.

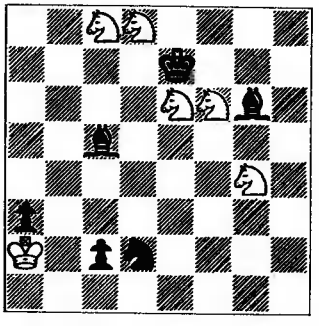
163



Study by Korolkov. White to play and win. The solution runs: 1 ♘f4+ ♔h6! 2 g8♘+! ♔h7 3 ♘gf6+ ♔h6

4 ♘xg4+ ♔h7 5 ♘ef6+ ♔g7 6 ♘e6+ ♔f7 7 d8♘+! ♔e7 8 c8♘ mate, surely a position that deserves another diagram.

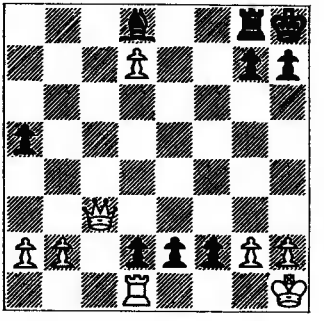
164



Note how ironic it is that Black deliberately chooses a kind of self-mate, because he dare not allow a white pawn to promote to a queen with check, whilst White for his part must not queen without check, since this would permit ... c1♘+! followed by ... ♘db3 mate or ... ♗d4 mate, depending on which pawn queens!

We have already witnessed the power of single advanced pawns, so it is not difficult to imagine how strong two or more connected and mobile passed pawns can be. Indeed, such a phalanx of pawns is often worth the sacrifice of material in its creation, as we shall soon see. However, let us first illustrate the theme with a historic example:

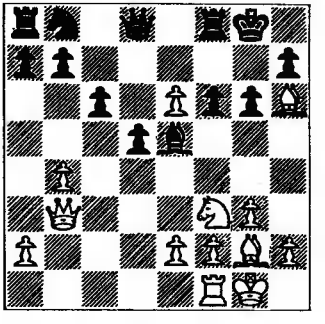
165



McDonnell–LaBourdonnais
World Championship, 1834

This is the final position in which White resigned, having no answer to the incredibly powerful row of three connected black pawns on the seventh rank against which his queen is helpless. Now let us return to the present era.

166

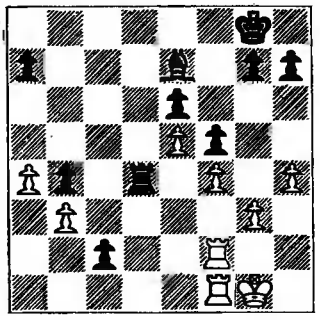


Korchnoi–Diez del Corral
Palma de Mallorca, 1969

White must take urgent steps to utilize his passed e pawn before

Black captures it, but he has even more ambitious ideas in mind, including the creation of two central connected passed pawns. 1 ♗xf8 ♕xf8 2 ♘xe5 fe 3 e4! a5 (clearly 3 ... de fails to 4 e7+ winning at once; if 3 ... ♘a6 4 ed cd 5 ♗xd5 and 6 ♗xb7 wins, or here 4 ... ♘xb4 5 e7! ♕xe7 6 d6+ winning at least a piece, or 4 ... ♕xb4 5 d6 ♕xd6 6 ♕xb7 wins) 4 ed ♕xb4 5 d6! ♕xb3 6 ab ♔f8 (or 6 ... ♘a6 7 ♖e1 supports the pawns) 7 f4! e4 8 f5 Resigns.

167

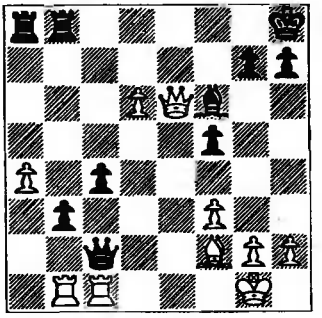


Yurgis–Botvinnik
Electro-workers Teams, Leningrad, 1931

It is well known that a rook is usually helpless against two connected passed pawns on the sixth rank. By 1 ... ♖c4!! Black succeeds in bringing this about with a forced sequence of moves, as follows: 2 bc ♗c5 3 ♔g2 ♗xf2 4 ♔xf2 b3 and White had to resign.

However, that was comparatively simple compared to the next position.

168



Hort–Keres
Bad Oberhausen, 1961

Banking on the strength of his two connected passed pawns, Keres immediately sacrifices his queen, but time-trouble causes problems for both sides.

1	...	♕xc1+!
2	♖xc1	b2
3	♖b1	c3
4	♕e2!	

The only chance of stopping the pawns. After 4 ♕xf5 ♖xa4 White cannot prevent 5 ... ♖a1.

4	...	♖xa4
5	d7	

It is the advance of this pawn which complicates matters. Black should now prevent ♕e8+ by playing 5 ... ♖g8 threatening 6 ... ♖a1. Both players are short of time and understandably make errors.

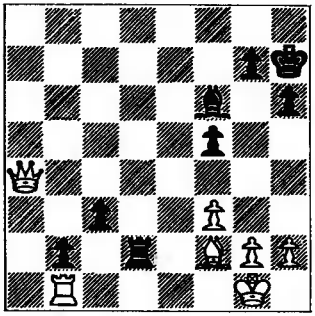
5	...	h6?
6	♕e8+	♔h7
7	d8♕?	

The correct 7 ♕xb8 would have

saved the game, in view of the strong pawn on d7 e.g. 7 ... ♖a1 8 ♖f1 c2 9 ♕xb2! and White is out of danger. Black could, however, try 7 ... c2 8 ♕xb2 ♗xb2 9 ♖f1 ♖a8! 10 ♗b6 ♖a1 11 d8♕ ♖xf1+ 12 ♔xf1 c1♕+ 13 ♔f2 ♗c3! with good practical chances.

7	...	♖xd8
8	♕xa4	♖d2!

169



Black is now threatening the deadly 9 ... c2, which could also be played after the best defence 9 ♕b5 e.g. 9 ... c2 10 ♕f1! (10 ♕xf5+? g6!) 10 ... ♖d5! followed by the transfer of this rook to a1.

9	♖xb2	cb
10	♕b3	♖d8!

Heading for a1 via a8

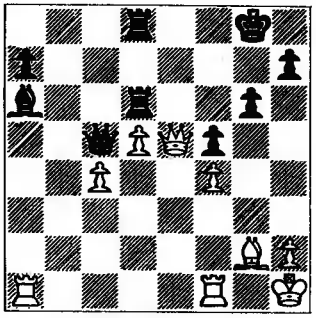
11	♕c2	♖b8
12	♕b1	g6

Black has time to consolidate, because the white king is still stuck on the back rank.

13	g4	♖a8
14	♔g2	♖a1
15	♕c2	b1♕
16	♕c7+	♗g7
17	♗d4	♕f1+
18	♔g3	f4+
19	♔xf4	♕c1+

Resigns

170

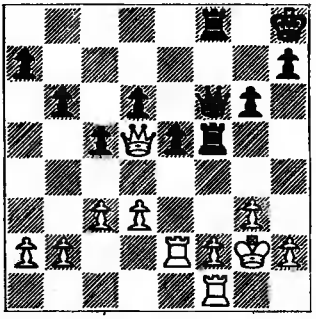


Panov–Taimanov
USSR, 1952

White's apparently soundly blockaded pawns are about to come to life with a vengeance. He plays 1 ♖xa6! to first remove the rook from d6, and after 1 ... ♖xa6 2 d6! forces the exchange of queens because 2 ... ♕xd6 fails to 3 ♗d5+ ♔f8 4 ♕h8+ followed by mate in two moves. However, after 2 ... ♕xe5 3 fe ♖a5 4 ♗d5+ ♔f8 (or 4 ... ♖xd5 5 cd and the rook quickly penetrates to the seventh rank) 5 ♖b1 Black resigned within a few moves since his position is hopeless.

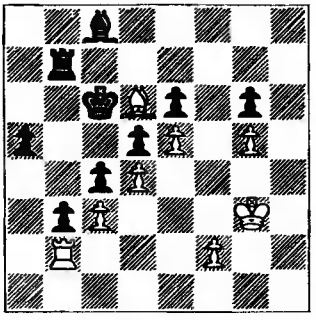
Our next example is even more subtle.

171



Medina–Mecking
Palma de Mallorca, 1969

172



Kmoch–Nimzowitsch
Niendorf, 1927

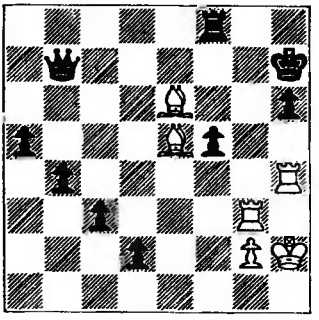
It seems incredible that within the space of a mere four moves Black's two central pawns will have overwhelmed the white position, but a series of strong threats brings this situation about, as follows: 1 ... e4! (this pawn cannot be captured, since 2 ♕xe4 ♖e5 3 ♕g4 h5 wins a rook) 2 ♕c4 d5 3 ♕b5 e3! 4 f4 d4! (all forcing moves have created a powerful protected passed e pawn which ties down White's forces; he should now prevent Black's next move with 5 h4!) 5 ♖c1 g5! 6 cd gf 7 ♔h1 fg 8 Resigns. White's whole position has collapsed.

There is no finer example than our next one to illustrate the unblocking of a pawn phalanx by sacrificial means.

With his pawns blockaded on black squares which are not controlled by his own bishop, Nimzowitsch has a seemingly impossible task, but his startling first move 1 ... ♖b4!! suddenly changes the perspective. Since this rook is threatening to reach a2 and then c2, White is compelled to capture it with the pawn, thus freeing the c pawn. After 2 cb a4! White must play 3 b5+! to prevent the blockade by the king on b5 followed by the advance of the a pawn. Now, however, there are three passed pawns in line, and these prove too much for the rook and bishop. The game ended as follows: 3 ... ♔xb5 4 ♗a3 c3 5 ♖b1 ♔c4 6 f4 ♔xd4 (and now there are four!) 7 ♔f2 ♔c4 8 ♔e1 d4 9 ♔e2 ♔d5 10 ♔f3 ♗b7 (at last this bishop comes into play) 11 ♖e1 ♔c4+ 12 ♔f2 b2 13 f5 ef 14 e6 ♗c6 and White resigned. The quickest way to win is to play the king to b3 when there is no way White can stop the pawns.

Now for a view from another angle.

173

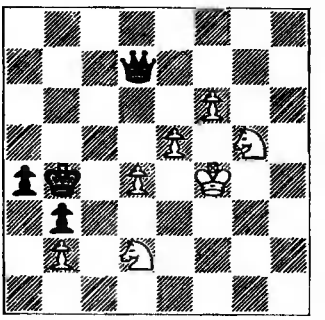


Boleslavsky–Botvinnik
Sverdlovsk, 1943

Here Black has no fewer than four connected passed pawns on the queen side, including one on the seventh rank, but White has more than enough compensation with his piece attack against the enemy king. Play went: **1 ♗f4! ♕g7** (the only viable defence, since 1 ... ♖f6 2 ♗g8+ ♔h8 3 ♗e5 is hopeless for Black) **2 ♖xg7+ ♔xg7 3 ♗b3 ♖d8 4 ♗e5+ ♔g6 5 ♖d4 ♖e8** (exchange of rooks would only help White) **6 ♗f4 ♖e1 7 ♖d6+ ♔g7 8 ♗xh6+ ♔h7** and we have reached the critical moment of White's attack. By **9 ♗f8!** Boleslavsky could have created the final mating net, but unfortunately he only drew after **9 ♗g5?** which allowed the king to escape.

In our next position we have an unusual case of a queen desperately fighting against three connected passed pawns supported by two knights.

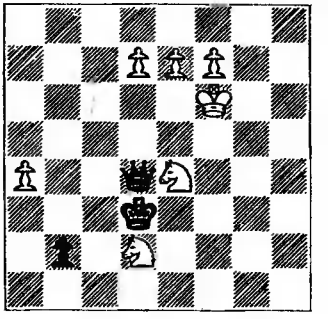
174



Janowski–Ed. Lasker
New York, 1924

The play is easy enough to understand: **1 f7 ♕e7 2 d5 a3 3 ba+ ♔c3! 4 d6 ♕f8 5 ♘ge4+! ♔d3 6 e6 ♕h6+ 7 ♔f5 b2 8 d7 ♕f8 9 a4 ♕a8 10 e7 ♕d5+ 11 ♔f6 ♕d4+**

175



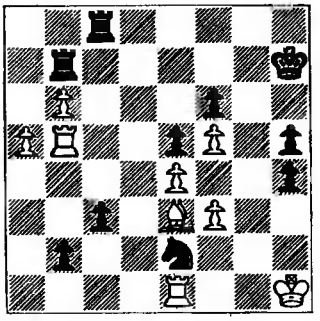
White has managed to place all three pawns on the seventh rank, but Black's pawn is also on the seventh, which makes Janowski's next move critical. Since 12 ♔f5? ♕xd7+ and 12 ♔g5? ♕e5+ are

clearly bad, he has to make the difficult choice between 12 ♔e6 and 12 ♔g6. If we examine the game continuation of 12 ♔e6? b1♕! 13 ♘xb1 ♕xe4+ 14 ♔f6 ♕h4+ drawing, in view of the line 15 ♔g7 ♕xe7 16 d8♕+ ♕xd8 17 f8♕ ♕d7+ followed by 18 ... ♕xa4, there seems no difference between the two moves, because 12 ♔g6! b1♕ 13 ♘xb1? ♕xe4+ 14 ♔g7 ♕xe7 merely transposes to the game conclusion. However, the subtle point resides in the fact that in the latter variation White can improve with 13 d8♕! pinning the queen on d4 and winning against both 13 ... ♕b6+ 14 ♕xb6 ♕xb6+ 15 ♔h7! and 13 ... ♕g1+ 14 ♘g5! etc., whereas after 12 ♔e6? b1♕! 13 d8♕ Black has 13 ... ♕a2+! 14 ♔f5 ♕xf7+ with at least a draw.

The fact that White made an error after all the hard work testifies to the complexity of such endings in which a pawn can be suddenly transformed from a weakling into a tower of strength. Here is the great Botvinnik seeing his way clearly through the complications of the following position. (*See Diagram 176*)

Both sides have connected passed pawns, but Black's are the more dangerous since they are further advanced. He also has the move and can immediately force White to give him three connected passed pawns by 1 ... ♘d4! 2 ♗xd4 ed. Smyslov attempts to get his own pawns moving but after 3 a6 ♖xb6!

176

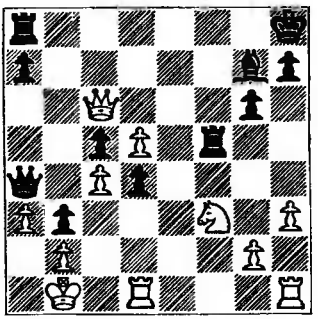


Smyslov–Botvinnik
Moscow, 1941

4 ♖xb6 d3! he thought for 50 minutes without finding a way to save the game which ended: 5 ♖g1 d2 6 ♖xf6 ♖c7! (not falling for the crafty trap 6 ... c2 7 ♖f7+ ♔h8 8 ♖f6 ♔h7 9 ♖f7+ with a draw by repetition) 7 ♖fg6 d1♕ 8 Resigns.

Of course, if a king is in the way of a pawn phalanx, the advance of the pawns is usually linked with a mating attack, as our final example shows.

177



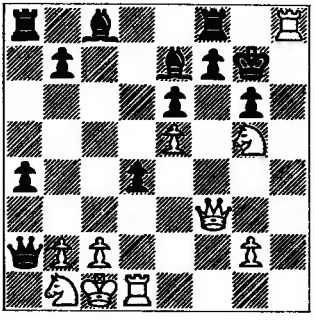
Minić–Rakić
Novi Travnik, 1969

In order to get his pawns rolling, which will at the same time open up the long black diagonal for his bishop, Black is happy to sacrifice a whole rook and even exchange queens, as the following play shows: 1 ... ♕xc4! 2 ♕xa8+ ♖f8 3 ♕xa7 ♕c2+ 4 ♔a1 d3 5 ♖b1 c4 6 ♘d4 ♕f2 7 ♘b5 ♕xa7 8 ♘xa7 c3! (the pawns are far stronger than the rook, so White tries in vain to queen his d pawn) 9 ♖bd1 ♖f2! 10 d6 ♖xb2 11 d7 ♖a2+ 12 ♔b1 c2+ 13 ♔c1 ♗h6+ and White resigned, since 14 ♖d2 b2 mate is a triumph for the pawns!

Let us now turn our attention to another aspect of the pawn's usefulness, its role in many attacks on the enemy king, protecting vital squares in the opposite camp or hemming in the monarch, thus preventing his escape. Once a pawn nears the enemy king, its value is immediately increased, and if it manages to penetrate to the sixth rank, it becomes a veritable 'thorn in the flesh'.

Consider the *white pawn on f6* which has formed the basis of many a king side attack, attacking in particular the g7 square, where a queen may mate or a bishop may ensconce itself or where, more rarely, even a rook may settle, as in our first example.

178

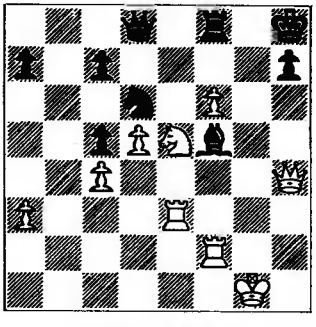


Siegfried–Hünnefeld
1941

By sacrificing his queen with 1 ♕f6+! ♗xf6 2 ♖h7+ ♔g8 3 ef White has fixed his pawn on f6, thus allowing the rook to go to g7 next move followed by ♖h1 mate, or if 3 ... ♖d8 then 4 ♖dh1 and 5 ♖h8 mate is the sequel, with the pawn now stopping the king escaping via g7 or e7. Clearly an extremely useful pawn!

These two black squares also prove vital attacking points in our next example.

179

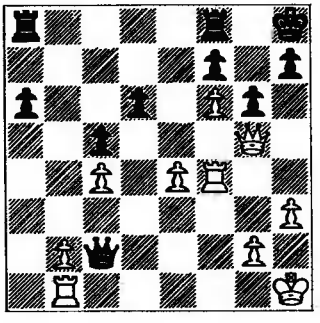


Sämisch–Grünfeld
Carlsbad, 1929

White concludes the game in original fashion as follows: 1 ♖xf5! ♘xf5 2 ♘g6+ ♔g8 3 ♖e7! (in order to answer 3 ... ♘xh4 with 4 ♖g7 mate, whilst of course 3 ... ♘xe7 4 fe once again involves the f6 pawn!) 3 ... ♖f7 4 ♖xf7 ♔xf7 5 ♘e5+ ♔f8 6 ♕xh7 and Black resigned, since his only way to prevent the two mating threats is 6 ... ♕xf6 which loses the queen to 7 ♘d7+.

We see a classic use of the f6 pawn in the following famous finish from an exciting game between two redoubtable players.

180

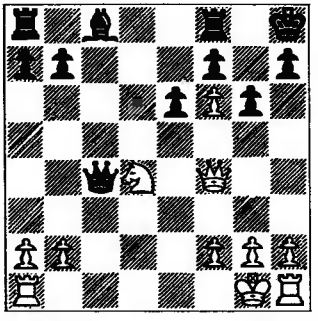


Bronstein–Keres
Budapest, 1950

First of all, White forces Black to 'block' the g8 square by 1 ♕h6! ♕xb1+ 2 ♔h2 ♖g8 and then comes 3 ♕xh7+! ♔xh7 4 ♖h4 mate, now a standard piece of technique in the armoury of any master.

An interesting variant of this combination occurred after a sharp opening in one of my games, arising after the moves: 1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 ♘f6 4 ♗g5 ♗b4+ 5 ♘c3 dc 6 e4 c5 7 ♗xc4 cd 8 ♘xd4 ♕a5 9 ♗xf6! ♗xc3+ 10 bc ♕xc3+ 11 ♔f1! ♕xc4+ 12 ♔g1 0-0 13 ♕g4 g6 14 ♕f4! ♘d7 15 e5 ♘xf6 16 ef ♔h8

181



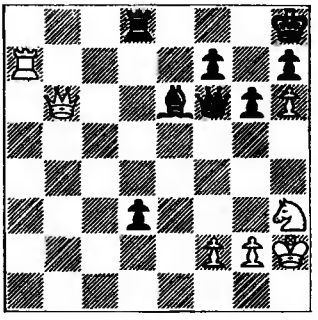
Kotov–Yudovich
USSR Championship, 1939

Black has temporarily stopped the attack but has no way of meeting the final combinative sequence which involves an amusing queen sacrifice as follows: 17 ♖c1 ♕d5 18 ♕h6 ♖g8 19 ♘f3! ♕h5 20 ♘g5! ♕xh6 21 ♘xf7 mate. (It is interesting to note that the first move of this sequence seems not only redundant but even counter-productive, since the immediate 17 ♕h6 ♖g8 18 ♘f3 wins without any problems or frills. For example, if here 18 ... g5 simply 19 ♘xg5 ♖xg5 20 ♕xg5 followed by mate on g7, whereas in the game continuation 19 ... g5 would have to be answered by 20 h4! when White wins, but not so simply. In addition, by 17 ♖c1 Kotov involves himself in messy

'desperado' variations such as 17 ... e5!? 18 ♕h6 ♕xc1+ 19 ♕xc1 ed or 17 ... ♕b4 18 ♕h6 ♖g8 19 ♘f3 ♕xb2, but of course not here 19 ... ♕f8? 20 ♘g5! as in the game. Perhaps he originally intended to play for the mate we saw in the last example with 17 ... ♕b4 18 ♖c3 ♗d7? 19 ♕h6 ♖g8 20 ♕xh7+ ♔xh7 21 ♖h3 mate, but Black has 18 ... e5! guarding the h3 square. I venture these comments in no way to denigrate a fine tactical player but to show the reader how important timing and accuracy are in even the simplest looking combinations. Translator's note).

A *pawn on h6* has similar characteristics, but in this case only the g7 square is under attack and the h file is blocked. We just quote a couple of examples.

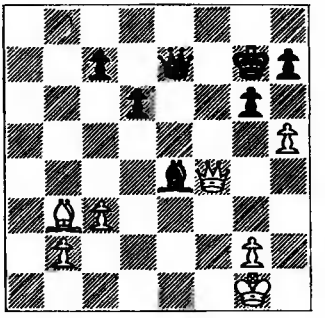
182



Perez–Chaude de Silans
1958

Back-rank mates and threats along the a1–h8 diagonal are in the air, but first White takes advantage of the overloaded black queen by 1 ♖xf7! which cannot be captured by the bishop, when the queen is lost, or by the queen, when White mates in three moves after 2 ♕xd8+. Play continues: 1 ... ♕e5+ 2 f4 ♕d6 but again the overloading aspect is seen after 3 ♕b2+ ♕d4 4 ♖f8+! ♗g8 5 ♘g5! delightfully echoing the Kotov finish above. Black resigned, since 5 ... ♖d7 6 ♕xd4+ ♖xd4 7 ♘f7 mate only serves to pin-point the effectiveness of the pawn on h6.

183



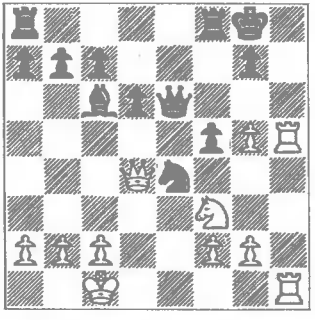
Ivanović–Popović
Yugoslavia, 1973

In this seemingly innocuous position, with queen, bishop and four pawns on each side, it is incredible to find that two moves by White immediately force Black's resignation. First the move 1 h6+! ♔h8 pins the black king to the back rank, and then the startling 2 ♗e6!! completes the study-like finale. Black's bishop is attacked and he can neither defend it with 2 ... d5 3 ♕e5+ nor move it away because of 3 ♕d4+ followed by

mate next move in both cases. Finally, if 2 ... ♕xe6 3 ♕f8+ mates in two more moves. A beautiful combination.

A *pawn on g6* is perhaps the most dangerous of attacking weapons, because it controls two vital squares in the enemy king's territory, f7 and h7, and is usually linked with an open h file, as our first classic example illustrates.

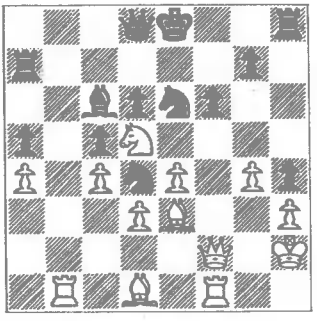
184



Alekhine–Mindeno
Holland, 1933

White would like to play g6 followed by ♖h8 mate, but of course the black queen can capture this pawn at the moment. However, the cunning 1 ♘e5! (threatening 2 ♖h8 mate) deflects the d pawn after 1 ... de (1 ... ♕xe5 2 ♕xe5 de 3 g6 followed by mate) allowing 2 g6! ♕xg6 3 ♕c4+ forcing a rapid mate by ♖h8 as soon as f7 is blocked.

185

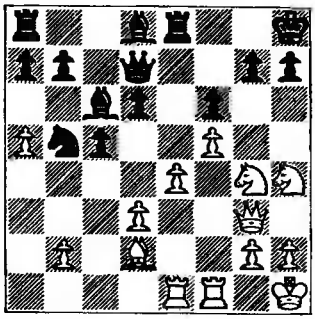


Botvinnik–Keres
USSR, 1966

First of all, the g pawn puts pressure on f6 by 1 g5! 0-0 (1 ... fg allows 2 ♗xd4 cd 3 ♕f5 penetrating Black's position, or here 2 ... ♘xd4 3 ♗h5+! ♖xh5 4 ♕f8+ ♔d7 5 ♖f7+ ♔c8 6 ♖b8+! followed by mate. Best seems 1 ... ♖f7 but 2 gf ♗xd5 3 cd ♖xf6 4 ♕g2! should win) and now White suddenly switches to 2 g6! f5 3 ♖b8! forcing resignation, since 3 ... ♕xb8 4 ♕xh4 mates quickly.

One important characteristic of a pawn on g6 is that it is often difficult for the defence to bring reserves up, whereas White's space advantage makes this much easier for him. Here is a good example of this.

186

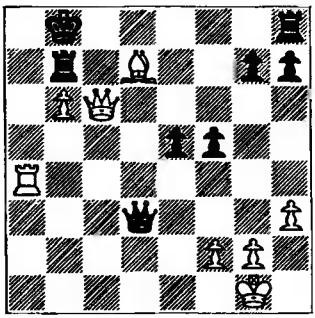


Klovsky–Muratov
Moscow, 1967

1 ♘g6+! hg 2 fg ♔g8 3 ♕h4 ♕e6 (the threat was 4 ♕h7+ ♔f8 5 ♘xf6! ♗xf6 6 ♖xf6+! gf 7 ♗h6+ followed by mate) 4 ♕h7+ ♔f8 5 ♘h6! (this prevents ... ♕g8, but even the immediate 5 ♗g5! wins, because 5 ... ♕g8 is answered by 6 ♘xf6! ♗xf6 7 ♖xf6+! ♔e7 8 ♖f8+! ♔xf8 9 ♖f1+ followed by mate, or here 6 ... ♕xh7 7 gh! and the pawn must queen. Finally, if 5 ... ♕xg4 6 ♖xf6+! ♗xf6 7 ♗xf6 forces mate. Translator) 5 ... ♗c7 6 ♗g5! d5 7 ♗xf6! gf 8 g7+ ♔e7 9 g8♕+ ♔d6 10 ♕g3+ Resigns. The pawn that was assisting in the mates suddenly becomes a queen, a constantly recurring theme in such positions.

Of course, all we have said about White's attacks on the king side also applies to Black attacking with pawns on f3, g3 or h3, and is equally valid when attacks are taking place on the queen's wing, as our final example illustrates.

187

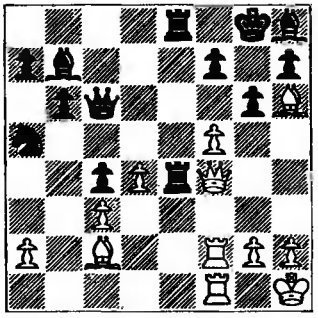


Niedermann–Zucs
1895

Again, this could almost be considered a composed study, showing as it does to perfection the power of the pawn on b6. The movements of the white queen around this pawn are particularly instructive: 1 ♗c8! ♖xc8 (1 ... ♕b1+ 2 ♔h2 ♕xb6 3 ♗xb7! ♕xb7 4 ♕d6+! wins at least the queen for a rook) 2 ♖a8+ ♔xa8 3 ♕xc8+ ♖b8 4 ♕c6+ ♖b7 5 ♕a4+ ♔b8 6 ♕e8+ followed by mate next move.

The pawn is often even more directly involved in mating attacks, even sometimes supplying the actual mate. We conclude this chapter with a few examples of the pawn's prowess in this field.

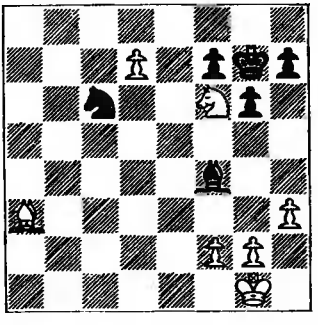
188



Geller–Smyslov
Match, 1965

Watch the f pawn's progress! First 1 fg! opens the f file for White's major pieces. The pawn cannot be captured by the f or h pawn because of mate on f7, nor by the queen because after 1 ... ♕xg6 2 ♕xf7+ ♕xf7 3 ♖xf7 the mate on f8 can be prevented only by 3 ... ♖e1 which allows 4 ♗xh7 mate. If instead 1 ... ♖xf4?? then 2 gh mate follows, so Black is forced to play 1 ... f6 2 ♕g5 ♕d7 (again the queen cannot be captured, because 3 ♖f8+ and mate next move follows) 3 ♔g1! (the best way to win, since it both prevents any back-rank mates and emphasises the helplessness of Black's position) 3 ... ♗g7 4 ♖xf6 ♖g4 (or 4 ... ♗xf6 5 ♕xf6 hg 6 ♕xg6+ ♔h8 7 ♗g5! ♖4e6 8 ♗f6+ ♖xf6 9 ♖xf6 and but for a 'spite' check on e1, showing the reasoning behind White's third move, Black has no defence) 5 gh+ ♔h8 6 ♗xg7+ ♕xg7 7 ♕xg4! and Smyslov had to concede defeat, since the white pawn has the last word after 7 ... ♕xg4 8 ♖f8+ ♖xf8 9 ♖xf8+ ♔g7 10 h8♕ mate!

189

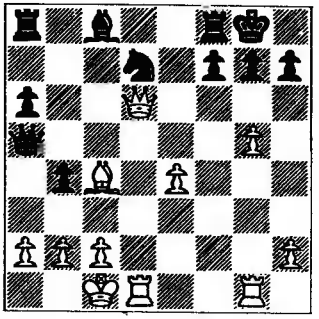


Csom–Ghitescu
Olympiad, 1970

White cleverly combines a king hunt with the threat of queening his d pawn, winning as follows: 1 ♗e7! ♗g5 (otherwise a piece is lost) 2 ♘e8+ ♔h6 3 ♗f8+ ♔h5 4 ♘g7+ ♔h4 (or 4 ... ♔h6 5 ♘f5+ ♔h5 6 g4 mate!) 5 ♔h2 ♗d8 6 f4! followed by 7 g3 mate.

Our next example is much more complicated and, in fact, was not pursued to its logical conclusion by White, after he had begun it so expertly.

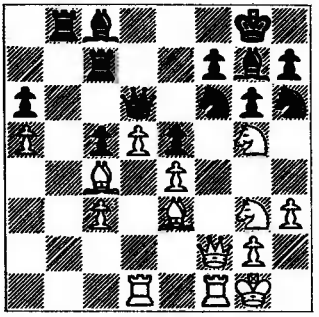
190



Schöneberg–Tukmakov
Zinnowitz, 1967

After the energetic 1 g6! ♕c5 2 gf+ ♔h8 3 ♕h6! ♕e5 (not of course 3 ... gh 4 ♖g8+ followed by mate) White should have continued with 4 ♖d6!! (in the game, Black warded off the attack after 4 ♖d3? ♕f6 5 ♕xf6 ♘xf6 etc.) 4 ... ♘c5 5 ♖g6! and Black is completely lost.

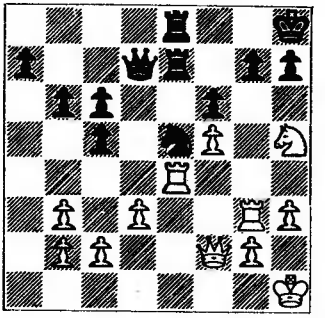
191



Olsson–Holmstand
Sweden, 1969

In the following play, the d pawn is powerfully utilised first to open the d file then the a2-g8 diagonal and finally as the basis for a sacrifice on f7 which completes Black's destruction. 1 ♘e6! fe 2 de ♕e7 3 ♖d8+! ♘e8 (3 ... ♕xd8? 4 e7+) 4 ♕f7+ ♘xf7 5 ef+ ♕xf7 6 ♖xe8+ ♗f8 7 ♗h6! ♗e6 (the only way to prevent mate on the next move) 8 ♖xb8 ♕xf1+ 9 ♘xf1 Resigns. 9 ... ♖f7 .10 ♗xe6 and 9 ... ♖c8 10 ♖xc8 (the bishop is pinned!) are both hopeless.

192



Tartakower–Rubinstein
Moscow, 1925

White's f pawn is freed to advance by 1 ♖xg7! ♖xg7 2 ♘xf6 ♕e7 3 ♘xe8 ♕xe8 when the game is won as follows: 4 ♕f4! ♖e7 5 f6! ♘g6 (or 5 ... ♖e6. 6 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 7 f7 winning) 6 ♖xe7! ♘xe7 7 f7 and Black resigned rather than allow 7 ... ♕f8 8 ♕f6 mate.

5 The Genesis of Combinations

Chess has much to offer to its devotees. Some are enamoured by the crystal-clear logic of strategic plans, others by the complex analysis of theoreticians, but almost everyone delights in an imaginative sacrifice or an unexpected combination. We have already experienced many of the latter but have not yet examined how a combination is conceived, developed and finally realized on the chess-board. We have not yet considered the thought processes of a master, how he selects ideas from the mass of possibilities then heads unswervingly for the position he first visualised. Creative imagination is just as evident in the combinative achievements of a chess-master as in the artistic production of writers, composers and painters. He often has to go beyond the bounds of accepted knowledge, whilst learning to control and discipline his rich imagination within the ordered confines of a successful combination.

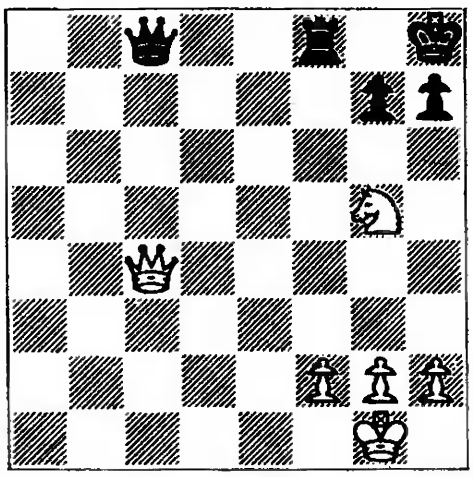
How does a combinative idea emerge? In what sequence are its tactical elements visualised? How are the variations calculated? Why has the final position to be evaluated and how? These are the questions which we shall now attempt to answer.

We have already seen that there are various types of game, ranging from the quiet positional to the violently tactical, but even though the parameters of a combination are defined by the strategic nature of a position the specific idea will often appear with surprising suddenness. Like a painter enraptured by an unexpected juxtaposition of natural elements, a chess-player is wont to enthuse over a combinative idea which suddenly flashes into his consciousness but then has to be carefully evaluated within the context of the given situation. We must, however, distinguish between two kinds of thought processes used in evolving a combination.

Firstly, there is the case of a final position rapidly crystallising from a given idea, when all that has to be done is find the tactical means of reaching this thematic set-up. Secondly, there are those types of position where a player's practical experience, knowledge and instinct alert him to the existence of a combination, even if the precise outline of the final position remains unclear. In this case, a player begins to make concrete calculations until, hopefully, the intuitively sensed combination finally emerges.

Consider the following position:

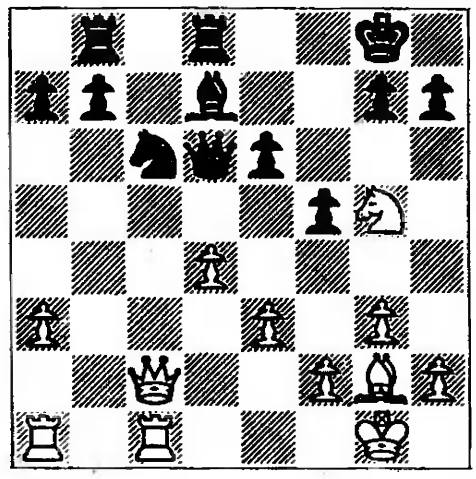
193



Let us assume we have a strong natural player in charge of the white pieces, but one who has never read a chess book and comes upon this position for the first time over the board. He has the move and sees immediately that the black king is so hemmed in by his pawns that, if only there were a black rook on g8, then ♘f7 would be mate. But how can he reach the desirable set-up? At the same time, he knows there is at least a draw to be had by 1 ♘f7+ ♔g8 2 ♘h6+ ♔h8 3 ♘f7+ etc., and it may be at this point that the idea occurs to him that on move three of this sequence he can in fact sacrifice his queen on g8, at a time when the king cannot capture, thus forcing 3 ♕g8+!! ♖xg8 4 ♘f7 mate. He will presumably experience a great deal of pleasure at having found this idea, not realizing that he is discovering America for the second time! What matters to us, however, is the way he comes upon this discovery by visualising the final thematic position.

Alekhine possessed this visualising ability to a striking degree. Here he is, applying the above idea to a more complex situation.

194

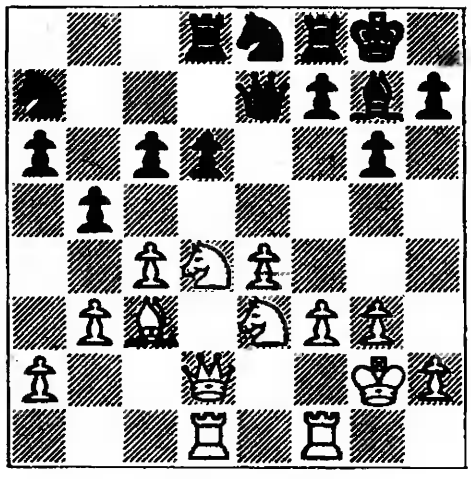


Alekhine–Golombek
Margate, 1935

Immediately sensing the possibilities on the a2–g8 diagonal, he played 1 d5! ♘e7 2 de ♗xe6 3 ♖d1 ♕e5 4 ♗xb7 h6 5 ♘xe6 ♕xe6 6 ♕c7 with an extra pawn and the better position. But why did Black refuse to play 1 ... ed winning a pawn? Because then White planned 2 ♗xd5+! ♕xd5 3 ♖d1! compelling the queen to relinquish control of the a2–g8 diagonal, thus allowing the 'smothered mate' after 4 ♕a2+ etc., now one of the thousands of standard elements of technique at a chess-player's disposal.

Now for one of my own game positions where I can guarantee the authenticity of my thought processes, in simplified form of course!

195



Kotov-Barcza
Stockholm, 1952

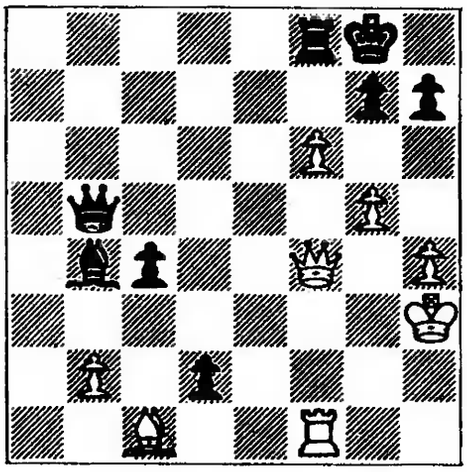
I was firmly convinced that I stood far better, with a strongly centralised position in contrast to Black's passive set-up, his knight on a7 being conspicuously out of play. As a matter of course, a master immediately considers possibilities such as ♘xc6 followed by ♘d5, or playing a knight to f5, but it is quite another matter to work these ideas out in detail. The move 1 ♘df5 in particular excited my imagination, because several positional factors were linked to the obvious tactical virtues: Black's important dark-squared bishop is eliminated, thus denuding his king and increasing the power of White's bishop on c3; the knight on f5 will be extremely active; White's queen can infiltrate via g5; and finally Black's position will remain without any real counterplay. Surely, sufficient factors to make the sacrifice almost intuitively, but I began calculating specific variations in order to make sure there was no surprise in store for me.

After 1 ♘df5 gf 2 ♘xf5 where does Black play his queen? The obvious 2 ... ♕e6 fails to 3 ♗xg7 ♘xg7 4 ♕g5 ♕e5 5 ♘h6+ ♔h8 6 ♕xe5 de 7 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 8 ♘xf7+ and 9 ♘xd8 winning easily. On d7 the queen will later be attacked by ♖xd6, so 2 ... ♕c7 is the only move that comes into consideration. What then? In most lines the defence by ... f6 seemed perfectly adequate, so the idea of preventing this by 3 ♘xg7 ♘xg7 4 ♗f6 suddenly occurred to me. But would not this give Black time to defend against ♕g5 by playing 4 ... ♘e6 at once? I then worked out a win by 5 f4! ♖fe8 (5 ... h6 6 f5 ♘g5 7 ♗xg5 hg 8 ♕xg5+ and 9 ♖f4 mates) 6 f5 ♖d7 7 ♖f4 h6 8 ♖g4+ ♔h7 9 ♕xh6+ ♔xh6 10 ♖h4 mate. This pretty finish encouraged me to examine the position more deeply, so I began to examine the line 4 ... ♔h8 5 ♕h6 ♖g8. Now the plan of f4–f5 seemed too slow, as it would allow Black to counter-attack in the centre, but what about advancing the h pawn to h6 in order to exploit the pin of the knight?

The game continuation shows the practical application of all this, as follows: 1 ♘df5! gf 2 ♘xf5 ♕c7 3 ♘xg7 ♘xg7 4 ♗f6! ♔h8 5 ♕g5! (clearly better than ♕h6 in view of the planned advance of the h pawn) 5 ... ♖g8 6 h4! ♖de8 7 h5 ♖e5 8 ♗xe5 de 9 ♕f6! (the final point of the combination, maintaining the pin) 9 ... ♘c8 10 h6 ♘e7 11 ♖d2! Resigns.

Our next example illustrates one of Alekhine's longest combinations at the end of which he reaches a won pawn ending. It shows instructively how an idea germinates and develops within a master's thought processes.

196



Treybal–Alekhine
Pistyan, 1922

The combination runs: 1 ... ♕d7+! (White would have drawing chances after 1 ... dxc1♕ 2 ♖xc1 ♖c8 3 ♕g4 etc.) 2 ♔g2 d1♕ 3 ♖xd1 ♕xd1 4 ♕xc4+ ♖f7 5 ♕xb4 ♕xc1 6 ♕b8+ ♖f8 7 f7+! ♔xf7 8 g6+! (in the actual game White played the weaker 8 ♕b3+ ♔g6! and the checks were over, whereas if now 8 ... hg? 9 ♕b3+ White has perpetual check or win of the rook by checking on f3, a3 and a8) 8 ... ♔xg6! 9 ♕xf8 ♕xb2+ 10 ♔h3! (the strongest move, but Black still manages to win the ending) 10 ... ♕c3+ 11 ♔g2 ♕d2+ 12 ♔g3 ♕e3+ 13 ♔g2 ♕e4+ 14 ♔g3 ♕e5+ 15 ♔g2 ♔h5! (an advance which is typical of such endings) 16 ♕f3+ ♔xh4 17 ♕h3+ ♔g5 18 ♕xh7 ♕e2+ 19 ♔g3 ♕g4+! followed by the exchange of queens next move, with an easily won queen ending.

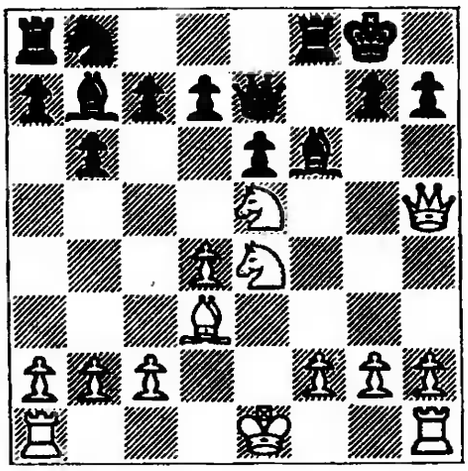
Did Alekhine see all of this from the original position? Almost certainly not, but his thought processes probably ran as follows: I can't capture on c1 without giving my opponent drawing chances, but I'll have to play this if I can find nothing better. What happens if I win the rook for the pawn instead? He then has 4 ♕xc4+ winning my bishop on b4, but I can then capture his bishop on c1, providing I don't play 4 ... ♔h8 when 5 ♕xb4 attacks my rook. So 4 ... ♖f7 5 ♕xb4 ♕xc1 seems fine for me . . . but wait . . . what if he now plays the devilishly cunning 6 ♕b8+ ♖f8 7 f7+! ♔xf7 8 g6+! obtaining perpetual check if I retake with the pawn? I must play 8 ... ♔xg6! with a difficult queen ending in prospect. Still, I would then be a pawn up with an active king, and that's better than going in for the 1 ... dc♕ line, so off we go . . . it's the best winning chance.

Of course, I cannot prove that Alekhine thought in this way, but most Grandmasters would proceed on similar lines, with an equal mixture of elation and dismay followed by the need to make a rapid decision about the envisaged final position.

It is clearly easier to calculate entirely forced sequences, as we see in the following game played by Edward Lasker: 1 d4 f5 2 ♘f3 e6

3 ♘c3 ♘f6 4 ♗g5 ♗e7 5 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 6 e4 fe 7 ♘xe4 b6 8 ♗d3 ♗b7 9 ♘e5 0-0 10 ♕h5! ♕e7

197

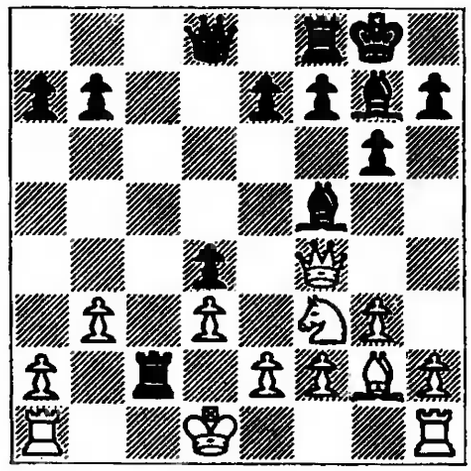


Ed. Lasker–Thomas
London, 1912

Black has played the opening carelessly but has now defended against the threatened ♘xf6+ and is hoping to consolidate. White for his part probably saw the idea of sacrificing his queen in the first place as an extravagant coffee-house gesture, with the continuation 11 ♕xh7+ ♔xh7 12 ♘xf6+ ♔h8? 13 ♘g6 mate, and would only then begin working out the possible king hunt after the better 12 ... ♔h6. It is well known that a king in the open can be highly vulnerable, so it is now merely a matter of calculating a forced sequence, hardly a difficult task in the present position. The game ended attractively as follows: **11 ♕xh7+! ♔xh7 12 ♘xf6+ ♔h6 13 ♘eg4+! ♔g5 14 h4+ ♔f4 15 g3+ ♔f3 16 ♗e2+ ♔g2 17 ♖h2+ ♔g1 18 0-0-0 mate!** (also 18 ♔d2 mate). [White can mate one move quicker by both 16 ♔f1 and 16 f4+ but these are harder to see as Black has choice – editor.]

The next example is more complicated.

198

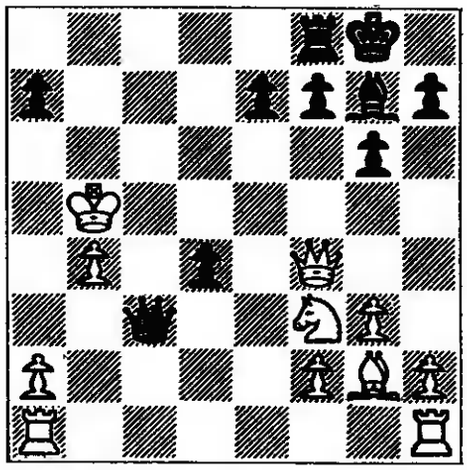


Rudakov–Kotov
Tula, 1939

Positionally, Black's game is far superior, with control of the important c file and the white king no longer able to castle into safety. However, tactically it is not easy to maintain the pressure. 1 ... ♕c8 or 1 ... ♖c3 both allow 2 ♖c1, and 1 ... ♗b2 even loses the rook after 2 ♕c1. Whilst I was pondering these continuations, I discovered **1 ... ♕a5!** with the forced variation **1 ♔xc2 ♕c3+ 3 ♔b1** (3 ♔d1? ♕xa1+) **3 ... ♗xd3+! 4 ed ♕xd3+ 5 ♔b2** (5 ♔c1? ♖c8+) **5 ... ♕c3+ 6 ♔a3** (not of course 6 ♔b1? d3 followed by mate) but the question now remains, how can Black continue? Clearly the white king is exposed, but Black has already sacrificed a rook and bishop, so must be exact in his calculations. If, for example, the obvious 6 ...

♕a5+ 7 ♔b2 d3+ then White plays 8 ♘d4! with an unclear outcome. Finally, I managed to find the 'thematic' solution to the problem and after carefully rechecking the main variations I plunged into the whole line beginning 1 ... ♕a5! and finishing with 6 ... ♕c5+! 7 b4 (7 ♔a4? b5+) 7 ... ♕c3+ 8 ♔a4 b5+! 9 ♔xb5

199

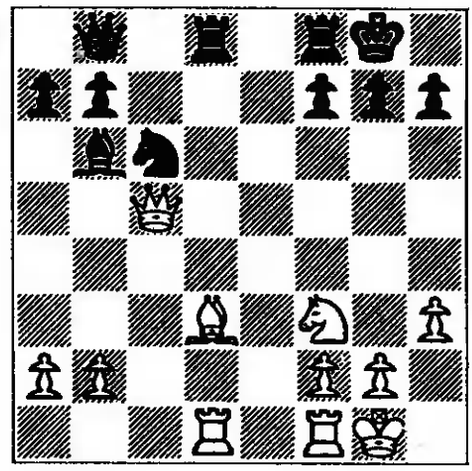


9 ... e5! 10 ♕c1! ♖b8+ 11 ♔a6 ♕xb4 12 ♕c7 ♕a4+ 13 ♕a5 ♕c6+ 14 ♔xa7 ♖a8 mate.

Once again we must point out that the author in no way visualised the final mating position when he played his first move, but he was convinced that the exposed position of the white king on b5 would guarantee the win.

There is one important point to be made before we close this section. A great deal of calculating time can be saved by the player who has a thorough knowledge of basic combinations, since he then can devote his energies to working on the additional or unusual details of the position before him, without wasting time on the obvious. Consider the following simple example:

200

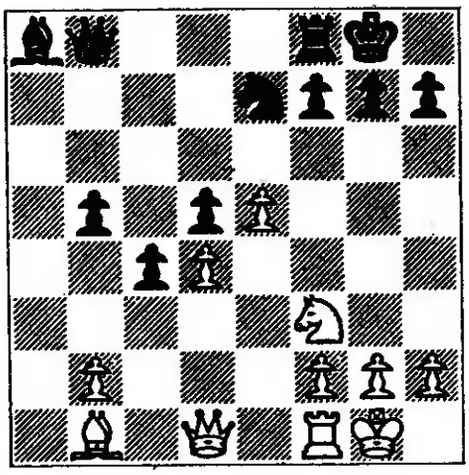


Composed position

Any master can finish off the game almost without thinking, with 1 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 2 ♕h5+ ♔g8 3 ♘g5 ♖fe8 4 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 5 ♕h5+ ♔g8 6 ♕h7+ ♔f8 7 ♕h8+ ♔e7 8 ♕xg7 mate, since it is a standard mating pattern.

However, this typical combination can occur in a multitude of slightly different situations and can sometimes prove tricky when the knight has to check on g5 before the queen enters the attack. On a number of occasions the bishop sacrifice requires precise calculation of concrete variations which may even demonstrate that it is erroneous! White has little trouble in the following example:

201

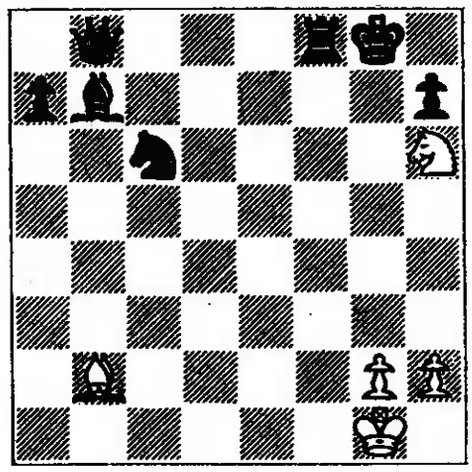


Schlechter–Wolf
Vienna 1898

1 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 2 ♘g5+ ♔g6 (this move is usually the best defensive try in such positions; after 2 ... ♔g8 White wins by 3 ♕h5 ♖e8 4 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 5 ♘e6 ♖g8 6 ♕h5 mate) 3 ♕g4! f5! 4 ef gf (or 4 ... ♔xf6 5 ♖e1) 5 ♘e6+ ♔f7 6 ♕g7+! ♔xe6 7 ♖e1+ ♔f5 8 ♕h7+ ♔g5 9 ♖xe7 ♖g8 10 ♖e3! b4 11 ♖g3+ ♕xg3 12 ♕xg8+ Resigns.

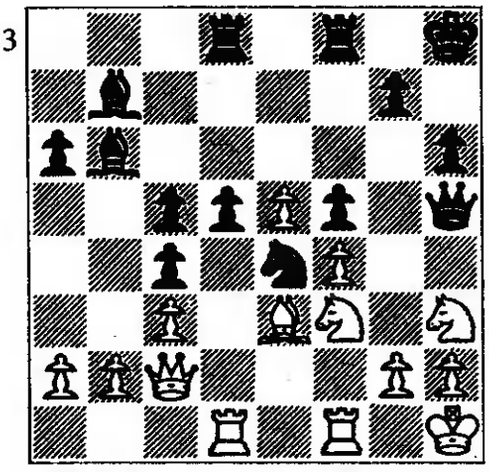
Here is another thematic position:

202



This typical mating pattern is so well known by a master that he can see it beckoning from afar in even the most complex position. Look how Alekhine plans for the key mate in the following position.

203



Thorez–Alekhine
Seville, 1922

Try to visualise the h1–a8 diagonal clear of pieces and the coming combination seems perfectly logical. Alekhine proceeded: 1 ... d4! 2 cd cd 3 ♗xd4 ♗xd4 4 ♖xd4 ♖xd4 5 ♘xd5 ♕xh3! 6 gh ♘f2+ 7 ♔f1 ♘xh3 mate!

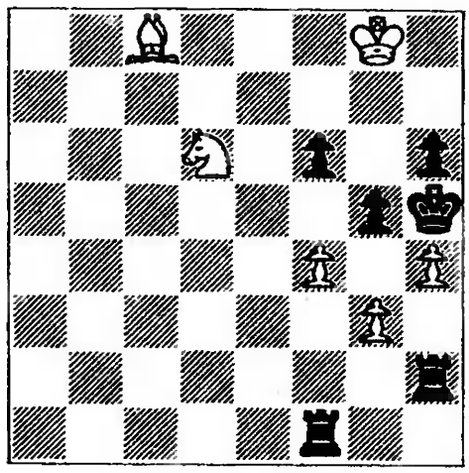
6 Combinations Exploiting Piece Placings

A master realizes the importance of positioning his pieces correctly, not only to give them maximum effectiveness but also to make sure that they are working together harmoniously. Once a piece becomes separated from its colleagues or lands itself in an exposed or uncomfortable situation, it immediately becomes vulnerable to the kinds of attack we shall be examining in this chapter. A player must learn to sense and exploit such situations, so we can only hope that the following examples will help to increase his awareness of the issues involved.

The double-attack

'Fork' is perhaps the most apt description of this attack on two pieces at the same time, often leading to the capture of one of them. The smallest unit, the pawn, is by its very nature one of the most dangerous exponents of the double-attack, since any piece is usually stronger than it. The following study is a drastic illustration of the theme.

204

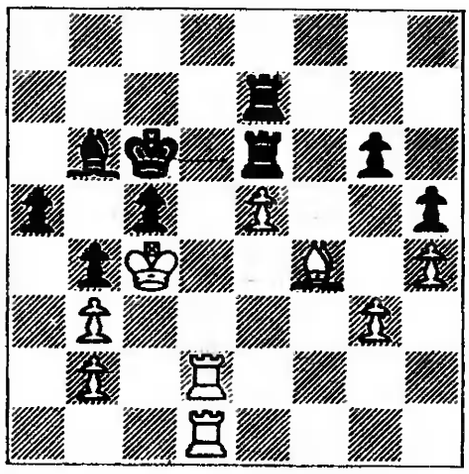


Study by Kasparian

1 ♘e8! (threatening 2 ♘g7+ and 3 ♗f5 mate) 1 ... ♔g6 2 h5+! ♖xh5 3 f5+ ♖xf5 4 g4! (the fork appears) 4 ... ♖e5 5 ♗f5+! ♖xf5 6 ♘g7! forcing mate on either f5 or h5.

In our next position, White exploits the pawn fork in unusual fashion.

205

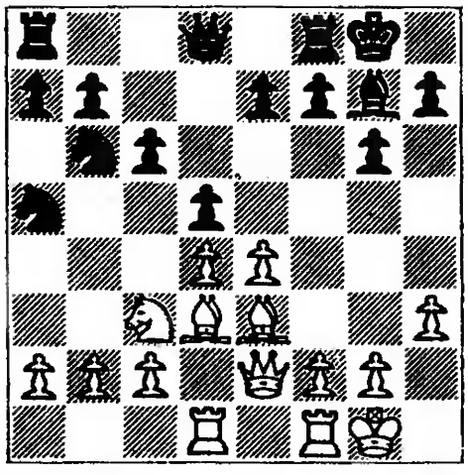


Matz–Freiberg
Frankfurt, 1931

After 1 ♖d6+ ♔c7 the move 2 ♔d5! forces Black's resignation. His rook on e6 is attacked, and 2 ... ♖xd6 loses to 3 exd6+ forking king and rook.

The pawn fork is particularly useful in the opening stages, where pieces occupying the centre are often exposed to attack. Here is an instructive example from my own repertoire.

206

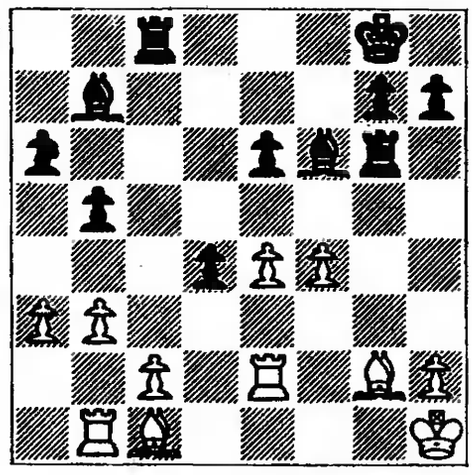


Hörberg–Kotov
Stockholm, 1959

Chances appear even, with the white pieces seemingly better centralised, but the very placing of the knight on c3 and bishop on e3 gave me the idea of a possible pawn fork on d4. The sudden collapse of White's game is astonishing. Play went: 1 ... e5! 2 ed (or 2 de d4 3 b4 de 4 ba ef+ 5 ♕xf2 ♗xe5 winning) 2 ... ed 3 dc ♘xc6! (far better than 3 ... de 4 cb followed by 5 ♗xg6 with compensation for the piece) 4 ♗b5 ♕c7 5 ♗xc6 dc 6 ♗e4 cb 7 ♗d4? b1♕ 8 Resigns.

We have already seen how effective a bishop fork can be in the Reti–Alekhine game finish (diagram 126) where a rook and knight were neatly 'pronged', with neither able to defend the other. Here is another splendid illustration of the theme linked with clever sub-play.

207



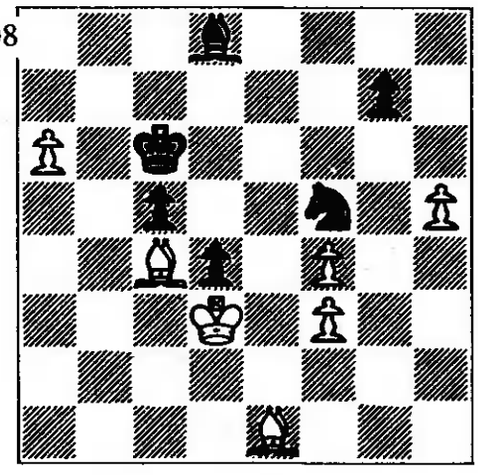
Fiensch–Postler
East Germany, 1969

The geometric position of the pawn on c2 and the bishop on g2,

in conjunction with the placing of the white king and rooks, immediately points to e4 as the critical square. Black can hardly resist the invitation to play 1 ... ♖xg2! 2 ♔xg2 ♖xc2! 3 ♖xc2 (3 ♔f3 would offer more resistance, but 3 ... ♖c3+! followed by the advance of the d pawn should win) 3 ... ♗xe4+ 4 ♔f1 ♗xc2 5 ♖b2 d3 6 ♖xc2 dc and although White can pick up the c pawn the ending is easily won for Black. Perhaps White missed the neat point that 6 ♖a2 loses at once to 6 ... d2! 7 ♗xd2 ♗xb3 winning a piece.

A so-called 'skewer' is an interesting form of double-attack, linked in our next example with the theme of deflection which we shall meet later.

208

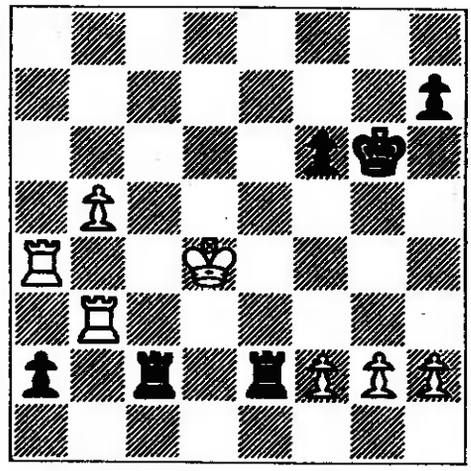


Composed position

Firstly, 1 ♗d5+! forces 1 ... ♔b6, as the capture of the bishop would allow the advance of the pawn, and then 2 ♗a5+! completes the picture with a double-attack and deflection combined. Black must lose a piece.

The rook's forking ability is usually seen at its best in the ending, when it is most effective at picking up loose pawns in this way. In fact, in the following position it looks as though Black must be satisfied with the capture of the f pawn, which would hardly win for him.

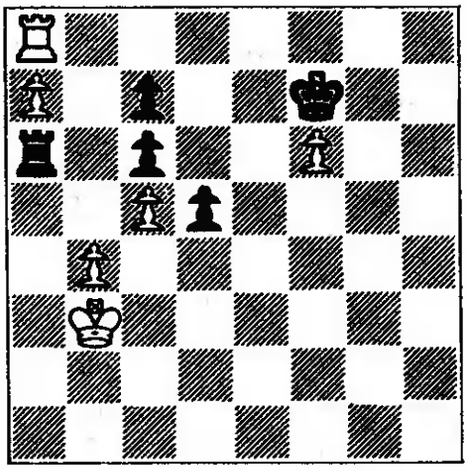
209



Composed position

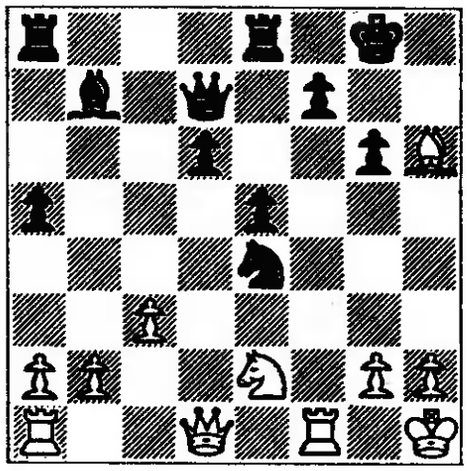
However, once again a mixture of double-attack and deflection brings about an attractive finish as follows: 1 ... ♖c4+! 2 ♔xc4 ♖e4+ and 3 ... ♖xa4 queening the pawn.
Here is a typical winning method often seen in rook and pawn endings but brought about in this position in cunning fashion.

210



Alekhine–Spielmann
New York, 1927

211



Composed position

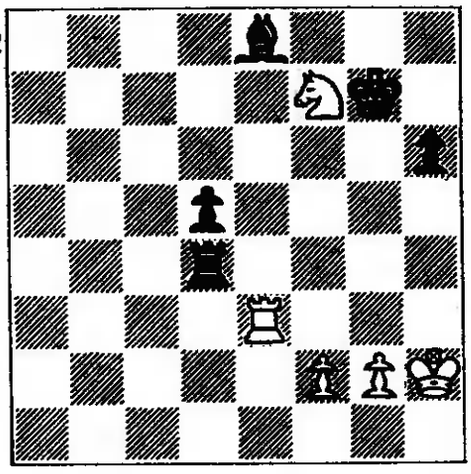
1 b5! cb 2 ♔b4 c6 (the only alternative is 2 ... d4 but White can then simply play 3 ♔xb5 ♖a1 4 ♔c4 ♖a4+ 5 ♔d3! and Black is in zugzwang) **3 ♖h8! ♖xa7 4 ♖h7+ Resigns.**

Since the queen combines the powers of the rook and bishop, it is clearly the most dangerous exponent of the double-attack theme, as many opening traps reveal e.g. 1 e4 c5 2 d4 cd 3 ♘f3 e5?! 4 ♘xe5?? ♕a5+ and White loses a piece. We shall restrict ourselves to one example in which the diagonal and vertical movement combine to bring about by force a mate with which the reader should be by now thoroughly acquainted.

Black plays **1 ... ♕h3!** threatening both the bishop and 2 ... ♘g3+ followed by 3 ... ♕xg2 mate, so White replies **2 gh** allowing **2 ... ♘f2+ 3 ♔g1 ♘xh3 mate.**

I have deliberately left the knight until last and make no apologies for giving it pride of place in this section on the double-attack, in view of its bewildering zig-zag movement which even masters sometimes find difficult to control. This factor makes the knight the tactician's favourite piece in a double-attack situation, since it often seems to pop up out of nowhere. But that is enough talk. Let us see it in action, firstly in a position full of the double-attack theme.

212

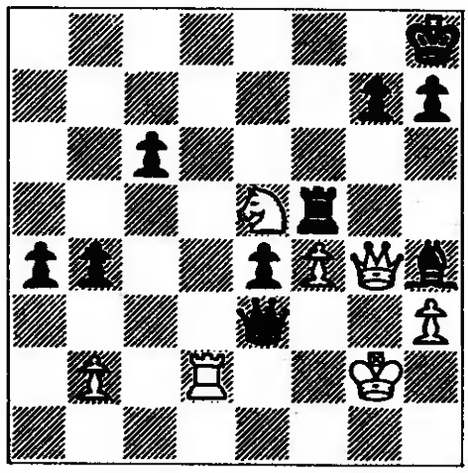


Composed position

1 ♘d6! forces 1 ... ♗d7 2 ♖e7+ ♔f6 3 ♖xd7 when Black hopes that 3 ... ♔e6 will regain the piece. However, after 4 ♖d8! he sees that 4 ... ♔e7 loses to the knight fork on f5.

Now for a touch of magic.

213

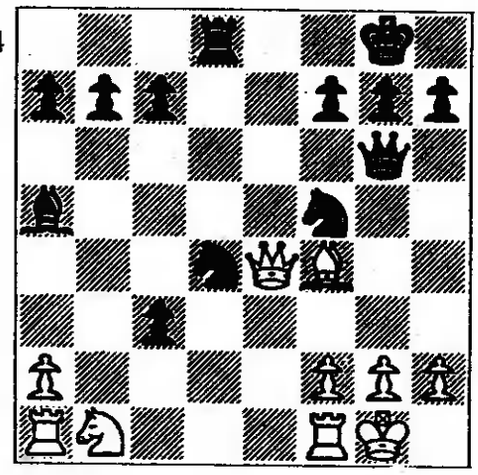


Composed position

Since the white rook is under attack and 1 ♖e2 fails to 1 ... ♕xf4, White needs a minor miracle to win. In fact, a back-rank mate, a pin and principally the placing of Black's rook and queen are the factors which give White a win as follows: 1 ♘f7+! ♔g8 (1 ... ♖xf7 allows 2 ♕c8+ and mate in 2) 2 ♘h6+ ♔h8 3 ♕xg7+! ♔xg7 4 ♘xf5+ and 5 ♘xe3.

I cannot resist the following classic finish:

214

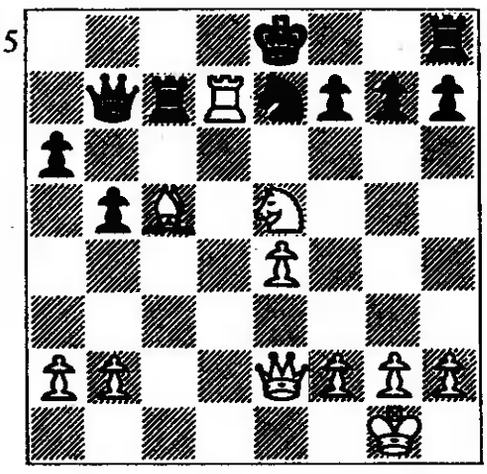


Marache–Morphy
New York, 1857

1 ... ♘g3! is an unusual form of the double-attack, involving a 'discovery' of the piece behind the knight, the black queen, which attacks the white queen and thus gives White no time to defend against the even deadlier threat of 2 ... ♘de2 mate!

Boleslavsky exploits the knight fork magnificently in our next example.

215

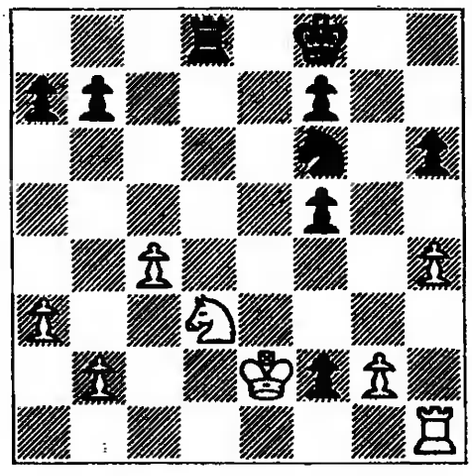


Boleslavsky–Dzhindzhivhashvili
1969

If White's knight could check on d6, with the black king on e8 or c8, Black's queen would be lost. This idea lies behind the sequence: 1 ♖d8+! ♔xd8 2 ♘xf7+! ♔d7 3 ♕g4+! ♔c6 4 ♕e6+ and Black resigned in view of 4 ... ♔xc5 5 ♕d6+ ♔c4 6 ♘e5 mate. The knight fork never came into operation but it formed a vital part of the combination!

Passed pawns on the seventh rank are particularly useful with a knight about which can either control the queening square or prevent the approach of the enemy king. Here is a typical example of the knight's agility in such situations.

216

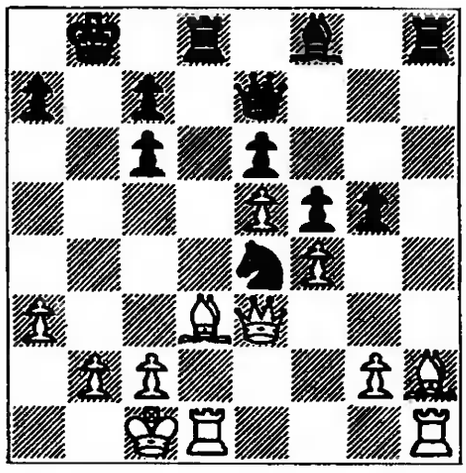


Gliksman–Sokolov
Kraljevo, 1967

1 ... ♘h5! threatening a check on g3 practically forces 2 ♖d1 when Black immediately wins a piece with 2 ... ♖xd3! since if the rook recaptures then the knight forks king and rook on f4. After 3 ♔xd3 ♘g3 White resigned.

It is well worth studying the mechanism of the following example, because in essence it has appeared in a number of finishes.

217

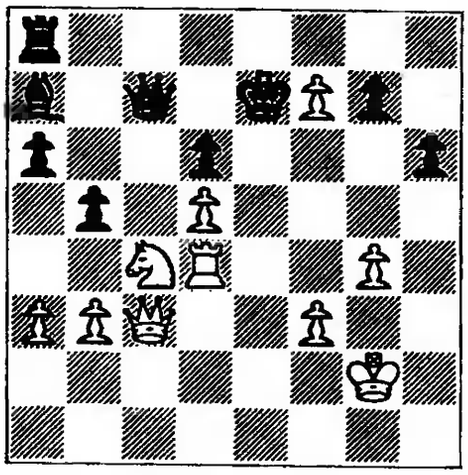


Andreyev–Dolukhanov
Leningrad, 1935

First of all, Black deflects the rook on h1 by 1 ... ♖xh2! 2 ♖xh2 in order to leave the other rook unguarded. He then plays 2 ... ♕xa3! 3 ba (if 3 ♔b1 ♘c3+! 4 bc ♔a8 and 5 ... ♖b8+ wins) 3 ... ♗xa3+ 4 ♔b1 and now comes the whole point: 4 ... ♘c3+ 5 ♔a1 ♗b2+! forcing the king onto the critical b2 square so that 6 ♔xb2 ♘xd1+ wins back the queen with a won ending.

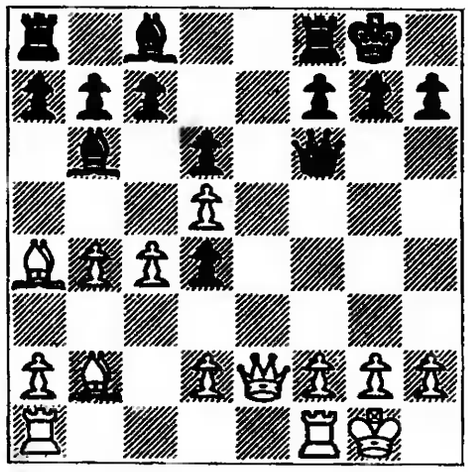
Our next example is an even more brilliant illustration of the same mechanism, but it is complicated by other factors such as the discovery tactic and a passed pawn on the seventh rank.

218



Composed position

219

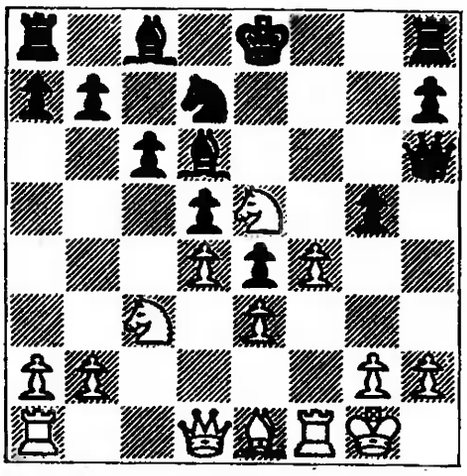


Opening variation

At the moment, White's knight is pinned, but this very pin turns out to be more of an embarrassment to Black. Play goes: 1 ♖e4+ ♔f8 (if 1 ... ♔xf7 2 ♘e5+ wins the queen, and 1 ... ♔d7 2 ♕xg7 is clearly lost for Black) 2 ♘xd6! ♕xd6 (it is clear that 2 ... ♕xc3 allows 3 ♖e8+ ♖xe8 4 fe♕ mate, but why has White given up his knight? We shall soon see that White wants the black queen on d6 for a specific reason . . .) 3 ♖e8+ ♖xe8 4 ♕xg7+! ♔xg7 5 fe♘+! ♔f7 6 ♘xd6+ and once again a won ending is reached.

1 ... d3! immediately wins a piece, since White's queen and bishop are both threatened at the same time and if 2 ♗xf6 de the double threat proves fatal.

220

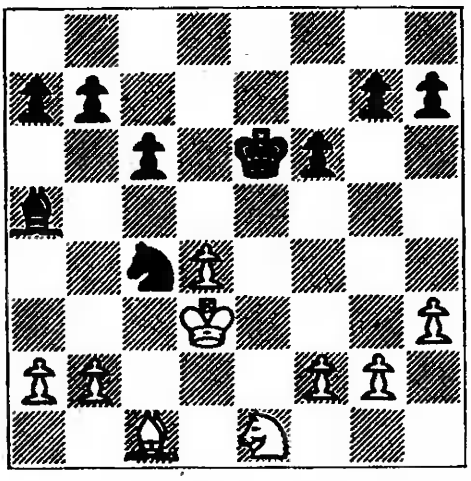


Opening variation

In diagram 214 we saw how two threats were involved in the movement of the knight, giving us a peculiar form of double-attack in which two pieces take part. Let us consider a few more of this type.

After 1 ♘f7! Black is forced to give up the exchange, because 1 ... ♔xf7 loses to 2 fg+ winning the queen.

221

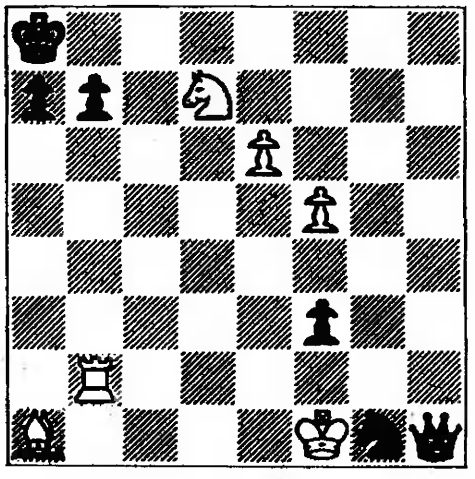


Lasker-Euwe
Nottingham, 1936

By 1 b4! ♗xb4 2 ♘c2 White creates a winning double-attack, after which Black must lose a piece.

Strictly speaking, this position and our next one are difficult to classify, having an element of the decoy about them, as a piece is lured onto a critical square. Consider the following:

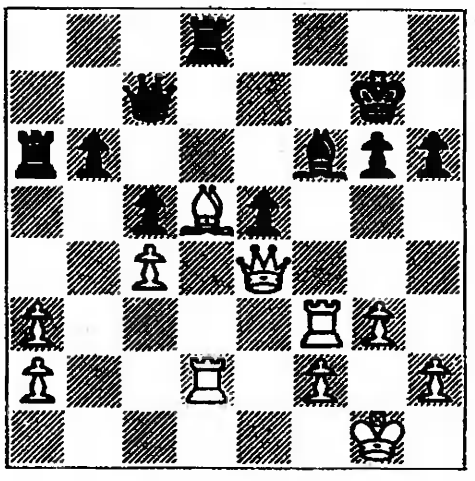
222



Friedman-Thomson
Canada, 1949

After 1 ♘b6+! ♔b8 (1 ... ab 2 ♖a2+ ♔b8 3 ♗e5+ and 4 ♖a8 mate) the move 2 ♖h2! threatens both the queen and ♗e5 mate, the point being that 2 ... ♕xh2 loses to the second decoy 3 ♗e5+! ♕xe5 followed by the knight fork on d7 winning the queen and the game. A delightful conjuring trick!

223

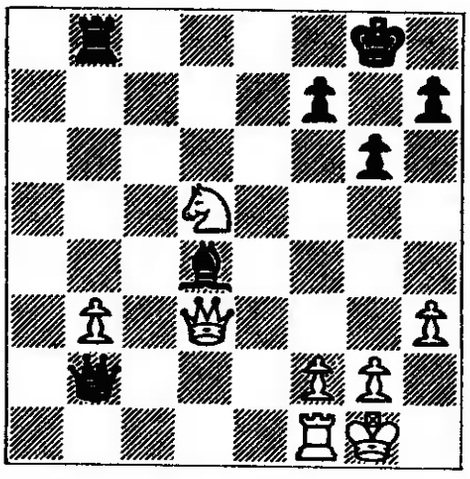


Stahlberg-Najdorf
Buenos Aires, 1947

1 ♗f7! releases the power of the rook on d2 whilst attacking g6, as seen in the variation 1 ... ♖xd2 2 ♕xg6+ ♔f8 3 ♕g8+ ♔e7 4 ♕e8+ ♔d6 5 ♖xf6 mate and the fact that 1 ... ♕xf7 fails to 2 ♖xd8. The main point comes, however, after 1 ... ♔xf7 2 ♖xd8 ♕xd8 3 ♕b7+ when the double-attack wins the rook on a6.

Our final example of the double-attack theme contains a wealth of intresting play, coming as it does from a fascinating match between two great players.

224



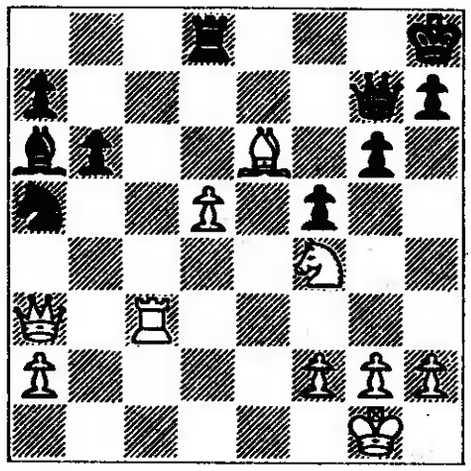
Alekhine–Euwe
World Championship, 1937

Despite White's extra pawn, it seems difficult for him to make progress against Black's coordinated pieces. It is finally the knight which brings about the minor miracle in the following imaginative sequence: 1 ♘e7+ ♔f8 2 ♘c6 ♗xf2+ (Black counters the double-attack with a move that would produce a double-attack for him after 3 ♖xf2 ♕c1+ and 4 ... ♕xc6, but Alekhine can now exploit the f file) 3 ♔h2! ♖e8 4 ♕f3! (indirectly aiming at f7) 4 ... ♖e2 5 ♘d4! ♖d2 6 ♘e6+ ♔e7 7 ♘f4 (and suddenly a new threat of 8 ♘d3 appears, yet another double-attack!) 7 ... ♕d4 8 ♔h1! (preventing a check and therefore threatening 9 ♘e2 winning at once) 8 ... ♖a2 9 ♘e2 ♖a1 (Euwe has to give up the queen) 10 ♕b7+ ♔f6 11 ♘xd4 ♖xf1+ 12 ♔h2 ♗g1+ 13 ♔g3 ♗f2+ 14 ♔f3 ♗d4+ 15 ♔e4 ♖d1 16 ♕d5 (or even more thematic 16 ♕c6+ and 17 ♕c2 winning) and Black finally had to admit defeat.

Unmasking

We have already met examples of the power of a masked piece unleashed when a piece or a pawn in front of it suddenly moves away, as in diagrams 219 and 220, but let us now examine this theme a little more closely. We begin with a player deliberately setting up such a mechanism because of its latent strength.

225

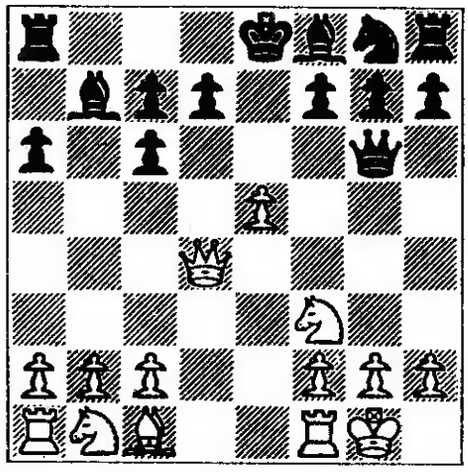


Furman–Smyslov
Moscow, 1949

1 ♕b2! immediately threatens 2 ♘xg6+ hxg6 3 ♖h3 mate, and although Smyslov finds the best defence by offering a pawn he lost after 1 ... ♘c4 2 ♘xg6+ ♕xg6 3 ♖xc4+ ♕g7 4 ♕xg7+ ♔xg7 5 ♖c7+ ♔f6 6 f4! etc.

Or consider the following:

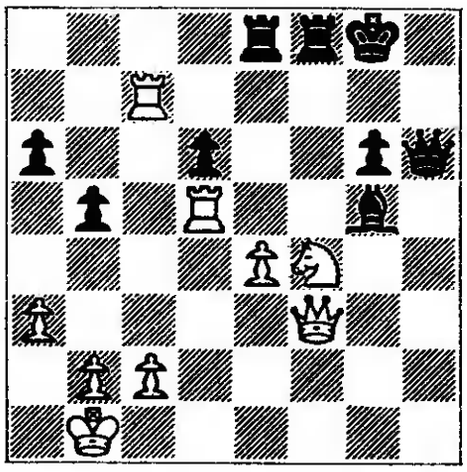
226



Opening variation

White is convinced that his opponent is lost after 1 e6 because 1 ... ♕xe6 fails to 2 ♖e1 and 1 ... fxe6 2 ♘e5 attacks d7 and the queen. However, in the latter variation Black has the startling 2 ... ♕xg2+! 3 ♔xg2 c5+! unmasking the bishop on the king and at the same time attacking the queen, thus reaching a won ending.

227

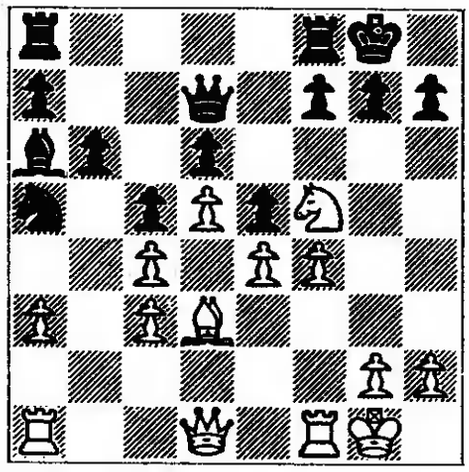


Fischer–Bolbochan
Stockholm, 1962

With 1 ♕b3! White sets up a deadly mating attack. If now 1 ... ♔h8 Fischer has 2 ♘xg6+! ♕xg6 3 ♖xg5 ♖f1+ 4 ♔a2 ♕xg5 5 ♕h3+ followed by mate. The game ended: 1 ... ♖xf4 2 ♖e5+! ♔f8 3 ♖xe8+ Resigns (after 3 ... ♔xe8 4 ♕e6+ it is mate next move).

Our next example illustrates a tactical trap well worth remembering, since it often occurs within analysis of various forms of king side attacks.

228

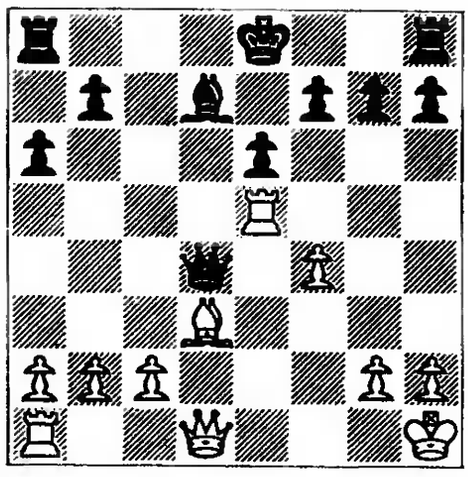


Opening variation

White has the devastating move 1 ♕g4! which threatens both mate on g7 and the win of the black queen by 2 ♘h6+ against which there is no defence.

Here is another typical opening trap involving the unmasking theme.

229

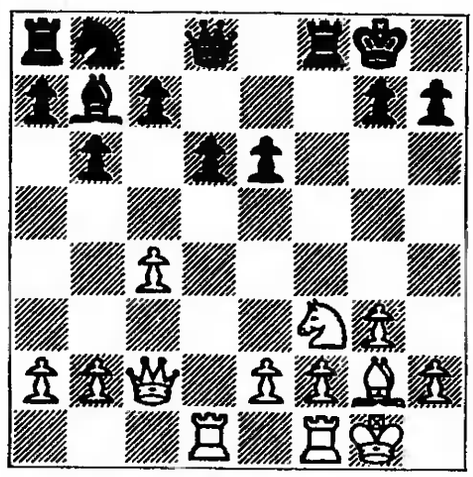


Opening variation

The black queen is unprotected. If only White could move away the masking bishop with check, the queen would be lose, so clearly **1 ♖xe6+!** is playable. Black cannot capture either way without losing the queen to ♗g6+ or ♗b5+, so must move his king, giving White a pawn plus a winning game.

Two further opening traps follow.

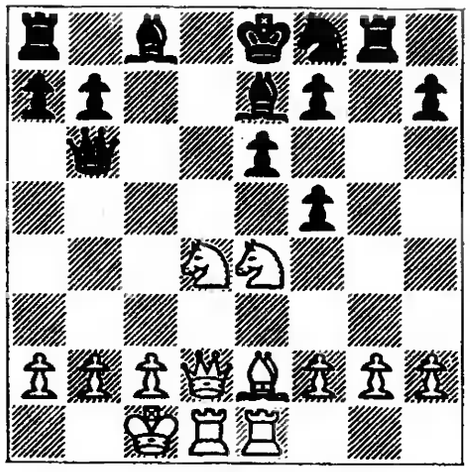
230



Opening variation

This is a position which could arise from the Queen's Indian Defence. With **1 ♘g5!** White threatens both mate on h7 and the bishop on b7, thus forcing **1 ... ♕xg5 2 ♗xb7 ♘d7 3 ♗xa8** winning the exchange.

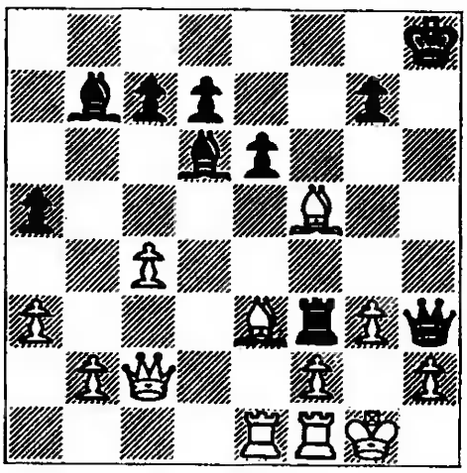
231



Opening variation

The most deadly of unmasking moves is the double check whose tremendous strength resides in the fact that the only reply possible is a move of the king, failing which it is mate! In this position the second situation arises after **1 ♘xf5 ef 2 ♘f6+ ♕xf6 3 ♕d8+! ♗xd8 4 ♗b5** mate.

232

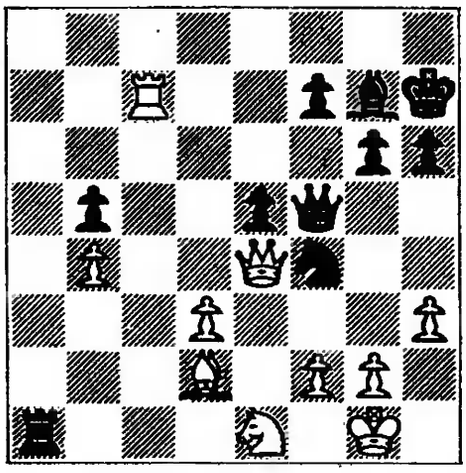


Composed position

Once again the double check proves fatal in the finish: 1 ... ♕g2+!! 2 ♔xg2 ♖xg3 mate! An original mating position.

The double check unmasking also forms part of the next combination which contains additional interesting elements.

233

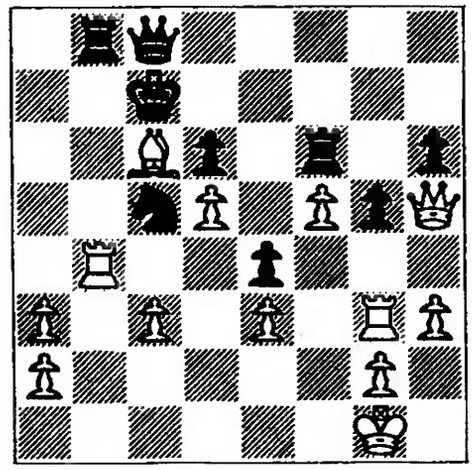


Barcza-Bronstein
Moscow, 1959

After 1 ... ♘xd3! 2 ♕xf5 the zwischenzug 2 ... ♘xe1! with the threat of 3 ... ♘f3 mate proves the winning move. White tries 3 ♔f1! in order to win back the piece after 3 ... gf 4 ♗xe1, but Bronstein replies 3 ... ♘c2+ cutting the white rook from the c1 square and planning to answer 4 ♔e2 with 4 ... ♘d4+. White's final desperate attempt of 4 ♗c1 fails to 4 ... ♖xc1+ 5 ♔e2 ♘d4+ (not 5 ... gf 6 ♔d2 although Black would still win) 6 ♔d2 ♘b3+! and this agile knight ends all resistance.

Our final illustration of the unmasking theme is perhaps the finest historical example of the power of the double check imaginatively visualised at the end of a complex combination.

234



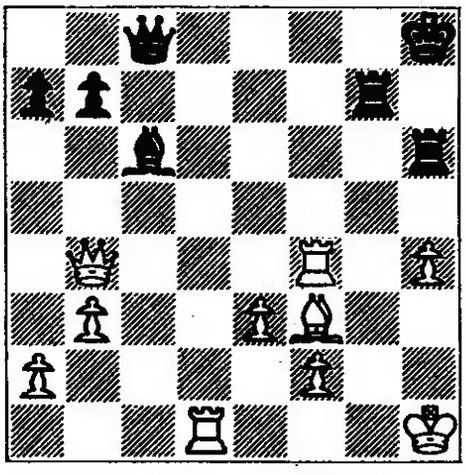
Mason-Winawer
Vienna, 1882

White first of all breaks through to the seventh rank by 1 ♖xg5! hg 2 ♕h7+ ♘d7! (2 ... ♔d8 3 ♕h8+ ♔e7 4 ♕g7+ ♖f7 5 f6+ wins at once) 3 ♗xd7 ♕g8! a defence which White had to take into account when he sacrificed the rook initially. His queen is attacked but Black's rook on b8 is overloaded because it cannot guard the queen and the b7 square at the same time. This allows White to lure the king to a square where it will be exposed to the dreaded double check as follows: 4 ♖b7+!! ♔xb7 5 ♗c8+!! forcing Black to resign, because he not only loses his queen which is now unguarded, but also loses a rook immediately afterwards (5 ... ♔xc8 6 ♕xg8+ and 7 ♕g7+). A magnificent concept.

Line closure

We have often emphasised the importance of opening lines for our pieces. In this section we look at the opposite effect of closing the lines of enemy pieces by interposing one of our pieces at a judicious moment, as we saw with the move 5 ♗c8+ in the previous example, blocking the line of the rook on b8. Such line closures can often produce surprising sacrifices, as we shall see, and form an effective part of defence and counter-attack. Witness the following position.

235

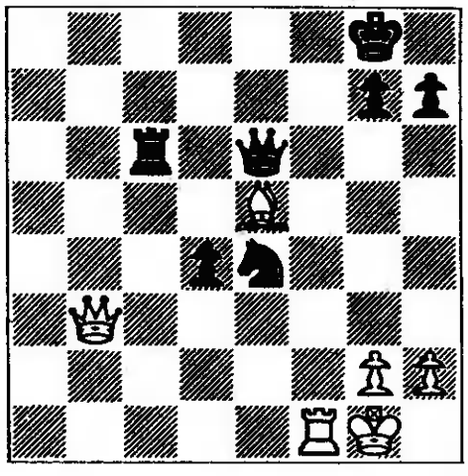


Silich–Rokhlin
Odessa, 1929

After 1 ♖f8+ ♔h7 White could win comfortably with 2 ♕e4+! ♗xe4 3 ♗xe4+ followed by 4 ♖xc8, but instead chose the plausible alternative 2 ♗e4+? only to be met with the startling 2 ... ♕f5!! which forced his resignation. The queen cannot be captured by the bishop, which is pinned, whereas 3 ♖xf5 allows 3 ... ♖xh4 mate, since the white bishop has cut the white queen off from the defence of the h4 pawn!

Here is another dramatic yet elegant line closure.

236

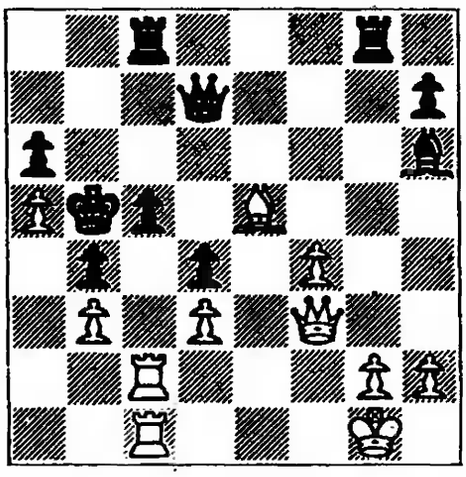


Composed example

At a casual glance it seems that White must settle for the exchange of queens followed by the capture of the pawn on d4, with complete equality, but 1 ♗d6!! puts matters into proper perspective. This mixture of line closure and decoy cleverly exploits the back-rank mates after both 1 ... ♕xb3 2 ♖f8 mate and 1 ... ♖xd6 2 ♕b8+ followed by mate in two, and since the queen is attacked there is no defence.

We are almost in the problem field, as can be seen from our next example which, despite appearances, actually occurred in a game.

237

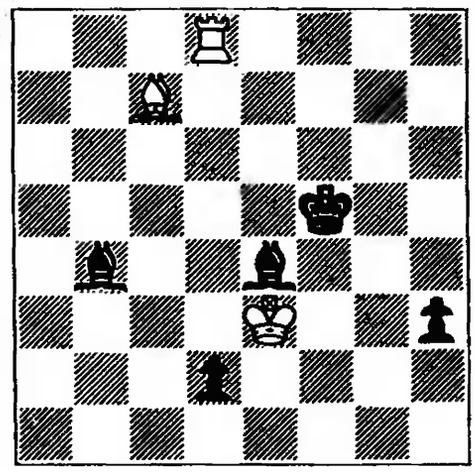


Tarrasch–Players in consultation
Naples, 1914

We here link the ideas of line closure, decoy and interference, all of which are second nature to top class problemists but are not as clearly understood by chess-players. The reasoning about this position runs something like this: but for the black queen's protection of b7, there would by 1 ♕b7+ ♔xa5 2 ♖a1 mate, and the same goes for Black's rook on c8 which is preventing 1 ♖xc5 mate. Suppose, however, that we could arrange for Black to place the queen or rook on a critical square (in this case, clearly c7) where they would interfere with each other's functions. We would then have a situation where a piece would be overloaded, having to do its colleague's work as well as its own, a fact we could exploit by deflecting the piece from its original defensive role. All this is a great deal of explanation! The moves of the game really speak for themselves: 1 ♗c7!! (closing both lines at the same time and thus compelling Black to capture the bishop) 1 ... ♖xc7 (or else 1 ... ♕xc7 2 ♖xc5+! ♕xc5 3 ♕b7+ ♔xa5 4 ♖a1 mate) 2 ♕b7+! ♖xb7 3 ♖xc5 mate.

Let us consider the following position again in terms of a player's possible thoughts.

238

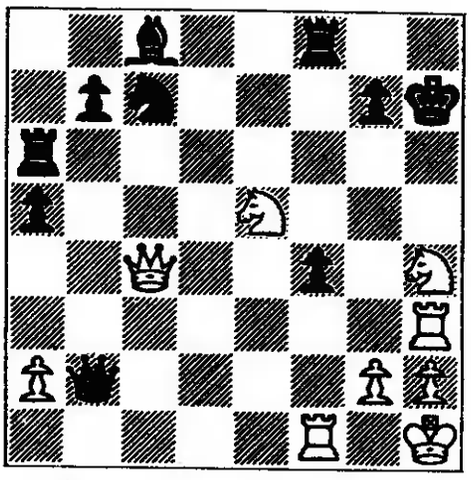


Nenarokov–Grigoriev
Moscow, 1923

The white bishop is stopping ... h2 and the rook is not only preventing the advance of the d pawn but also threatening ♖xd2 drawing at once. But the lines of these two defending pieces cross at the critical square d6, so 1 ... ♗d6!! 2 ♖xd6 h2! and one of the pawns must queen.

Suddenly, it all seems so simple, indeed as simple as it must surely have appeared to the great Sam Loyd in the next position.

239

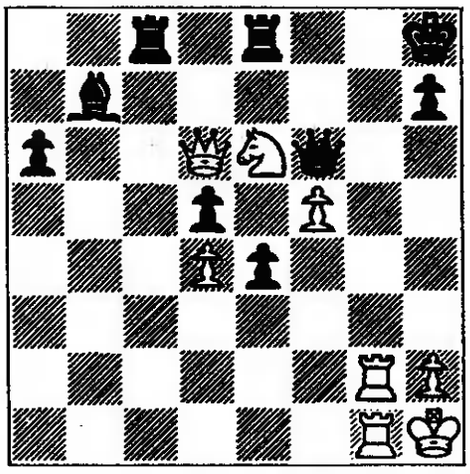


Loyd–Moore
1879

White would like to discover a check with the knight on h4, but if it goes to g6 Black has ... ♗xh3, and if it goes to f5 then ... ♖h6 is the reply. Since the critical square, where the lines of the defending bishop and rook intersect, is e6, why not place the queen on this square? So 1 ♕e6!! ♗xe6 (1 ... ♖xe6 allows 2 ♘hg6+ ♔g8 3 ♖h8 mate) 2 ♘f5+ ♔g8 3 ♘e7 mate. A problemist would not be happy to see the 'dual' after 1 ... ♘xe6, but would be delighted at the fact that the 'set' mates in one move which would occur if either the black bishop or queen's rook were off the board are transformed into mates in two moves after the 'key' move of the queen which, although guarding the important 'flight' square g8, relinquishes this control for the higher purpose of interference!

It is always interesting to see various themes interwoven within the same combination. In our next example we witness a line closure linked with an unmasking, back-rank mate and deflection, all in the space of two moves!

240

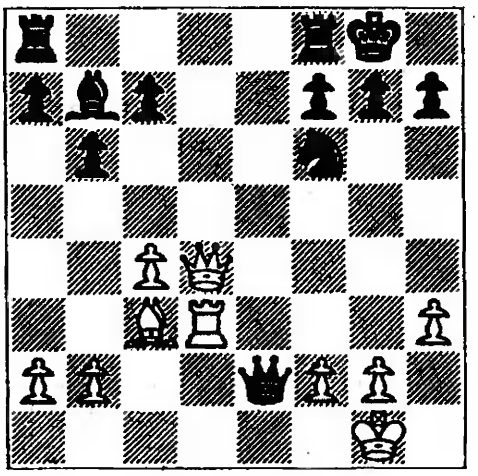


Olland–Rüster

1 ♘f8! forces immediate resignation. The same mate occurs after both 1 ... ♖xf8 2 ♖g8+! ♖xg8 3 ♕xf6+ and 1 ... ♕xf8 2 ♖g8+! ♕xg8 3 ♕f6+ and of course 1 ... ♕xd6 allows 2 ♖g8 mate.

The discovery of original ideas is a creative process. It is amazing how seemingly analogous positions contain hidden elements which may appear to be chance factors, such as a pawn on a particular square, but the task of a player is to fathom out the secrets of the piece lay-out facing him and link all relevant factors in his search for the decisive combination. The final examples of line closure given in this section all demonstrate that spark of imagination which distinguishes a chess-player from a mere wood-pusher.

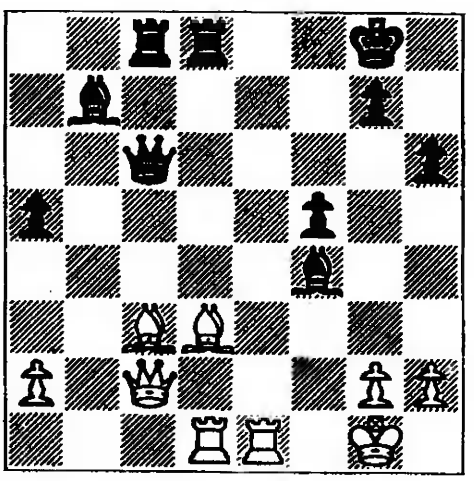
241



Ahues–N.N.
Berlin, 1920

White had given up a rook and a minor piece to reach this position in which he produced his planned winning move 1 ♕xf6 so that after 1 ... gf 2 ♖g3+ mates. Black promptly resigned, but it was later discovered that he had a brilliant line closure defence in the startling 1 ... ♕g4! threatening mate and thus forcing 2 hg gf winning, because White's rook no longer has a fatal check on g3.

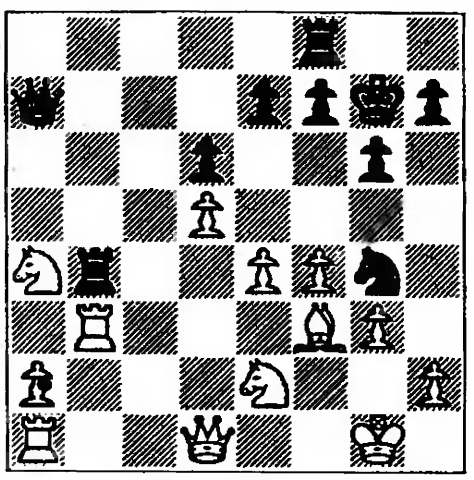
242



Dvoiris–Spassky
USSR, 1973

Even a top-class player can fail to recognise the possibility of a line closure defence, as did ex-World Champion Spassky in this position. He has much the better of it but mistakenly thinks that he can win out of hand by 1 ... ♕xc3? missing his opponent's brilliant counter 2 ♗c4+!! which immediately forced his resignation. The bishop move cuts out the protection offered to Black's queen by his rook, so 2 ... ♔h8 fails to 3 ♕xc3. As 2 ... ♕xc4 loses to 3 ♖xd8+ deflecting the rook on c8, Black must play 2 ... ♖xc4 allowing 3 ♖xd8+ ♔f7 4 ♕xf5+ ♕f6 5 ♖e7+! ♔xe7 6 ♕d7 mate.

243

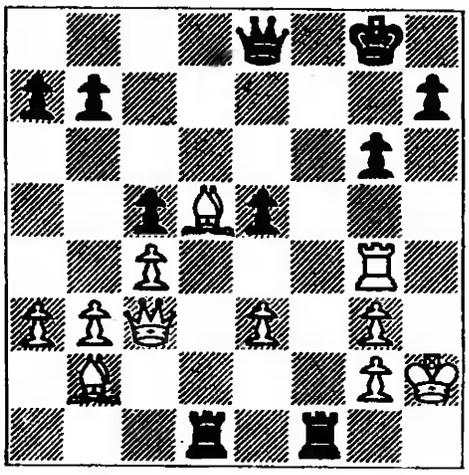


Oren–Dyner
1962

Black has sacrificed to reach this position and at first sight it looks completely lost for White, since any move of his king would lose the queen to a knight check. However, White has a clever way of exploiting the fact that all the vital lines meet

at the critical point d4. First, by 1 ♘b6! ♕xb6+ (1 ... ♖xb6 2 ♕d4+) he entices the queen to the b file, thus pinning the black rook, and then comes 2 ♕d4+!! ♕xd4+ 3 ♘xd4 ♖xd4 4 ♗xg4 with an easy win.

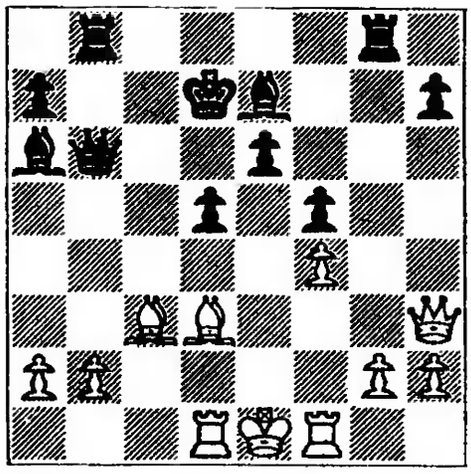
244



Eliskases–Henneberger
Bad Liebenwerda, 1934

As Black was threatening mate on h1, White has checked with his bishop and is prepared to give up material to stop mate or to give his king some air. He plans to answer 1 ... ♔f8 with 2 ♖f4+! and 1 ... ♔g7 with 2 ♕xe5+ ♕xe5 3 ♗xe5+ ♔f8 4 ♖f4+ or here 3 ... ♔h6 4 ♖h4+ ♔g5 5 ♗f4+ and 6 g4. Black immediately surprises him with the unexpected 1 ... ♕f7! and is rewarded for his ingenuity with 2 ♗xf7+? ♔f8!! after which there is no way White can prevent mate. However, there is a way for White to save himself. On the second move he can reply 2 ♖xg6+! ♔f8! (not of course 2 ... hg? 3 ♗xf7+ followed by 4 g4 winning) 3 g4 ♕xg6 4 ♕xe5 and in view of his exposed king Black can hardly exploit his material advantage. All this was a splendid mixture of line closure (1 ... ♕f7! blocked the f file and thus prevented ♖f4+) and square vacation (White's rook had to vacate g4 to give his king a flight square).

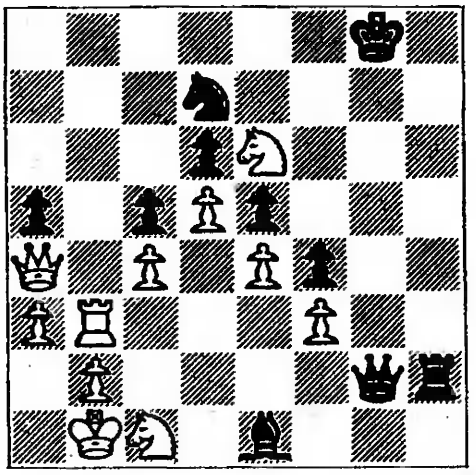
245



Reggio–Mieses
Monte Carlo, 1903

Here the critical square is e3, since if the black queen can reach this square without capture there is a forced mate. The g3 square is a pivot point on the third rank and e1–h4 diagonal, so Mieses produced the brilliant 1 ... ♖g3!! 2 ♕xg3 ♗h4! forcing resignation, a mixture of line closure and decoy, the queen being lured to a square where it can be pinned.

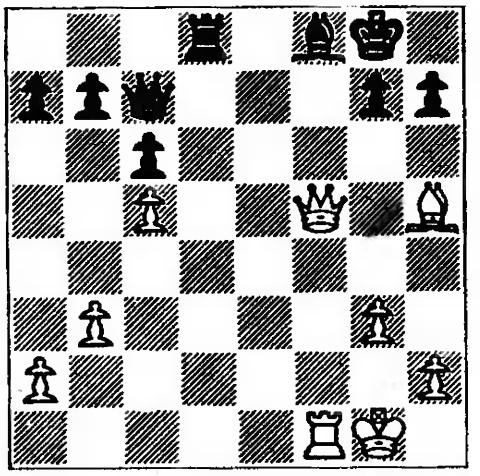
246



Kotov–Szabo
Zürich, 1953

A double-edged position, with both sides attacking. Black's pressure on the seventh rank is strong, but ... ♕c2+ is not playable because the queen must guard the g7 square. So 1 ... ♗c3 appears to be a deadly move. Clearly 2 ♖xc3? ♕xb2 mate and 2 bc? ♕c2+ 3 ♔a1 ♕xc1+ 4 ♖b1 ♕xc3+ followed by mate are both unplayable, and Black is also threatening 2 ... ♕xb2+! 3 ♖xb2 ♖xb2+ 4 ♔a1 ♖b4+ winning. However, fortunately for White there is a line closure sacrifice 2 ♘e2! which lures Black's queen from the defence of g7 and thus allows White the final say as follows: 2 ... ♕xe2 3 ♖b8+! ♘xb8 4 ♕e8+ ♔h7 5 ♕f7+ ♔h6 6 ♕g7+ ♔h5 7 ♕g5 mate.

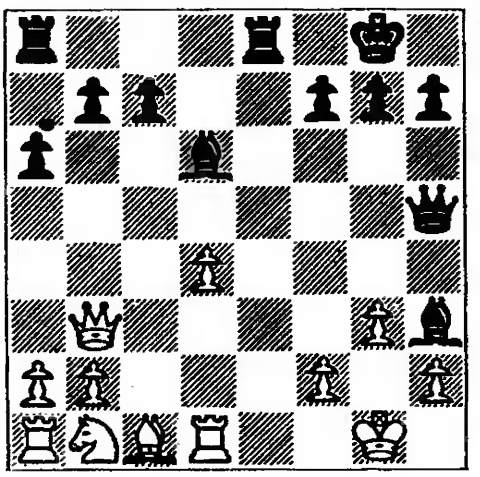
247



Réti–Bogoljubow
New York, 1924

Here is an impressive example of line closure coming at the end of a beautifully played game and with that elegant execution for which Réti was renowned. The finish went: 1 ♗f7+ ♔h8 2 ♗e8!! and as the reader can judge for himself there is no way Black can avoid at least the loss of a piece.

248

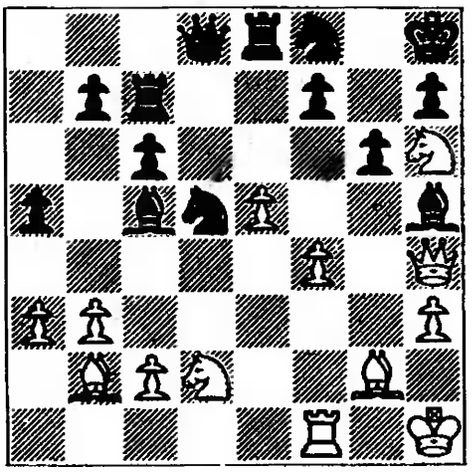


Opening variation

Black would like his queen to reach f3 when ... ♕g2 mate will be unstoppable. He succeeds through a clever mixture of line closure and deflection beginning 1 ... ♖e3!! White has three ways of capturing the rook, all of which lose as follows: 2 ♕xe3 ♕xd1+ followed by mate; 2 ♗xe3 ♕f3 mating; 2 fe ♕e2! followed by mate on g2 or f1.

Our final example of line closure involves the decisive sacrifice of a mere pawn.

249



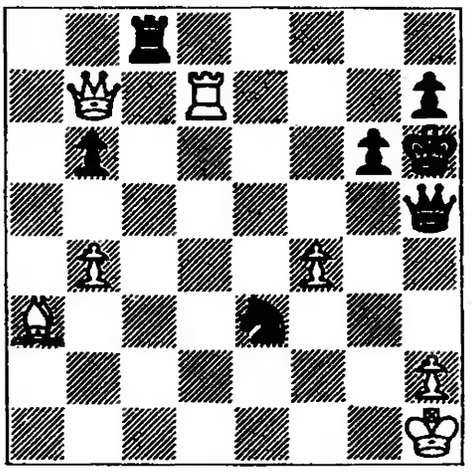
Podgayets-Belyavsky
Kiev, 1973

After 1 e6+ f6 the move 2 e7!! throws a spanner in the works by closing the seventh rank and the d8–h4 diagonal at one and the same time. Ideally, Black would like to protect his f6 pawn by 2 ... ♗xe7 but this fails to 3 ♘f7+, whilst 2 ... ♖xe7 allows 3 ♗xf6+. So Black continued with 2 ... ♕xe7 only to lose a piece to 3 ♗xd5.

Deflection

We have already used this term a number of times in our discussion of other combinations, a fact which is hardly surprising in view of the recurrent nature of the theme. It is all connected with the overloading of a piece by giving it too many tasks to perform, with the result that it cannot cope, as we saw for example in position 248 where 1 ... ♖e3! overloaded the white queen which could no longer guard the f3 square and the rook on d1 at the same time. In other words, Black's first move deflected the white queen from its basic defensive role. Here is another illustration of the theme.

250

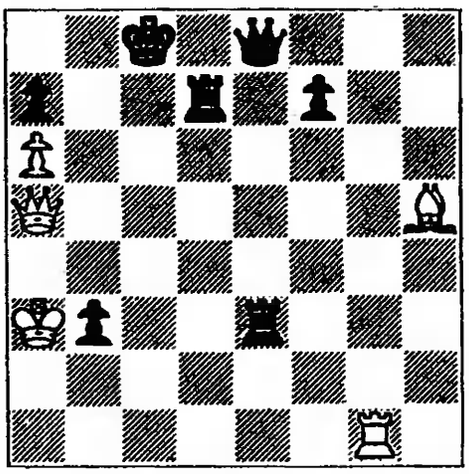


Durst-Tarrasch
Nuremberg, 1908

Black counters White's threat of ♖xh7 mate by the brilliant deflection move 1 ... ♖c7!! the purpose of which is firstly to close the rank

and secondly to lure away either the queen from the long white diagonal (2 ♕xc7? ♕f3+ followed by mate) or the rook from the d1 square (2 ♖xc7? ♕d1 mate). Not to be outdone, White replies 2 b5! planning to mate on f8 if his queen is captured and to answer 2 ... ♕e2 with 3 ♖xh7+! ♖xh7 4 ♗f8+ ♔h5 5 ♕xh7+ ♔g4 6 ♕xg6+ winning, or here 3 ... ♔xh7 4 ♕xc7+ etc. Once again it looks all over for Black, but a further deflection 2 ... ♕d1+! clears the way for his king to go to h5, and after 3 ♖xd1+ ♖xb7 the game was drawn. What a lot to happen within the space of three moves!

251

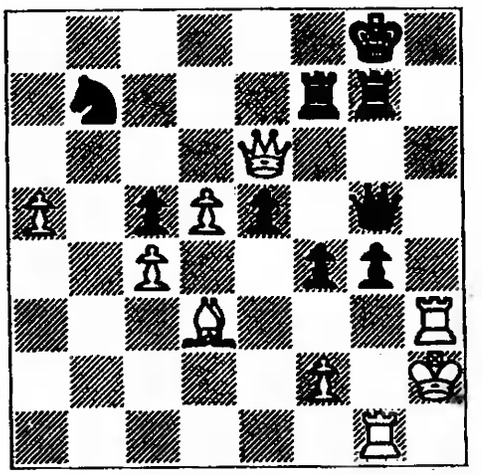


Duras–N.N.
Prague, 1910

Two fine deflection sacrifices win for White as follows: 1 ♖c1+ ♔b8 2 ♕b4+ ♔a8 3 ♗f3+! (firstly, the rook is deflected from e4) 3 ... ♖xf3 4 ♕e4+! (and now the queen is lured from the back rank) 4 ... ♕xe4 5 ♖c8 mate.

These two were fairly easy to visualize, but you need a good imagination to see the point of the initial deflection sacrifice in our next position.

252

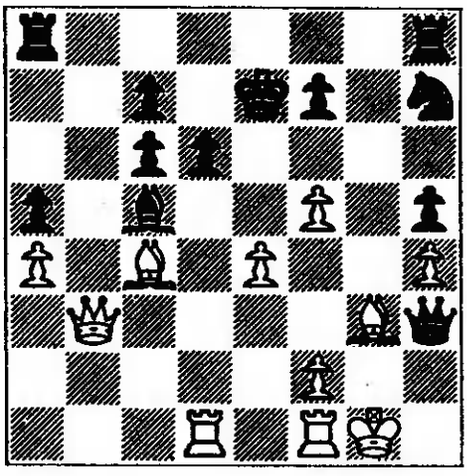


Johannsson–Rey
Correspondence, 1935

1 ♖xg4! (to deflect the queen from h6!) 1 ... ♕xg4 2 ♕e8+ ♖f8 3 ♖h8+ ♔xh8 4 ♕xf8+ ♖g8 5 ♕h6 mate. Note that if Black had declined the initial sacrifice by 1 ... ♕f6 (1 ... ♕e7 2 ♕h6! wins) White could simply reply 2 ♕e8+ ♖f8 3 ♗h7+ ♔h8 4 ♗f5+ ♔g8 5 ♗e6+ forcing mate.

Black's deflection play in our next position is even more subtle and very instructive.

253



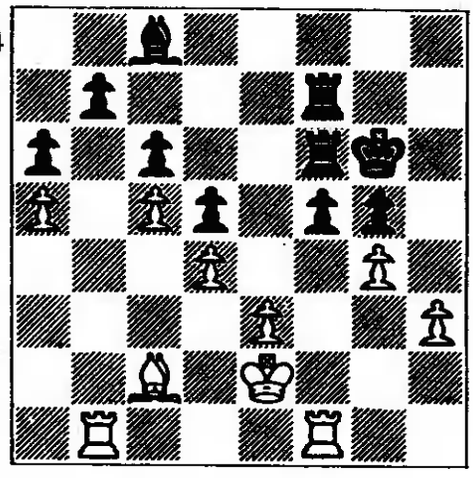
Composed position

The pin of White's f2 pawn means that Black will apply pressure on the bishop on g3 by **1 ... ♖hg8 2 ♖d3** but how is he to proceed now? Firstly he plays **2 ... ♖ab8! 3 ♕c3** so that the queen is no longer protected by the bishop, and then **3 ... ♖xg3+! 4 ♖xg3 ♖g8!!** reveals the point of the combination. After the forced **5 ♖xg8 ♕xc3** White is lost.

The pin

The previous position could also be considered as an excellent example of the pinning theme, with the white rook on g3 pinned onto the king (this is an 'absolute' pin, because the rook cannot legally move away from the g file exposing his king to check, although it can of course move along the file) but also pinned onto the queen (this, on the other hand, is a 'relative' pin, because the rook can legally move away from the third rank, although to do so would lose material). The pin is important from both a strategic and tactical point of view, so it is essential for the reader to understand fully the mechanism of the pinning theme. Here is a clear-cut illustration of its power.

254

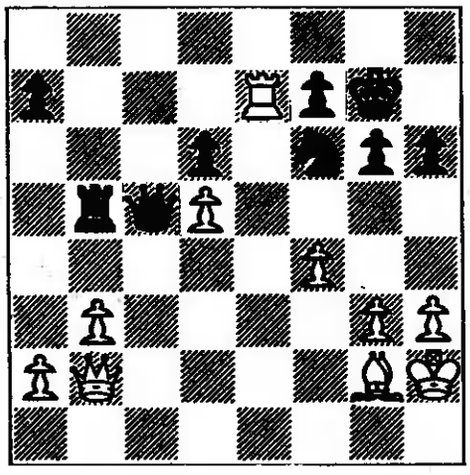


Composed position

After **1 gf+ ♗xf5?** (it was preferable to give up the pawn rather than allow the sequel) **2 ♖xf5!** (White temporarily gives up the exchange in order to maintain a pin, a typical stratagem in such positions) **2 ... ♖xf5 3 ♖f1 ♖f6 4 ♖f3!** and Black is helpless, since his king cannot move, nor can the rook on f6 leave the f file, nor can the g pawn be advanced (4 ... g4? 5 hg winning at once). He must simply wait for White to bring

his king to g4 winning material, a drastic demonstration of the frightening effect of a pin.

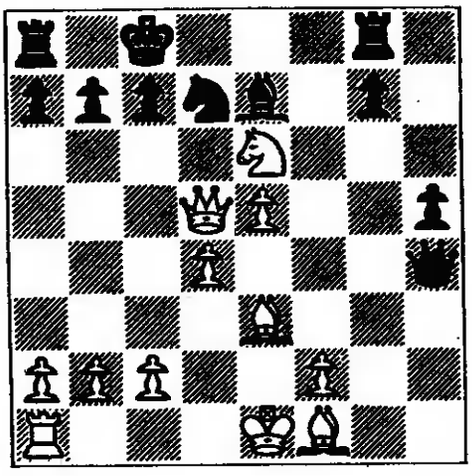
255



Trifunović–Golombek
Amsterdam, 1954

We have the same theme, the pin of a minor piece, with a few added touches as Black desperately tries to break the strangle-hold. Play proceeded: 1 g4 g5 2 h4! ♔g6 (the only way to protect g5) 3 ♗e4+! ♘xe4 4 h5+ ♔h7 5 ♖xf7+ and 6 ♕g7 mate. Note how Black escapes from the pin only to find himself mated!

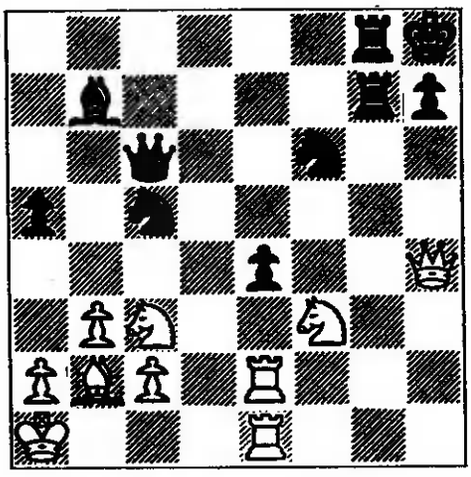
256



Philidor–Brühl
London, 1789

1 ♗a6! (a 'relative' pin, but of course 1 ... bxa6 would lose material) 1 ... ♖b8 2 ♕c6! (the real point, an 'absolute' pin which proves fatal) 2 ... ♗d8 3 ♗g5! and this final deflection forced Black to resign.

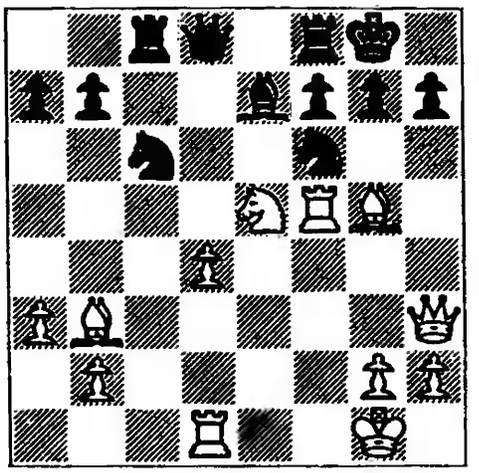
257



Composed position

The latent power of White's bishop on b2 is decisively revealed in the brilliant continuation: 1 ♘xe4! ♘cxe4 2 ♖xe4! ♘xe4 3 ♖xe4 ♕xe4 4 ♘g5!! and now the queen cannot be captured (♘f7 mate) and if Black's queen retreats to e7 the h7 square is left unguarded (♕xh7 mate) so Black must play 4 ... ♕g6 allowing 5 ♕xh7+! (deflection) ♕xh7 6 ♘f7 mate.

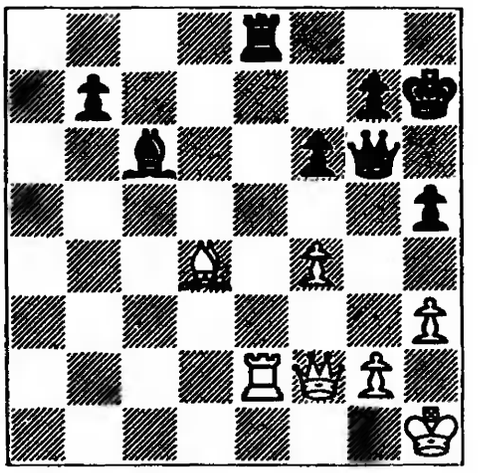
258



Cogan–Foster
Boston, 1937

There is a deceptive ease and simplicity about the instructive finish which runs as follows: 1 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 2 ♕xh7+! ♔xh7 3 ♖h5+ ♔g8 4 ♘g6! and there is no way Black can prevent 5 ♖h8 mate. Even if Black had foreseen this conclusion and played 1 ... gxf6 he would still have lost after 2 ♕g4+ ♔h8 3 ♖h5 ♘xe5 4 ♕h4 ♘g6 5 ♖xh7+ ♔g8 6 ♕h6 mating.

259

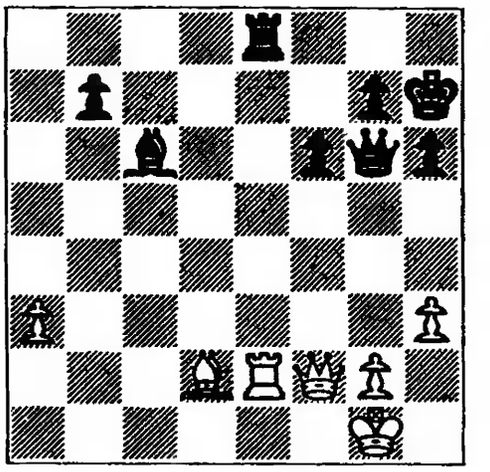


Kotov–Botvinnik
Leningrad, 1939

Here is a typical exploitation of a pin from which I suffered but also learned (see the following position!). Since White's queen is defending the rook, why not pin her by 1 ... ♕xg2+! 2 ♕xg2 when the fact that the black bishop is protected allows Botvinnik to play 2 ... ♖xe2 winning the exchange and the game.

It is a curious fact that, seven years later, I managed to pull off a similar finish, but with interesting differences.

260

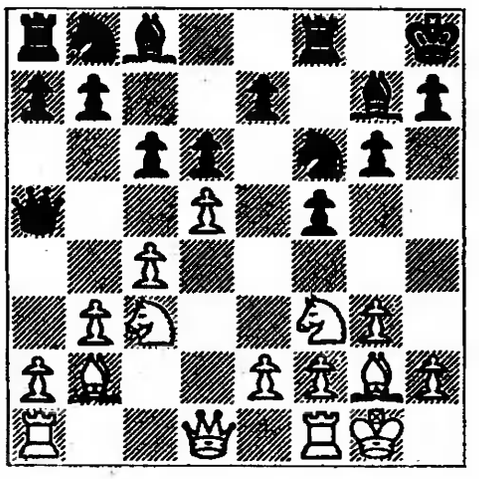


Guimard–Kotov
Groningen, 1946

Since White's king is on g1, the pin of the queen is now down the g file rather than along the a8–h1 diagonal after 1 ... ♗xg2! 2 ♖xe8 (now of course 2 ♕xg2 ♖xe2 wins a whole rook) 2 ... ♗e4+ 3 ♔h2 ♕xe8 and Black's two pawn advantage proved sufficient to win.

The so-called 'cross-pin' is an interesting and often spectacular example of a double pin, one relative and one absolute, as our next position illustrates.

261

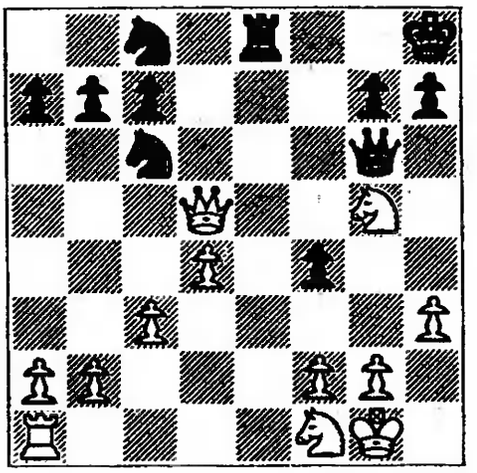


Robatsch–Jansa
Sochi, 1974

Black mistakenly thinks he can win a pawn by 1 ... ♘xd5? 2 cd ♗xc3 only to discover that White has the tremendous counter 3 ♕d2!! which wins either a piece or else (after 3 ... ♗xb2) a queen for a rook. The mechanism is simple enough, the already pinned black bishop on c3 being pinned once again, but this time on the queen. Here is another example. (*See Diagram 262*)
After 1 ♘f7+ ♔g8 2 ♘d6+ Black tries to preserve the material balance by countering with 2 ... ♕e6 (note that the alternative 2 ... ♖e6 loses to 3 ♖e1 ♘d8 4 ♘xb7!) failing to see the cross-pin 3 ♖e1! ♕xd5 4 ♖xe8 mate.

When the king is in the centre, pins of pawns or pieces, down the

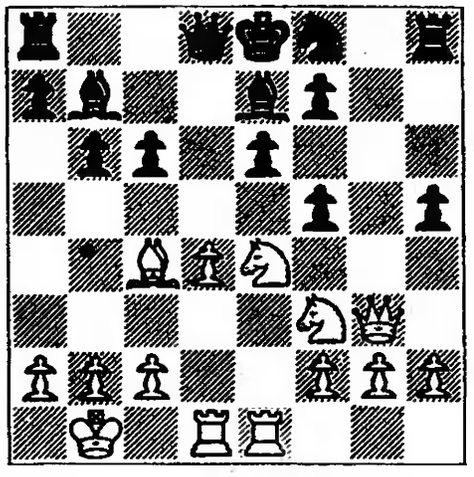
262



Composed position

e and d files are often in the air, and many opening traps exploit this factor e.g. 1 e4 c6 2 ♘c3 d5 3 ♘f3 de 4 ♘xe4 ♘d7 5 ♕e2(?) ♘gf6?? 6 ♘d6 mate. Here is a position where both files are utilised in drastic fashion.

263

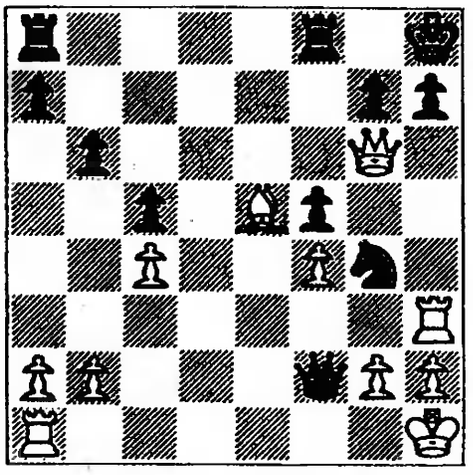


Kotov–Kalmanok
Moscow, 1937

Black has left his king in the centre too long and it will now be attacked down the e file and the a4–e8 diagonal, but the vulnerability of his queen will also prove a decisive factor. Play proceeds:

1 d5! cd (capture by the e pawn allows ♘f6 mate, whereas 1 ... fe loses to 2 dxe6 threatening both the pawn mate on f7 and the black queen) 2 ♗b5+ ♘d7 3 ♘e5 ♗c8 4 ♕g7 ♖f8 5 ♖xd5! ed 6 ♘f6+ ♗xf6 7 ♘g6+ ♗e7 8 ♕xf8 mate, referred to by problemists as a pin-mate, since both possible defenders of f8, the knight on d7 and bishop on e7, are fatally pinned. Just one last word of warning before we close this section. Whilst pins in general, even if relative ones, are powerful tactical weapons, we must always consider whether in fact the pin is only an imaginary one or if there is a defensive unpinning resource such as the following:

264



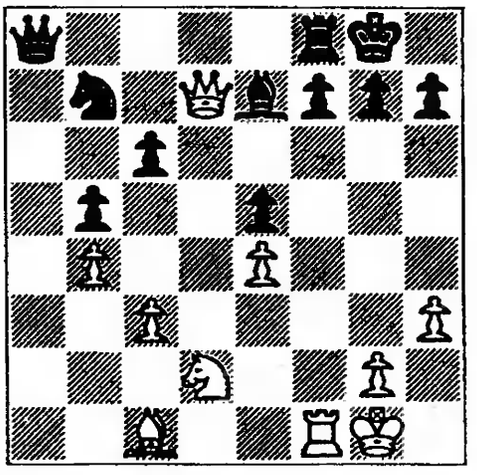
Weigap–Hodscha
Tirana, 1954

White's queen, which is at the moment threatening mate on both g7 and h7, cannot be captured by the pinned h pawn, so things look bad for Black. There is, however, an amazing resource which eventually not only eliminates the mating threats but also wins the exchange for Black. He plays 1 ... ♕e1+!! 2 ♖xe1 ♘f2+ 3 ♔g1 ♘xh3+ (all with check!) 4 gh hg winning easily.

Trapping a piece

Many beginners lose pieces in the opening stages simply by bad play (1 e3 d5 2 ♘c3 e5 3 ♕f3? e4 4 ♕f4?? ♗d6 and the queen has no moves . . .) or as a result of a cunning trap (1 e4 e5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 ♗b5 f5 4 d4 fe 5 ♘xe5 ♘xe5 6 de c6 and if White does not want to lose his valuable e pawn to ... ♕a5+ he is compelled to go in for the interesting sacrifice of a piece by 7 ♘c3!? cb 8 ♘xe4 with a double-edged position), but trapping pieces is part and parcel of our entire tactical arsenal. Here are four typical examples of such traps.

265



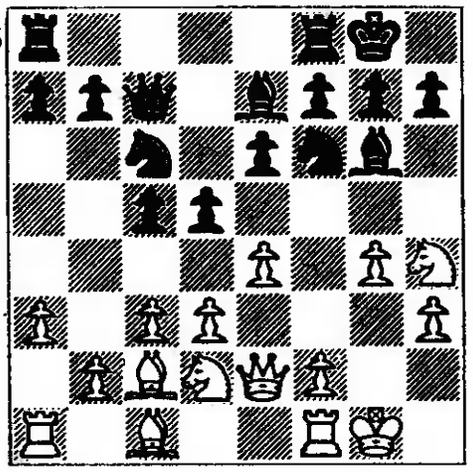
Karakljaić–Dely
Hungary v Yugoslavia, 1957

Black played 1 ... ♕c8! to force the queen away or exchange it. But what about the loose bishop

on e7? Clearly this is either a complete blunder on Black's part or else he is setting a trap. Incredible as it may seem, Karakljaic failed to see that his chosen 2 ♕xe7? lost his queen for rook and bishop after 2 ... f6! followed by 3 ... ♖f7.

That was reasonably easy to visualise, but it is difficult not to sympathise with Petrosian for missing the subtle sequence which I managed to find in the following position.

266

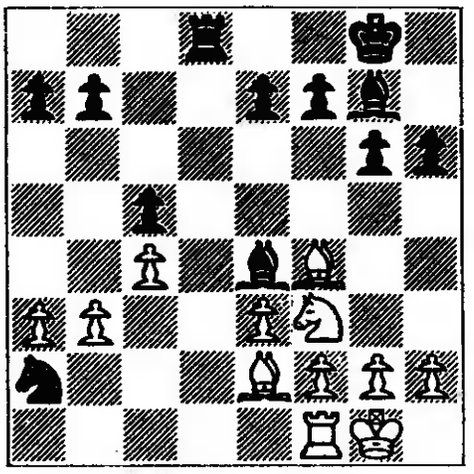


Petrosian–Kotov
Moscow, 1952

1 ... ♘xg4! threatening mate on h2 forces 2 ♕xg4 unless White wishes to lose a pawn for nothing. Then comes 2 ... f5 3 ef ef 4 ♕a4 (the alternative 4 ♕g3 allows 4 ... f4 5 ♕g5 ♘e5 winning material) and now comes the point 4 ... ♗e8!! 5 ♘hf3 ♘a5! and the queen is trapped because of the unfortunate placing of the bishop on c2.

It is also rare to see ex-World Champion Smyslov falling into a trap in a simple-looking ending such as the following:

267

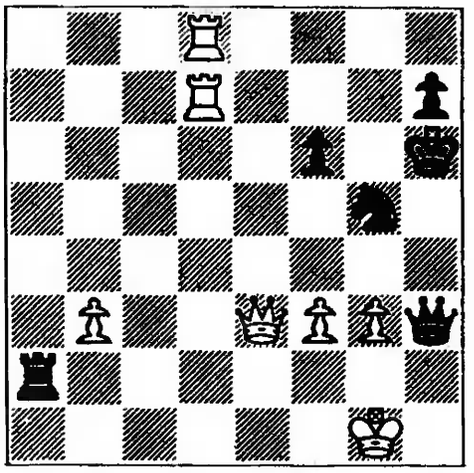


Smyslov–Bronstein
Teesside, 1975

Black already has the better of the position, but after 1 ♖d1? ♖xd1+ 2 ♗xd1 ♘c3! he resigned, because there is no way he can avoid the loss of a piece. After the forced 3 ♘d2 ♗d3! 4 ♗f3 e5 5 ♗g3 e4 6 ♗g4 f5 7 ♗h3 ♘e2+ 8 ♔h1 ♘xg3+ 9 hg ♗c3 the knight is trapped.

Our final example is based on the oft-recurring idea of skewering king and queen in order to win the latter.

268



Duras–Cohn
Carlsbad, 1911

White has a forcing sequence to win the queen by **1 ♖xh7+! ♔xh7 2 ♕e7+ ♔g6 3 ♖g8+ ♔f5 4 ♖xg5+ ♔xg5 5 ♕g7+ ♔f5 6 ♕d7+** Resigns.

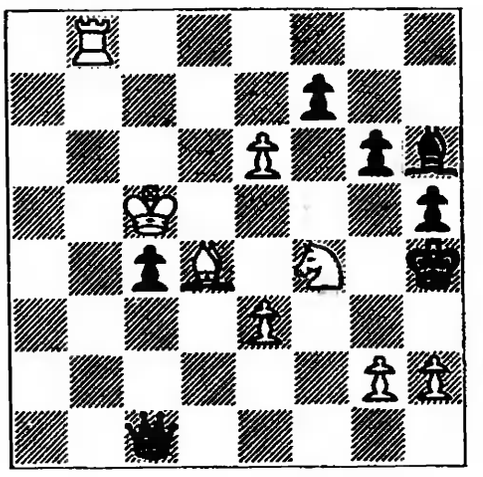
7 Beauty and Imagination

We have tried hard so far to help the reader by breaking down combinations into certain types which have at least common elements, however different they may be in other respects. The attentive reader will have realized, however, that the artistic and imaginative powers of individual players bring something extra to these positions, often transcending the purely competitive aspects of the game in order to create a thing of beauty. It is to such aesthetically pleasing achievements that this chapter pays tribute with a wide range of positions and ideas which will always delight and stimulate chess-players and perhaps challenge the very concept of computer chess.

David versus Goliath

In the same way that people enthuse over a David finding a method of defeating the giant Goliath, or a d'Artagnan taking on ten swordsmen at one time, the chess public is enthralled by a demonstration of mind over mere matter, by the triumph of imagination over mundane wood-pushing. The following study exemplifies, if not glorifies, this instinctive feeling within us all.

269

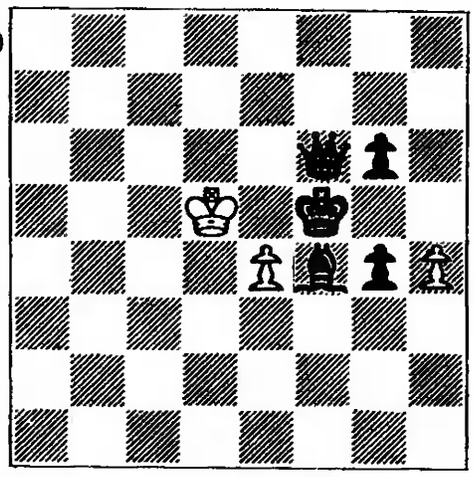


Study by Kasantsev

There is no mating net to be seen for White, but the composer has conceived the splendid idea of persuading Black to help create a beautiful mate by allowing White to give up practically the whole of his material. Here is how it is done: by 1 e7! threatening to queen the pawn White forces Black to capture it by 1 ... ♕a3+ 2 ♖b4! ♕a7+ 3 ♔xc4! ♕xe7 but meanwhile the rook has reached b4 and the king has removed the c pawn, important factors as we shall see. Now, using the vulnerability of the black queen, White produces the following forcing sequence: 4 ♘xg6+ fg 5 ♗f6+! ♕xf6 6 ♔d5+! (the point) 6 ... ♔g5 7 h4+ ♔f5 8 g4+ hg (blocking an escape square) 9 ♖f4+! ♗xf4 10 e4 mate,

a position surely worth another diagram.

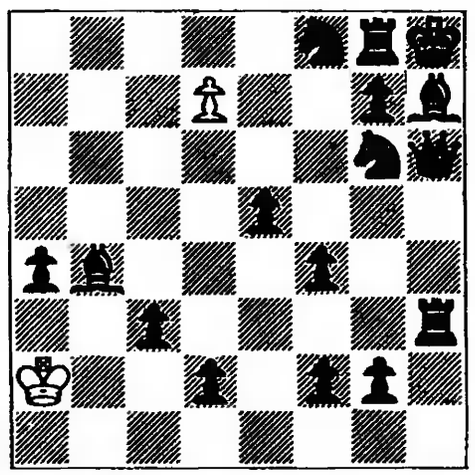
270



All of White's pieces have disappeared and the humble foot-soldier produces the final touch whilst monarch, spouse and bishop look on helplessly (if only the latter had been a pawn, the 'en passant' rule would have saved Black!).

An equally dramatic and amusing position is presented in our next diagram.

271

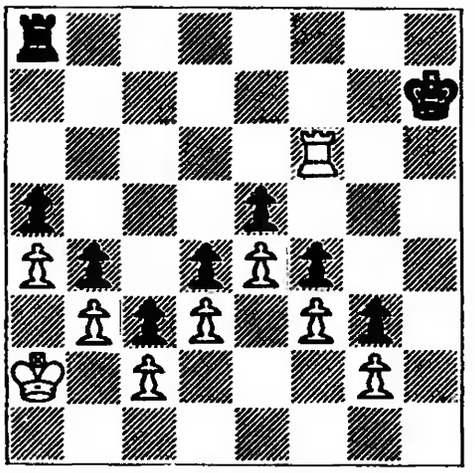


Study by Kipping

Clearly, we are far removed from the real world of chess-playing, but the theme of mind over matter is in evidence, since **1 d8♘!** threatens mate on f7 and there is absolutely nothing that Black, despite the fact that he has his whole army intact, can do about it!

Our third study illustrates what is termed a positional draw, a rare but fascinating phenomenon.

272



Study by Hasek

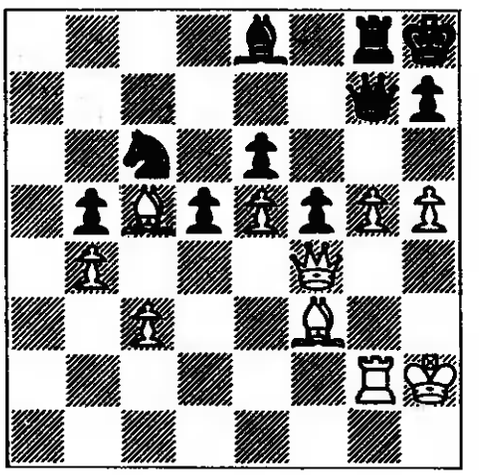
All appears lost for White who is faced by the threat of ... ♔g7 followed by ... ♖h8 and the fatal penetration of the rook to h2 and the creation of a passed g pawn. This would also win after 1 ♖f5 ♔g6 e.g. 2 ♖xe5 ♖h8 3 ♖f5 ♖h2 4 ♖xf4 ♖xg2 5 ♖g4+ ♔f7 6 ♔b1 ♖g1+ 7 ♔a2 ♖c1 8 ♖xg3 ♖xc2+ 9 ♔a1 ♖d2! 10 ♔b1 ♖b2+ 11 ♔c1 ♖xb3 etc., winning easily.

However, as we shall see, it is his king which White must mobilise if he is to reach the positional draw we were talking about, even if this

means sacrificing his rook in order to gain the required tempo. Let us see how all this works out: 1 ♔b1! ♔g7 2 ♖h6! (2 ♔c1 loses to 2 ... ♖h8) 2 ... ♔xh6 3 ♔c1 ♔g7 4 ♔d1 ♖h8 5 ♔e2! and White has attained the set-up he was aiming for. The point is that 5 ... ♖h1 is stalemate, so Black makes one last winning attempt with 5 ... ♖h2 which White counters with 6 ♔f1 so that if 6 ... ♖h1+ 7 ♔e2 the black rook must retreat in order to avoid stalemate. So 6 ... ♔g6 7 ♔g1 ♔g5 8 ♔f1 ♖xg2 9 ♔xg2 ♔h4 10 ♔g1! ♔h5 11 ♔h1 ♔g5 12 ♔g2 and the pawn ending is drawn.

Thrust and counter-thrust

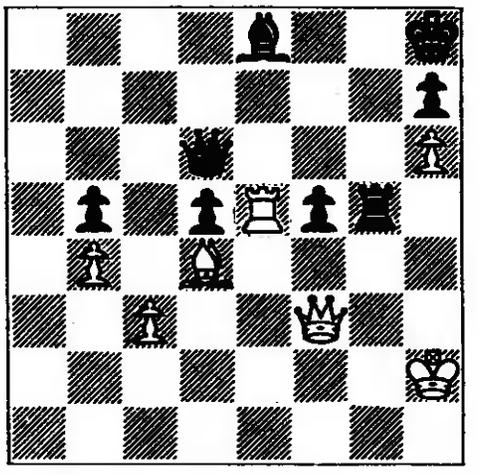
Positions sometimes arise in chess where each side produces or parries threats over a number of moves in the same way that ping-pong players smash or return those little celluloid balls from one side of the net to the other. The better the players, the more likely such a prospect appears, as in the following position (*See Diagram 273*)



273

Duras–Spielmann
Piestan, 1912

White is attacking, Black defending, and the latter's first move comes as something of a surprise: 1 ... ♘xe5!? (an incredibly bold move, but Spielmann has an idea and he can hardly wait for Whtie to come at him) 2 ♗d4 ♘xf3+ 3 ♕xf3 e5 4 h6! (of course, a retreat by the bishop would make Black happy) 4 ... ♕e7! (but not 4 ... ♕c7 allowing the powerful cross-pin 5 ♕f4!) 5 ♖e2 ♖xg5 6 ♖xe5 ♕d6! giving us the following position:



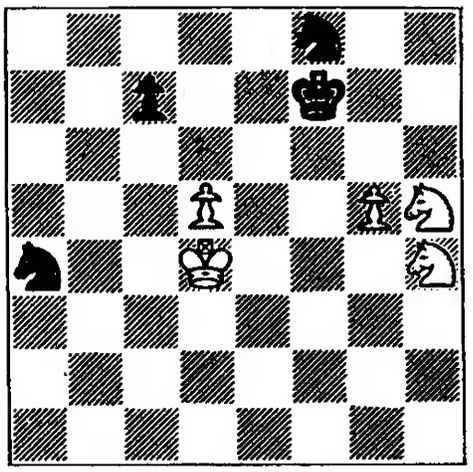
274

It is difficult to say just how far both sides had calculated the complexities arising from the initial 1 ... ♘xe5, but now that the smoke has cleared, so to speak, we cannot fail to see the tremendous strength of the battery of bishop on d4 and rook on e5, the latter capable of giving double-check mate on e8, if only it were not pinned on the king! How can White avoid this pin, however? For instance, if the king goes to h1, Black has mate in

two moves. Duras comes up with the answer: 7 ♕g3! ♕xh6+ (not of course 7 ... ♖xg3 8 ♖xe8 mate) 8 ♕h3! ♕d6 9 ♔h1! ♔g8 10 ♖xe8+ ♔f7 11 ♖h8 Resigns.

For our second cut-and-thrust episode I will quote one of my own positions in which my opponent had just made his move with the jesting comment: 'Please try to solve the study I've set you'.

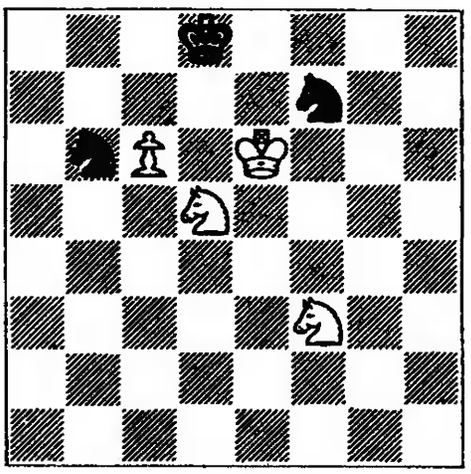
275



Sergiev–Kotov
Moscow, 1935

Almost certainly, Sergiev was referring to the well-known fact that two knights alone cannot mate a lone king, so if only I could sacrifice each of my knights for a pawn the game would be a draw! However, in chess it is rarely easy to make such sacrifices when your opponent is fully aware of the situation, so I had to plan carefully. First of all, I played 1 ... c6! and rose from my seat with the comment: 'Right, dear Alexander Sergeievitch, now do your damnedest to win'. The next few moves were played fairly rapidly: 2 dc ♘e6+ 3 ♔e5 ♘xg5 4 ♘f4 ♔e7 5 ♘d5+ ♔d8 6 ♘f3! and I began to think feverishly about the fact that I dare not take the knight without allowing White to queen his pawn by moving his king to d6. Finally, I came up with the saving idea and played 6 ... ♘f7+ 7 ♔e6 ♘b6!! reaching the following position:

276



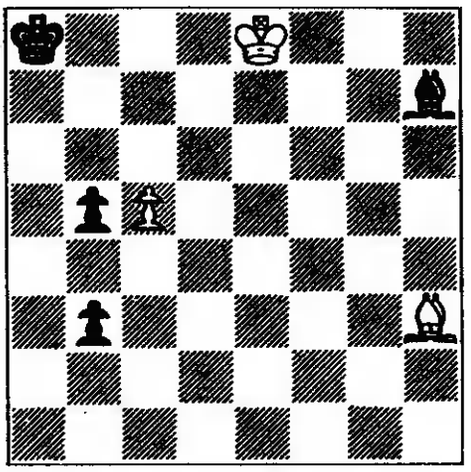
A piquant situation in which Black has placed both his knights 'en prise' but neither can be taken without losing the vital pawn. The game ended: 8 ♘e7! ♔e8 9 c7 ♘d8+ 10 ♔d6 ♘c4+ 11 ♔d5 ♔xe7! and a draw was agreed, since 12 c8♕ is answered by 12 ... ♘b6+.

Geometry

Just as we can admire the composition of a painting or the structure of a symphony or the curve of a graph, in chess we can value the harmonious flow of a game or the logic of its geometrical laws. Does not our eye take pleasure in the relationships between pieces

along the files, ranks and diagonals, as they cross and clash, or in the confluence of lines at certain critical points where combinations may take place? Consider, for example, the configuration after the move 7 ♕g3! from diagram 274, or the geometrical relationships of the various pieces in diagrams 261 and 264, and so on. Or admire the diagonal patterns traced by the pieces in our next position.

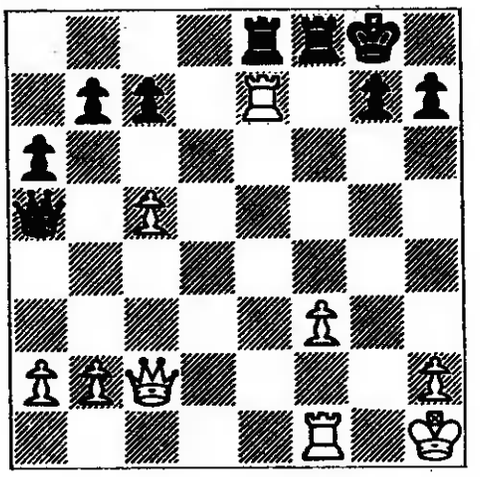
277



Study by Troitsky

1 c6 b2 (or 1 ... ♗e4 2 c7 ♗b7 3 ♗g2! winning) 2 c7 b1♕ 3 c8♕+ ♔a7 4 ♕c7+ ♔a8 (4 ... ♔a6? 5 ♗c8 mate) 5 ♗g2+ ♗e4 6 ♕h7! and the final cross-pin of the black bishop is aesthetically pleasureable, at least to me. Or witness the elegance of the following back-rank mating combination.

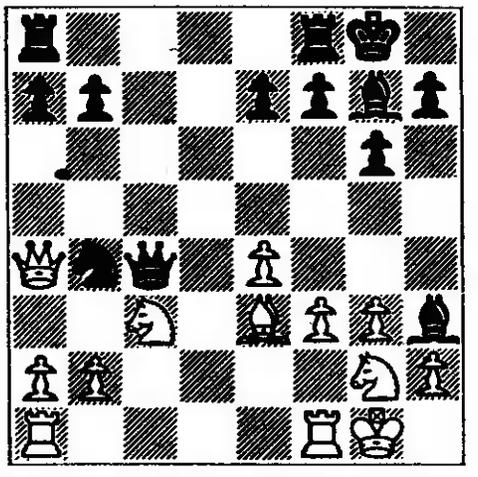
278



Composed position

White wins simply yet dramatically by 1 ♕b3+ ♔h8 2 ♕f7! and as neither the rook or queen can be captured without allowing back-rank mate, Black must play 2 ... ♖g8 losing to 3 ♖xe8 and mate next move. Similarly, who cannot enjoy the geometry of the following combination?

279



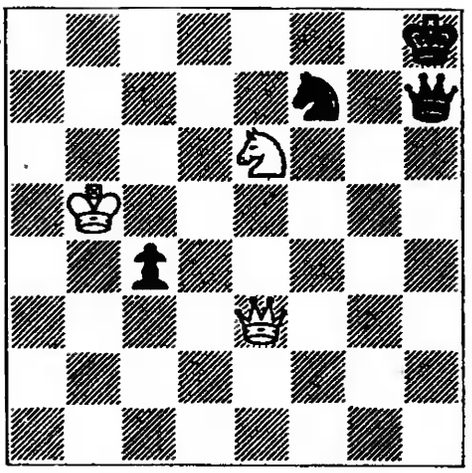
Hamann—Brinck-Claussen
Hastings, 1962

Black plans a discovery followed by a knight fork winning a piece, so he first removes the knight support for White's bishop and

brings the king to g2, then he eliminates the other knight which is defending the queen: 1 ... ♗xg2! 2 ♔xg2 ♗xc3! 3 bc and now comes the point 3 ... ♘d5! 4 ♕xc4 ♘xe3+ 5 ♔f2 ♘xc4 6 Resigns. Easy, but would the reader have seen the idea?

Interesting geometrical patterns are created by certain zig-zag or repetitive manoeuvres which at first seem meaningless but whose significance gradually emerges from the play. Consider the following study.

280

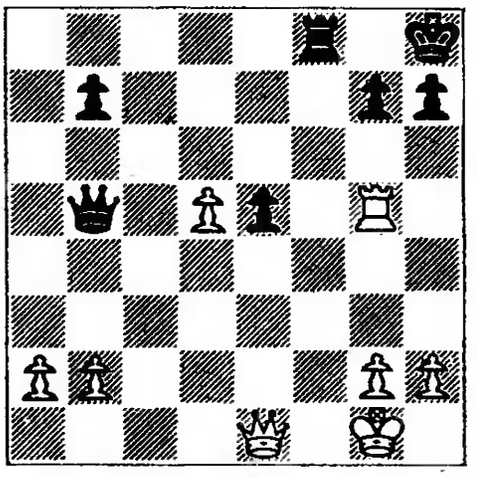


Study by Gaja

An intriguing sequence of moves allows White's queen to reach the desired a1 square, as follows: 1 ♕c3+! (but not 1 ♕d4+? ♔g8 2 ♕g4+ ♘g5! 3 ♕xg5+ ♔f7 drawing) 1 ... ♔g8 2 ♕g3+ ♔h8 (whereas now 2 ... ♘g5 loses to 3 ♕b8+! ♔f7 4 ♘xg5+ winning the queen) 3 ♕b8+ ♕g8 4 ♕h2+ ♕h7 5 ♕b2+! ♔g8 6 ♕g2+ ♔h8 7 ♕a8+ ♕g8 8 ♕h1+! ♕h7 9 ♕a1+! and the whole logic of the bewildering sequence finally emerges, since the white queen can now reach the back rank with Black's king on g8 rather than h8. After 9 ... ♔g8 10 ♕a8+ ♘d8 11 ♕xd8+ ♔f7 12 ♘g5+ the black queen falls.

Here is a similar zig-zag manoeuvre by a queen based on back-rank mate and deflection.

281

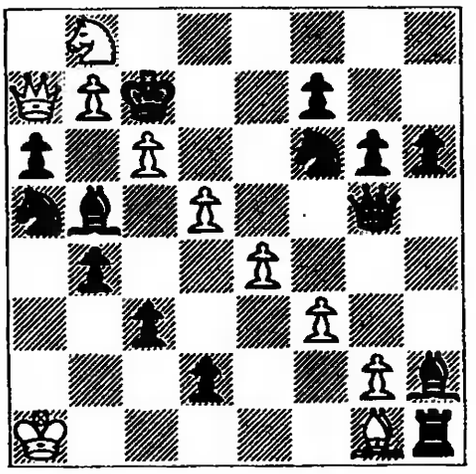


Lowski-Tartakower
Jurata, 1937

How can Black exploit the exposed rook? Here is the answer: 1 ... ♕c5+ 2 ♔h1 ♕c4! 3 ♔g1 ♕d4+ 4 ♔h1 ♕e4! (but not 4 ... ♕d2? 5 ♖xe5) 5 ♕c1 (or 5 ♕g1 ♕e2 or 5 ♕d1 ♕f4. Note that if Black had played 4 ... ♕f4 White had 5 h4) 5 ... ♕d3 6 ♔g1 ♕d4+ 7 ♔h1 ♕d2!! and this move now forces resignation.

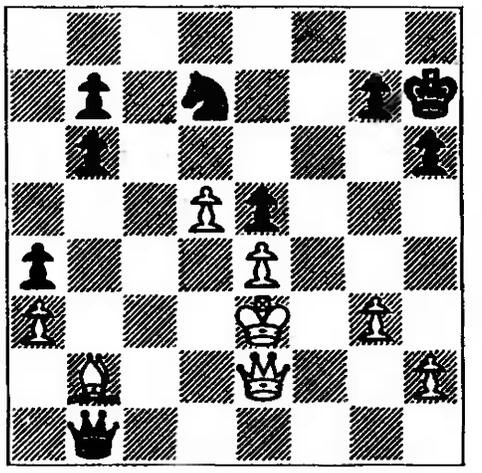
The next problem by Rinck is an amusing illustration of a forced sequence in which the king is brought down the board and then driven back purely to block the king's flight squares!

282



White to mate in 15 moves!

283



Pirc-Lilienthal
Warsaw, 1935

1 ♕b6+ ♔d6 2 ♕c5+ ♔e5 (if the king retreats the solution is shortened) 3 ♕d4+ ♔f4 4 ♕e3+ ♔g3 5 ♕f2+ ♔f4 6 g3+ ♗xg3 7 ♕e3+ ♔e5 8 f4+ ♕xf4 9 ♕d4+ ♔d6 10 e5+ ♕xe5 11 ♕c5+ ♔c7 12 d6+ ♕xd6 13 ♕b6+ ♔xb8 14 c7+ ♕xc7 15 ♕a7 mate.

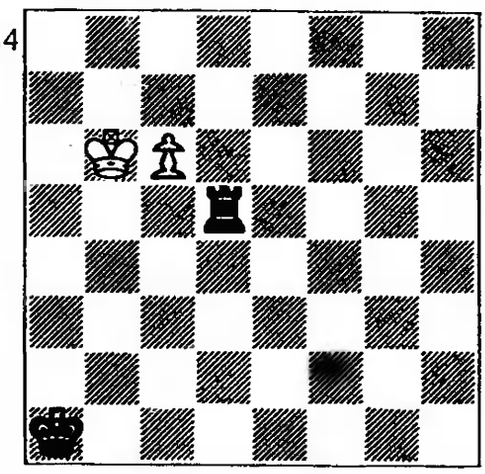
To end this section we offer a splendid piece of play, resembling a composed study, in which geometrical motifs are clearly apparent. With 1 ... b5! Black first decoys the white queen to b5 and after 2 ♕xb5 (if 2 ♕g4 ♕e1+ 3 ♔d3 ♘c5+ wins, since the b pawn guards c4) 2 ... ♘c5! this knight cannot be captured in view of the check on g1, so the e4 pawn must now fall. We give the remainder of the play without comment: 3 ♕c4 b5! 4 ♕xb5 ♕xe4+ 5 ♔d2 ♕xd5+ 6 ♔c3 ♕d4+ 7 ♔c2 ♕f2+ 8 ♔b1 ♕f5+ 9 ♔a2 ♕c2 10 ♕b4 ♘e4! 11 ♕e1 ♘d2 12 ♕c1 ♕b3+ 13 ♔a1 ♘c4 14 ♕c3 ♕xb2+! and everything is exchanged, giving Black a won pawn ending.

8 Tactical Finesses

The relationship between tactics and strategy is a complex one, since each depends closely on the other. Pure reason and logic which guide us in the formulation of our strategic plans, whilst being vital to chess thinking, must sometimes give way to chance factors which a master learns to recognise by experience. It is often only after the event that the analyst can point to the positional basis of these tactical elements, whereas during the game it is the practised eye of an Alekhine which discerns that seemingly incongruous juxtaposition of factors leading to a decisive combination. This chapter is devoted to this almost unteachable aspect of chess.

Let us begin with a justly famous study by Saavedra. (*See Diagram 284*)

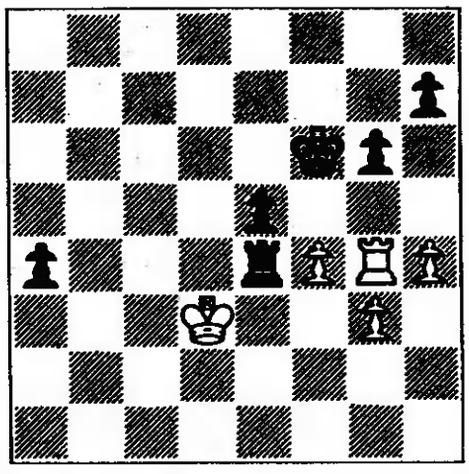
284



Study by Saavedra

The first five moves by White are readily comprehensible because they are forced if White wishes to avoid the draw: **1 c7 ♖d6+! 2 ♔b5** (clearly 2 ♔b7? ♖d7 draws and 2 ♔a5? ♖c6 even loses, whilst 2 ♔c5? allows 2 ... ♖d1! drawing, since 3 c8=♕ ♖c1+ wins for Black) **2 ... ♖d5+ 3 ♔b4 ♖d4+ 4 ♔b3 ♖d3+ 5 ♔c2!** and it looks all over for Black, but . . . the chance factor turns out to be the black king on a1 (note that if it had been on b1 the draw would have been forced!), giving Black an opportunity to play the brilliant **5 ... ♖d4!** intending to answer 6 c8♕ with 6 ... ♖c4+! 7 ♕xc4 stalemate! However, by a strange quirk of fate it is now White's chance to exploit the positon of the black king by playing **6 c8♖!!** threatening mate on a8 and thus forcing **6 ... ♖a4** when **7 ♔b3!** wins the rook or mates on c1. A beautiful study.

285

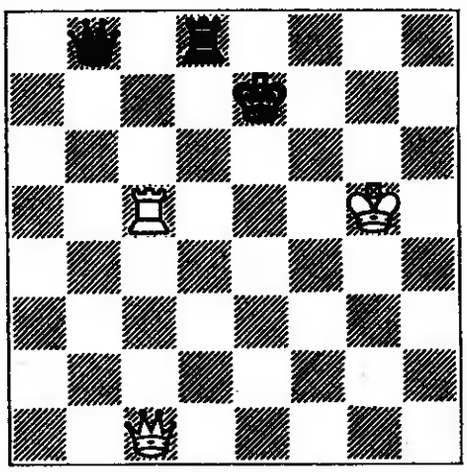


Flohr-Geller
Moscow, 1949

Black is admittedly a pawn up, but White is threatening fe+ drawing comfortably. However, 1 ... ♔g7!! puts matters in their proper perspective, since 2 ♔xe4 or 2 ♖g5 both lose at once to 2 ... a3! so after 2 ♔c3 a3 3 ♔b3 h5! 4 ♖g5 ef 5 gf ♖xf4 the two connected passed pawns win the ending easily for Black.

Now for two more studies.

286



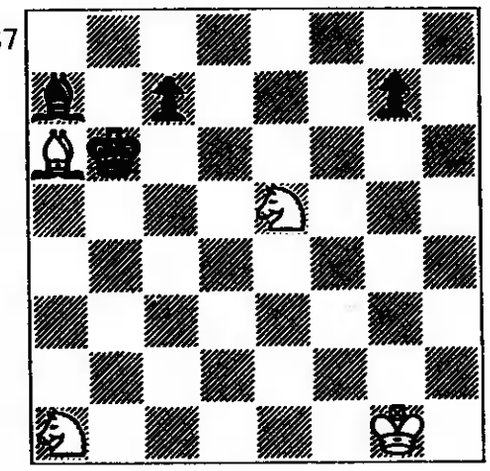
Study by Rinck

White has the advantage because he is controlling more space and, even more importantly, he has the first move. However, Black manages to ward off the immediate attack without great difficulty, and it is only then that a deep tactical finesse destroys his set-up. Play proceeds as follows: 1 ♖c7+ ♖d7 (a king move to d6, e8 or e6 allows mate in two, three and five moves respectively) 2 ♕c5+ ♔d8 (forced if he is not to lose rook or queen) 3 ♔h6!! an incredible move that places Black in zugzwang, winning at once, the variations being:

1) 3 ... ♕xc7 4 ♕f8 mate
2) 3 ... ♖xc7 4 ♕f8+ winning the queen, when the resulting ♕ v ♖ ending is won
3) 3 ... ♕b3 4 ♖c8 mate
4) 3 ... ♖d1 4 ♕e7 mate.

The reader can examine for himself why king moves other than 3 ♔h6 do not succeed, and thus convince himself about the chance-factor that, if the whole position were moved one square to the right, there would be no win!

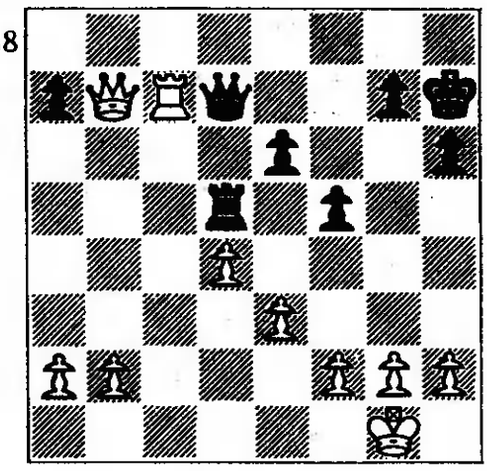
287



Study by Ratner

Purely strategic concepts will hardly help White here, since on the surface all we can say is that his bishop is attacked and, once it moves, Black's bishop will reach d4 winning one of the knights and thus drawing. It is only when we examine concrete tactical variations that an astonishing idea emerges. Let us proceed to the solution: 1 ♗e2! (here rather than c8, because the black king must not be allowed to reach b5, as we shall see) 1 ... ♔b7+ 2 ♔g2 ♗d4 3 ♘b3! ♗xe5 4 ♘a5+! ♔a8! (the first important tactical point becomes apparent, as both 4 ... ♔b6 5 ♘c4+ and 4 ... ♔c8 5 ♗g4+ followed by 6 ♘c6+ win the bishop for White. Note that now the obvious 5 ♗f3+? c6! only gives White a draw) 5 ♘c6! ♗d6 6 ♗a6!! and suddenly we realize that once White's king arrives at c8 there is a forced mate on b7. However, we can now understand the importance of White's second move of his king to g2, since he now wins by playing his king to f3 before Black's g pawn can reach g4. After 6 ... g5 7 ♔f3! it is clear that the black bishop can only watch helplessly while the king proceeds to c8 along the white squares, and the g pawn cannot even succeed in queening before mate is announced! Lasker thought highly of this original study.

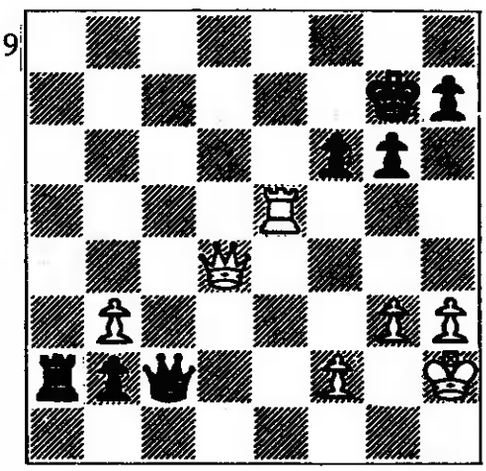
288



Yugoslavia, 1949

On the previous move White could have exchanged queens with an easily won rook ending, but one can hardly blame him for thinking that this position is resignable for Black. Indeed, White's only weakness is his undefended back rank, but how can Black exploit this factor? Here's how: 1 ... ♖c5!! which must have come as a dreadful shock to the conductor of the white pieces. If he wants to avoid mate, he must lose either his rook or his queen. Amazing!

289

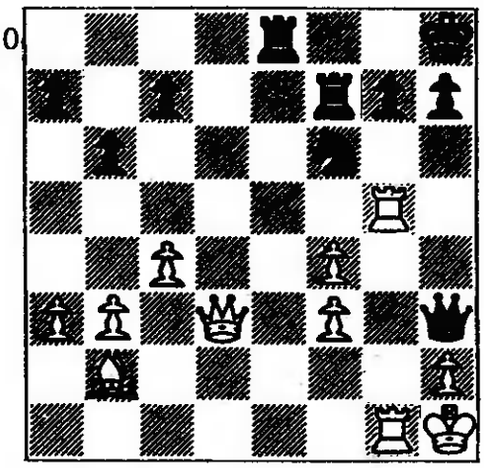


N.N.–Alekhine

Black might have won by 1 ... fe, but how much simpler was Alekhine's solution to the problem, exploiting the fact that the white king is on h2: 1 ... ♕xf2+! 2 ♕xf2 fe! and there is no way White can stop the b pawn queening.

We feel sure that by now the reader is aware of the importance of a high level of tactical understanding, if one is to win won positions or even defend lost ones. Here is an example of the latter.

290

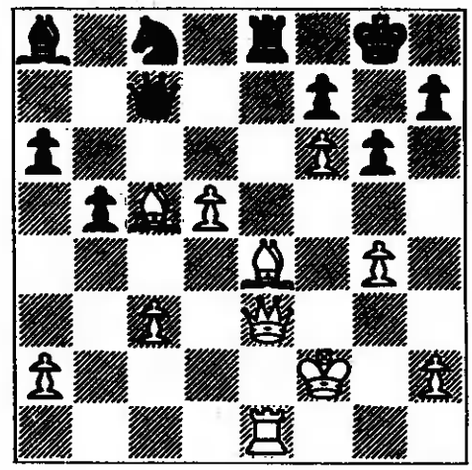


Uhlmann–Dely
Debrecen, 1962

White wrongly thinks it is all too easy after 1 ♖xg7? ♖xg7 2 ♗xf6 and completely misses the devastating 2 ... ♕g2+! forcing mate in three moves. Alas, how often this has happened even to the best of players . . .

Here is the opposite case.

291

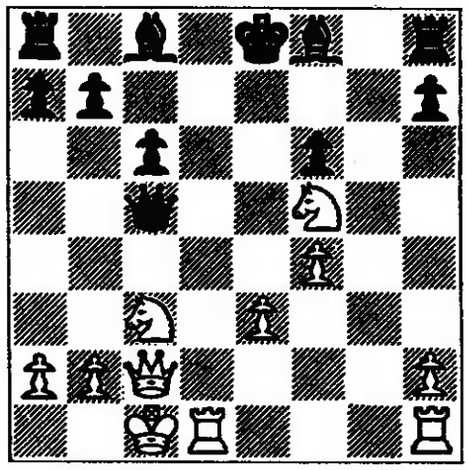


Dely–Hajtun
Hungary, 1954

Black is sure that he has prevented White's next move, but 1 ♕h6!! is played nevertheless, because after 1 ... ♕xc5+ 2 ♖e3! ♕f8 White has the startling 3 ♗xg6! ♕xh6 (3 ... hg 4 ♖xe8 mates) 4 ♖xe8+ ♕f8 5 ♗xh7+! ♔xh7 6 ♖xf8 and White comes out of the exchange ahead with an easily won ending.

The following example in which I was the unfortunate victim, contains a tactical finesse which was most difficult to see in advance, even taking into account my desperate need to make excuses! (*See Diagram 292*)
Although White has a positional advantage, mainly because Black's game is undeveloped, he makes the mistake of thinking he can force an immediate win by 1 ♕e4+? (he should play 1 ♘g3 ♗d7 2 ♖d4 0-0-0 3 ♖hd1 with a continued plus) 1 ... ♔f7 2 ♖d8? (2 ♘g3 was still essential) 2 ... ♗xf5 3 ♕e8+ ♔g7 4 ♖xa8. This was the position

292

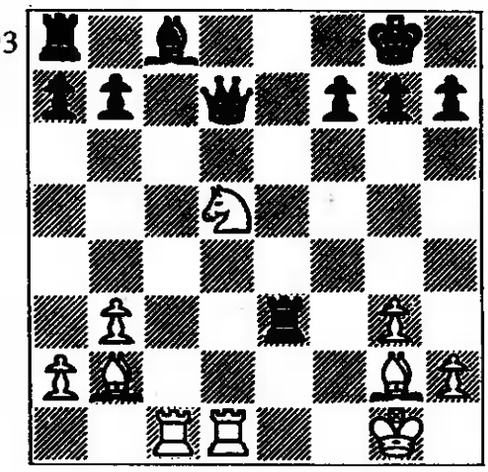


Kotov–Zaitsev
Sochi, 1967

I had visualised when launching the 'combination', feeling that the material advantage of the exchange and the placing of Black's king would ensure the win. However, after Zaitsev's next subtle tactical blow 4 ... ♔h6!! the situation has suddenly swung round, with the king snug on h6 and the threat of ... ♗g7 rearing its ugly head. Truly, the game of chess is sometimes unfathomable! I thought about the position for a whole hour without finding a way out, and the game ended: 5 ♖e1 ♗g7 6 ♕xh8 ♗xh8 7 ♖xh8 b5! 8 a3 a5 9 e4 ♕f2! 10 ♖e2 ♕xf4+ 11 ♖d2 ♗g6 12 b4 ab 13 ab c5! 14 bc b4 15 ♘d1 ♕xe4 and White resigned a few moves later.

A similar situation arose in the game Opočensky–Alekhine, where White had sacrificed his queen for what he thought was a dangerous initiative.

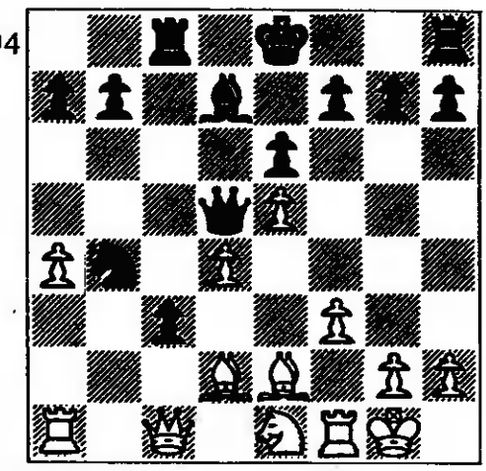
293



Opočensky–Alekhine
1941

However, play went: 1 ... ♖e2! so White decided to settle for a draw with 2 ♘c7 ♕e7 3 ♘xa8 when he was expecting Black to take a draw by perpetual by sacrificing his rook for the bishop on g2, only to be surprised by the cunning 3 ... ♗h3! a totally unexpected tactical finesse based on the fact that if White captures the intrepid bishop it is mate in four moves. The game ended: 4 ♖d8+ ♕xd8 5 ♗xh3 ♕xa8 and White resigned.

294



Donner–Kotov
Venice, 1950

Black to move has much the better of it, but if he merely recovers his piece there is a long hard struggle in prospect. This is a position in which tactical alertness is at a premium and I managed to find the excellent **1 ... ♘a2! 2 ♖xa2.** Note that the four possible queen moves also lose as follows:

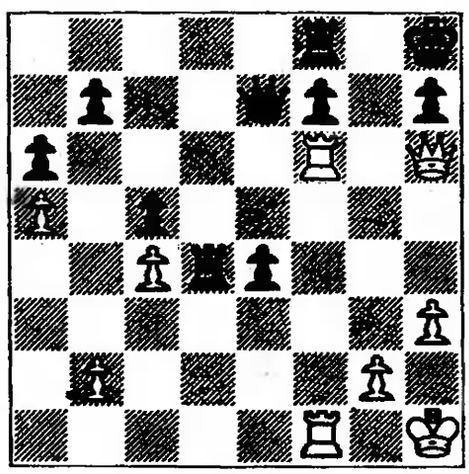
a) **2 ♕a3** cd **3 ♖xa2** de♕ **4 ♖xe1 ♕xd4+** followed by **5 ... ♕xe5;**

b) **2 ♕c2 ♕xd4+ 3 ♔h1** cd **4 ♕xa2** de♕ **5 ♖xe1 ♗c6** with a healthy extra pawn;

c) **2 ♕b1 ♕xd4+ 3 ♔h1** cd **4 ♘c2 ♕xe5** etc;

d) **2 ♕d1 ♕xd4+ 3 ♔h1 ♕xd2 4 ♕xd2** cd **5 ♖xa2** de♕ etc. **2 ... ♕xa2 3 ♗g5! h6!** (not falling for the trap of **3 ... ♕xe2 4 ♕a3!**) **4 ♗d3** hg **5 ♕xg5 ♕d2! 6 f4** (after **6 ♕xg7 ♖f8** Black's passed pawn proves decisive) **6 ... ♗c6!** (another tactical blow to answer **7 ♕xg7** with **7 ... ♕e3+ 8 ♔h1 ♕h3! 9 ♘f3 ♗xf3 10 ♗b5+ ♖c6!** winning) **7 ♕g3 g6 8 Resigns.**

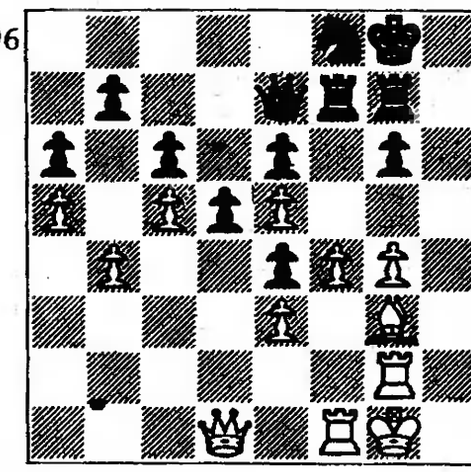
295



Karasiev–Klaman
USSR, 1969

One of the great difficulties in defending is recognising the unexpected in good time. In the present position, Black may have thought he was holding everything, since he can answer **1 ♖g6** with **1 ... ♖g8,** failing to realize that if first **1 ♖e6! ♕d8 2 ♖g6!** then **2 ... ♖g8** is parried by **3 ♖xf7!** when Black can only offer a few spite checks before resigning. Nevertheless, a good tactician can often unearth surprising defensive resources, if he can coolly appraise the strengths and weaknesses of his opponent's attacking possibilities. Here are two worthy adversaries at work.

296

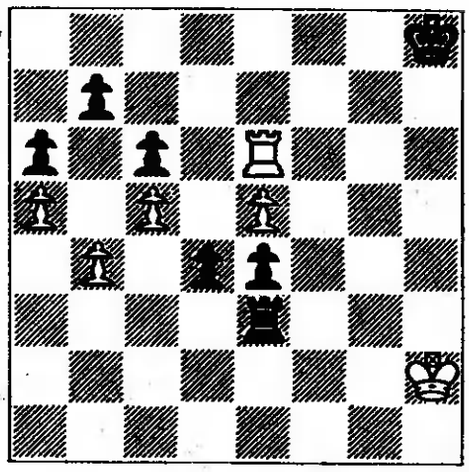


Alekhine–Euwe
Match, 1927

White has the more active position, so Euwe decides to play **1 ... ♔h8!** inviting White to win the queen by **2 ♗h4? ♕xh4! 3 ♖h2 ♖h7 4 ♖xh4 ♖xh4** and suddenly Alekhine has problems. After **5 ♕e2 ♖fh7 6 ♕g2 ♖h3** he realizes that if he guards his e3 pawn with his rook the black rooks will post them-

selves powerfully on f3 and h3, so he decides to head for a rook ending which has some swindling chances. Play continued: **7 f5! gf 8 gf ♖g7 9 fe! ♘xe6 10 ♖f6 ♖hg3 11 ♕xg3 ♖xg3+ 12 ♔h2! ♖xe3 13 ♖xe6 d4?** (Alekhine's bluff succeeds. Black would have good winning chances with 13 ... ♖f3!) giving us the following position:

297

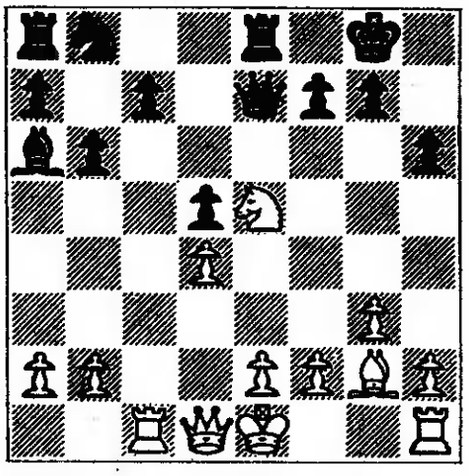


On the principle that it is vital to restrict the enemy king in such situations, Alekhine now played **14 ♖g6!** and drew after **14 ... ♔h7 15 ♖g2 ♖f3 16 ♖g4.**

Here is another example of tactics used in defence. (*See Diagram 298*)

At first sight, White's position seems preferable with the strongly centralised knight and pressure down the long white diagonal, but on closer examination there are weaknesses present which are highlighted by the fact that he is slightly behind in development, whereas once Black has played

298

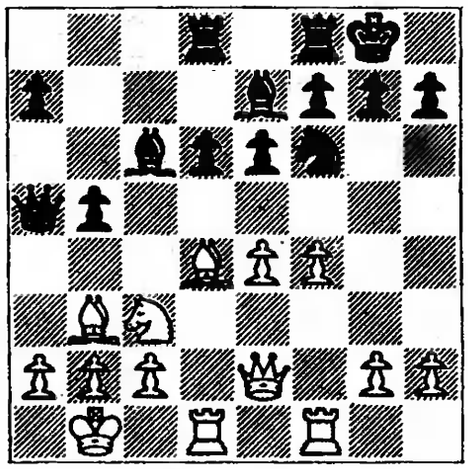


Uhlmann–Veresov
E. Germany v Byelorussia, 1969

1 ... ♘d7! 2 ♖xc7 ♖ac8! he is fully mobilised, as can be seen in the variation **3 ♖xd7? ♕b4+ 4 ♔f1 ♕xd4!** winning. Play continued: **3 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 4 0-0** (not of course **4 ♘xd7 ♖c1!**) **4 ... ♘xe5 5 de ♕xe5 6 ♖e1** d4 and Black has achieved a positional plus which won the game for him.

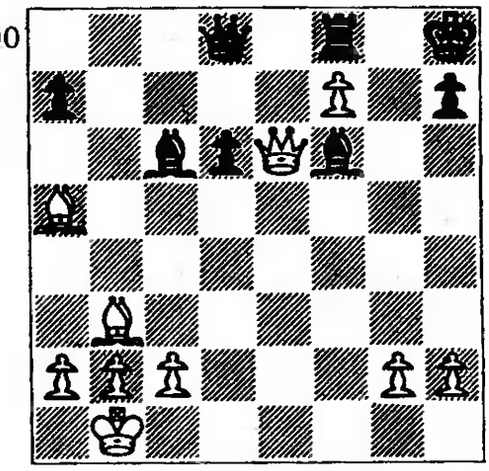
When we come to sharp tactical positions in which it is unclear who stands better, it is no longer a question of which strategic plan to follow but rather a matter of life or death in the full use of all combinative weapons at our disposal. 'First come, first served' seems to be the motto here, however primitive such a view may be. Consider the complex position arising after the following sharp opening variation: **1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cd 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 ♘c6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 ♗e7 8 ♗b3 0-0 9 ♕e2 ♕a5 10 0-0-0 ♘xd4 11 ♗xd4 ♗d7 12 ♔b1 ♗c6 13 f4 ♖ad8 14 ♖hf1 b5.**

299



Fischer–Geller
Skopje, 1969

300



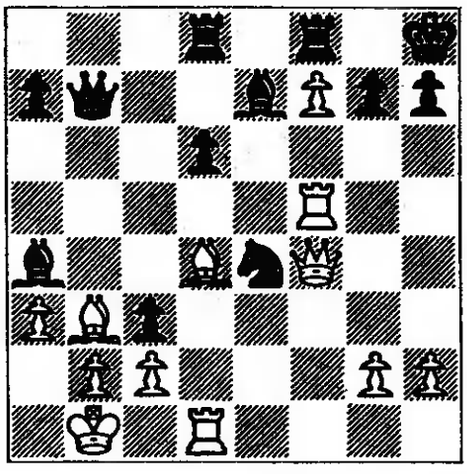
Sub-variation of Fischer–Geller

White has the initiative but Black is not without counter-chances. Fischer decides to strike while the iron is hot by sacrificing a piece for the attack, as follows: **15 f5!** b4 **16 fe!** bc **17 ef+** (Fischer must also have considered the interesting 17 ♖xf6! which gives us the following possibilities:

a) 17 ... gf and now not 18 ♕g4+ ♕g5! 19 ef+ ♖xf7 20 ♕e6 ♖f8 21 ♕xe7 ♕d2!! etc., but 18 ef+ ♔h8 19 ♕g4 with the unpleasant threat of 20 ♕e6. If now 19 ... ♗d7 20 ♕h4 ♔g7 21 ♖d3 ♖xf7 22 ♖g3+ ♔f8 23 ♕xh7! winning, so Black's best is probably 19 ... ♖b8 intending to protect the bishop on e7 with ... ♕d8, but White still has a powerful attack with 20 ♕e6 ♕d8 21 ♖f1 ♖b4! 22 ♗xc3 ♖xe4 23 ♖xf6! ♖e1+! 24 ♗xe1! ♗xf6 25 ♗a5!! giving us this position. White mates after 25 ... ♕e7 26 ♕xe7 ♗xe7 27 ♗c3+ etc. Or

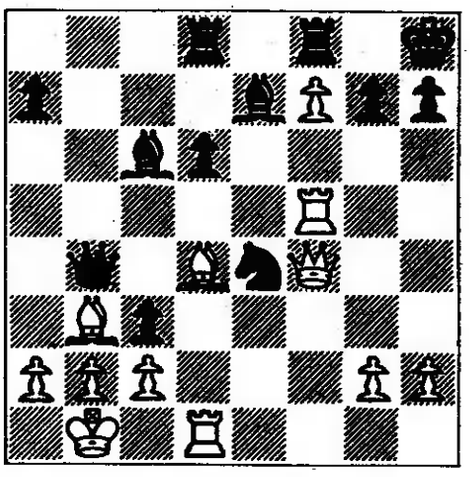
b) **17** ... ♗xf6 18 ♗xf6 gf 19 e7 and Black is lost e.g. 19 ... cb 20 ♕c4 or 19 ... ♖d7 20 ♖d5! ♗xd5 21 ♕g4+ or 19 ... ♕e5 20 ed♕ ♖xd8 21 ♕c4 ♗e8 22 ♕xc3. So it appears that 17 ♖xf6! would have won for Fischer, but the text-move also gives him good attacking chances) **17** ... ♔h8 **18 ♖f5 ♕b4 19 ♕f1!!** (an excellent move which present Black with almost insoluble problems, since now 19 ... ♘d7 loses quickly to 20 ♖h5 ♘e5 21 ♕f5 h6 22 ♕g6!! and if 22 ... ♘xg6 23 ♖xh6 mate, a variation planned by Fischer. Another possibility is 19 ... ♘g4 20 ♗xc3 ♕b7 21 ♖h5! ♗xe4 22 ♗d5 ♗xd5 23 ♕f5 h6 24 ♖xd5 ♘f6 25 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 26 ♖xh6+ gh 27 ♕xf6+ ♔h7 28 ♖h5 mating. So Geller's move offers the best chance) **19** ... ♘xe4 **20 a3? ♕b7 21** ♕f4 (hoping to mate first, but . . .) **21** ... ♗a4!!

301



A tremendous counter-blow that wins the game for Black in surprising fashion. The game ended: 22 ♕g4 ♗f6! 23 ♖xf6 ♗xb3! 24 Resigns. The fault clearly resides in White's 20 a3? which weakens the b3 square. Fischer later gave the winning move as 20 ♕f4!! at once, with the following position.

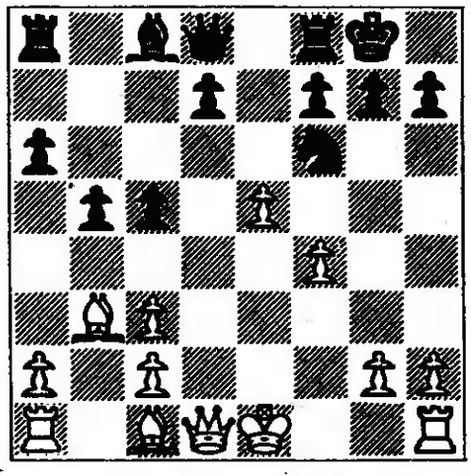
302



Improvement on Fischer–Geller

Black's best would then be 20 ... ♘d2+! 21 ♖xd2 cd 22 c3! with the possible finish 22 ... ♕c5 23 ♔c2! ♗d7 24 ♗xc5 ♗xf5+ 25 ♕xf5 dxc5 26 ♔d1 ♖d6 27 ♕e5 ♖d7 28 ♕e6 ♖b7 29 ♗c2 with a winning game for White. If instead 22 ... ♕xb3 White has 23 ♗xg7+! ♔xg7 24 ♕g4+ ♔h8 25 ♕d4+ and mate next move. I am indebted to the Moscow player Murei for the analysis of the main variations given here, an excellent example of the richness and complexity of chess.

303



Alekhine–Réti
Vienna, 1922

This is the finish of another sharply-played game in which both sides make the most of their chances. Before we consider White's first move, let us examine a few alternatives:

a) 1 ef ♖e8+ 2 ♔f1 c4 with good play for Black;

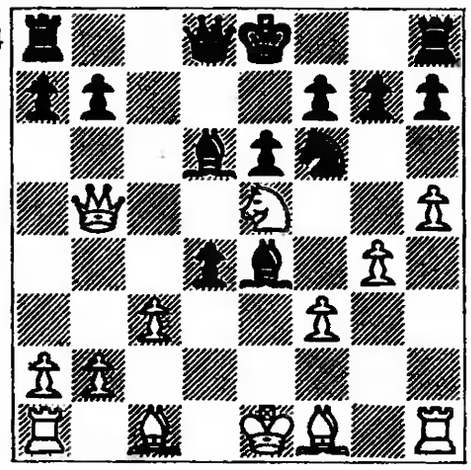
b) 1 c4 d5! 2 ef ♕xf6 followed by 3 ... dc;

c) 1 0-0 c4 2 ef ♕xf6 3 ♕d5 ♕b6+ 4 ♔h1 ♗b7;

d) 1 ♗d5 ♘xd5 2 ♕xd5 ♕b6! 3 ♗e3 ♗b7 4 ♕xc5 ♕g6!.

In all cases, Black is well placed, so Alekhine found the excellent 1 ♗a3! ♕a5! 2 0-0! ♕xa3 3 ef c4 4 ♕d5! ♕a5! (blow and counter-blow; 5 ♕xa8 would now be answered by 5 ... ♕b6+ and 6 ... ♗b7, but Alekhine's ideas are not yet exhausted) 5 fg! ♕b6+ 6 ♔h1 ♔xg7 7 ♗xc4! (the point, since now 7 ... bxc4 would allow 8 ♕xa8 ♗b7 9 ♖ab1!) 7 ... ♗b7! 8 ♕e5+ ♕f6 and White had the edge, although Réti managed to draw by skilful end-game play.

304

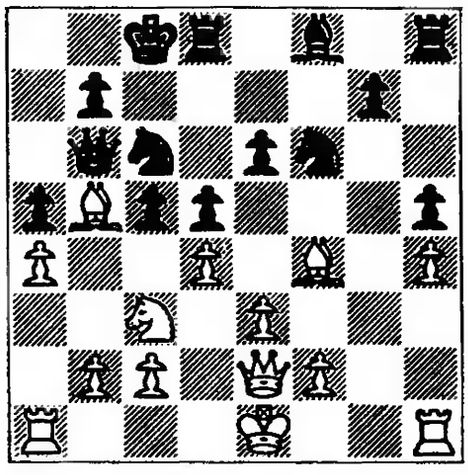


Karpov–Zaitsev
Kuibyshev, 1970

A complex middle-game position has arisen with hair-raising possibilities which neither side can fully calculate and yet which both have to accept of necessity. The future World Champion's style would normally incline towards a controlled plan of campaign but he is here driven willy-nilly into the whirlpool of tactical complications. Play went: 1 ... ♘d7 2 ♘xf7! (the strongest but at the same time most committal continuation; however, 2 ♘xd7 ♗c6! or 2 ♕xd7+ ♕xd7 3 ♘xd7 ♗xf3 or finally 2 fe ♗xe5 are all good for Black) 2 ... ♗g3+ 3 ♔e2 d3+! 4 ♔e3 ♕f6 5 ♔xe4! ♕xf7 6 ♖h3 a6 7 ♕g5 h6? (missing the chance of punishing White for his boldness with 7 ... e5! 8 ♖xg3 ♘c5+ 9 ♔e3 0-0 10 ♖h3 ♖ad8 and White's king is in trouble e.g. 11 ♗g2 ♘e4! 12 fxe4 ♕f2 mate, or here 12 ♔xe4 ♕d5+ 13 ♔e3 ♕c5+ 14 ♔e4 ♖d4+ etc.) 8 ♕e3 e5 9 ♔xd3 ♗f4 10 ♕g1 0-0-0 11 ♔c2 and Karpov finally managed to find a safe haven for his king and achieve victory.

So-called 'traps' are part and parcel of a player's armoury. In contrast with the combination, our opponent is not compelled to fall into the traps we set, which is why it is rarely advantageous to set a trap which is contrary to the demands of the position. In such cases, if the ploy fails, we are left with the worse of it, a situation only really acceptable if we are already desperate and have nothing to lose. On the other hand, a good trap which fits in with our strategic plans can be a most effective weapon, because the elements of surprise and disguise are then at their highest. Here is a classic example of two worthy opponents setting cunning traps for each other.

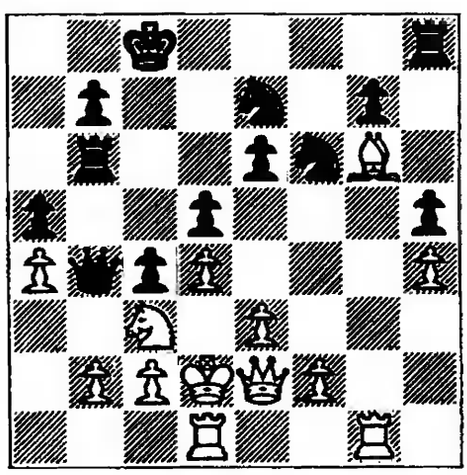
305



Nimzowitsch–Alekhine
Vilnius, 1912

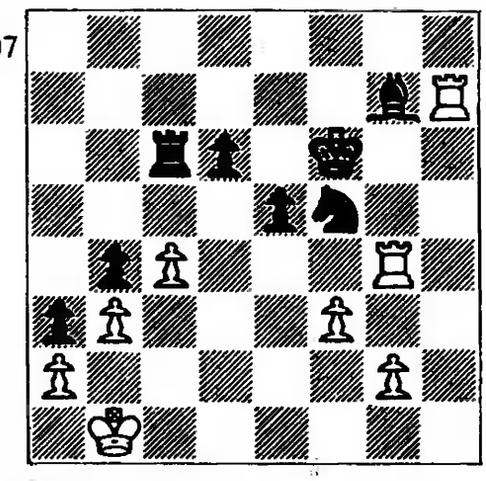
Nimzowitsch begins the process with **1 0-0-0!** an excellent, natural move completing his development, whilst at the same time inviting Alekhine to go in for 1 ... cd 2 ed ♘xd4 when 3 ♖xd4! ♕xd4 4 ♕xe6+ ♘d7 5 ♕xc6+! bc 6 ♗a6 mate would produce an attractive finish. Alekhine sees through this and replies **1 ... ♗d6 2 ♗xd6 ♖xd6 2 ♗d3 c4!** taking advantage of the bishop's retreat to launch his own attack. After 4 ♗g6 ♘e7 5 ♖hg1 ♕b4 6 ♔d2 ♖b6! we reach the following position.

306



We now have a case of double-bluff, with Alekhine threatening to fall into a trap by playing 7 ... ♘xg6 8 ♖xg6 ♕xb2! 9 ♖b1 after which 9 ... ♕xc3+! 10 ♔xc3 ♘e4 mate follows, a line which would also work after 7 ♗f7. Note that both the above traps form a natural part of the play. White immediately prevented all this by 7 f3 but his bishop was trapped after 7 ... ♖h6 8 ♗f7 ♘f5 9 ♕h2 ♕e7 and he resigned a few moves later.

307



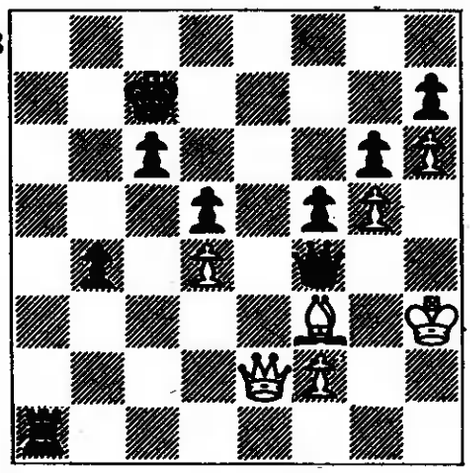
Averbakh–Gulko
Moscow, 1970

Here we have a case of the desperate situation we mentioned, in which anything goes. Clearly, White has a lost game if he plays passively, so why not set a trap for his young opponent? If he plays correctly, so what, the game is lost at all events. Averbakh produced **1 c5!?** dc? (he had to capture with the rook, winning) **2 ♖gxg7!** and after 2 ... ♘xg7 3 ♖h6+ the rook on c6 is lost.

The stalemate idea is always a

fruitful source of traps in lost positions. Here, the would-be trapper is hoist with his own petard:

308

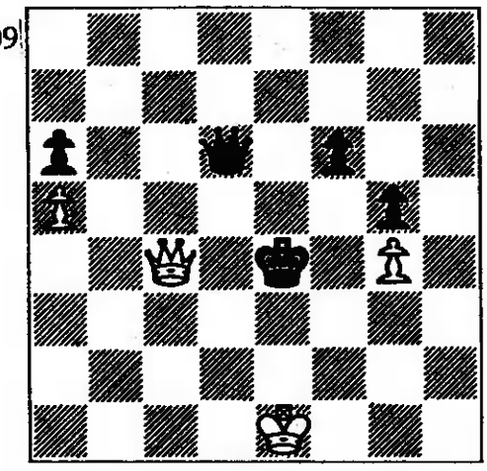


Composed position

Black could win comfortably with 1 ... ♔d6 or 1 ... ♖a3 but decides to simplify at once with 1 ... ♕xf3+? 2 ♕xf3 ♖a3 only to discover that the simple reply 3 ♔h4! ♖xf3 gives stalemate!

Here is another stalemate example.

309



Matulović–Botvinnik
Belgrade, 1970

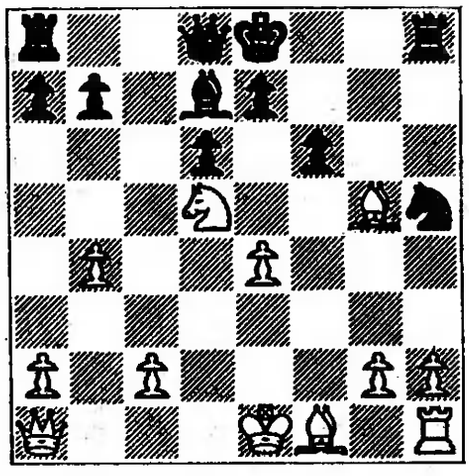
Black has adopted the correct strategy of advancing his king fearlessly in such situations, but because he sees that 1 ... ♔e3 2 ♕e2+ ♔f4? loses to 3 ♕h2+ and he does not wish to retreat his king, he plays 1 ... ♔f3? hoping for 2 ♕e2+ ♔g3 3 ♕f2+? ♔xg4. Unfortunately for him, the move 2 ♕d3+! ♕xd3 produces a typical queen ending stalemate, as it would also, in purer form(!), after 2 ♕e2+ ♔g3 3 ♕d3+! etc. When such a great player as Botvinnik can fail to see such a tactical finesse, the reader must be convinced of the vital importance of tactics in the game of chess.

9 Conclusion

We have examined a wide range of combinations, some fairly simple and others more complex, but have only touched upon the ways in which a player can improve his abilities in this field. Is combinative skill innate or acquired? Can we learn tactics and, if so, how? Can a player pursue individual study or is a formal training programme required? These are questions which have occupied chess pedagogues for nearly two centuries and to which we attempt an answer in this section, but only briefly, since we have dealt with this issue at great length in other Batsford volumes to which a keen reader will surely refer. Grandmasters are, of course, necessarily equally proficient in both tactics and strategy, but even here chess styles vary greatly. A Tal or a Bronstein will deliberately seek tactical complications, because they not only enjoy such situations but also have the self-confidence which stems from experience and practice at the highest levels, whereas a Petrosian or a Polugayevsky will seek the logical path of strategic principles, whilst being fully prepared at all moments to display their own by no means negligible tactical prowess. This is all to do with the different temperament, background and training of each player, but there is no doubt that combinative skill is a must for every top-class player, whatever his individual predilections may be. Let us now examine this skill more closely.

First of all, it demands the rapid and sound calculation of variations along with a methodical approach which is essential until one has acquired the speed and instinct of an Alekhine or a Fischer. In the initial stages, *all relevant moves are listed mentally*, making sure that no playable move is left out. This is important, because if we get bogged down too early in a complex variation we tend to neglect possibilities which may well save us all this trouble. On rapidly examining these lines, taking into account our own plans and the possible counter-plans of our opponent, we arrive at a group of tree (main line) variations with a number of branches (sub-variations) leading off from each and sometimes intertwined. *It is essential to consider these sub-variations methodically but once only*, as a mental discipline which will help to stave off time-trouble and avoid confused thinking. Here is a practical example of what we mean.

310



Platonov–Polugayevsky
USSR, 1969

Rasuvayev has carried out an analysis of this position on the lines of the method described. In the game White lost valuable time by playing 17 ♗h4? 'whereas the position needs to be handled energetically with three moves of the other bishop coming into consideration, to e2, d3 and c4'. He then proceeds to analyse each main line in methodical fashion, the gist of which we give here:

a) 17 ♗e2 ♔f7 18 0-0 ♗c6 19 ♗xh5+ ♖xh5 20 ♘xf6 ef 21 ♗xf6 ♕g8 22 ♗g7+ ♔e8 23 ♖f8+ ♕xf8 24 ♗xf8 with advantage.

b) 17 ♗d3 ♖g8 (or 17 ... ♘g3? 18 ♖g1 ♖xh2? 19 ♗f4) 18 ♗e3 ♖xg2 19 ♗e2 ♗g4 20 ♗xg4 ♖xg4 21 ♕d1. Rasuvayev then concludes that 18 ♗h4 is better in this variation.

c) 17 ♗c4 ♖c8 18 ♗b3 ♖g8! 19 ♘xf6+ ef 20 ♗xg8 fg and Black has dangerous counterplay.

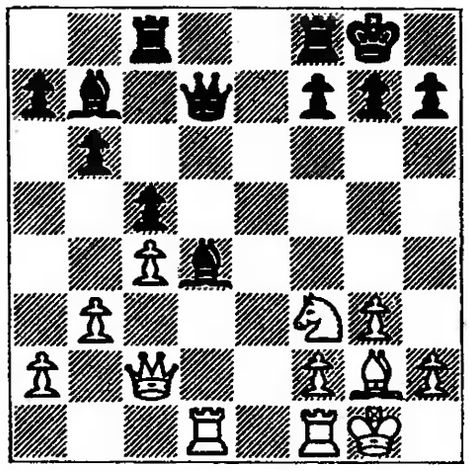
The conclusion was then reached that 17 ♗d3 would have been the best move. This is an approach we strongly recommend, but note that it helps little as regards our ability to assess the variations we are calculating. For this we need practical tournament experience, participation in special training tournaments, tests in solving problems, studies and game positions. In the latter case the student should try to find the strongest moves in a given position without moving the pieces, writing down the variations as he discovers them and experimenting with the method proposed. If he can afterwards compare his own analysis with an expert's annotations, all the better, or he can even read through an annotated game and stop at any given diagram to make his own calculations and evaluation before moving on, without cheating, of course!

The second difficulty facing us is to select the main moves we are to analyse, but again this can sometimes be a matter of style. Chekhover, for example, before making any move, used to ask himself the question: which piece can I threaten? Only when he had made sure he was not missing any possibilitiy would he begin his selection of possible moves. There are some masters, however, whose thought processes are so complex

and individual that they consider moves few others would even think about. For example, during a tournament masters and grandmasters had a bet on who could anticipate the moves of Kopylov, and it was only after a half dozen or so unsuccessful attempts that Bronstein (himself no stranger to the unexpected move) managed to discover one of Kopylov's intended moves!

This is of course an exceptional case, but every chess-player must develop the art of seeking out hidden and unexpected resources which at first sight seem anti-positional. The inner logic of a position can often be very different from our first superficial assessment, and imagination and originality have important parts to play in the creative development of a player. Let us end this volume appropriately by quoting a few examples of mind over matter.

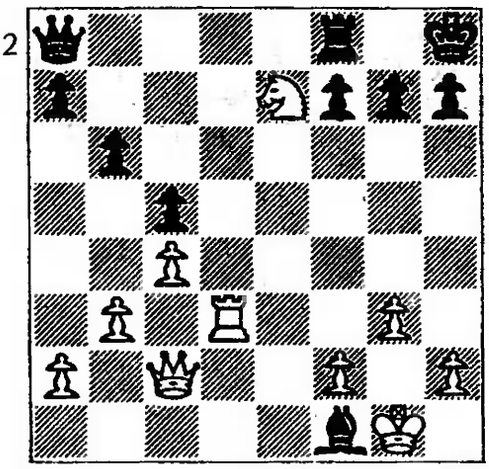
311



Lengyel-Sliwa
Polanica Zdroj, 1966

In this position White launches a complicated combination in which he has seen further than his opponent. Play goes: **1 ♘xd4 ♗xg2 2 ♘f5 ♕b7 3 ♘d6 ♕f3 4 ♖d3 ♕a8 5 ♘xc8 ♗xf1 6 ♘e7+ ♔h8.**

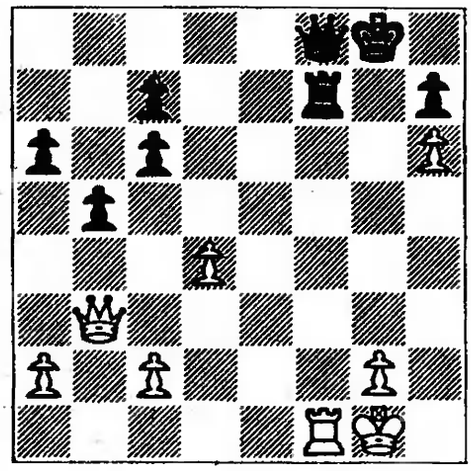
312



Both players had visualised this position but with different assessments. Sliwa had calculated the continuation 7 ♔xf1 ♕h1+ 8 ♔e2 ♕e4+ followed by 9 ... ♕xe7, whereas Lengyel had discovered the splendid move 7 ♖d5!! which brought about an immediate resignation. Why? Because Black's bishop is lost in view of the sudden threat of 8 ♕xh7+ ♔xh7 9 ♖h5 mate! An attractive piece of imaginative play.

Sometimes even a gifted grandmaster can miss a subtle finesse or an unusual sequence. Take the following position.

313



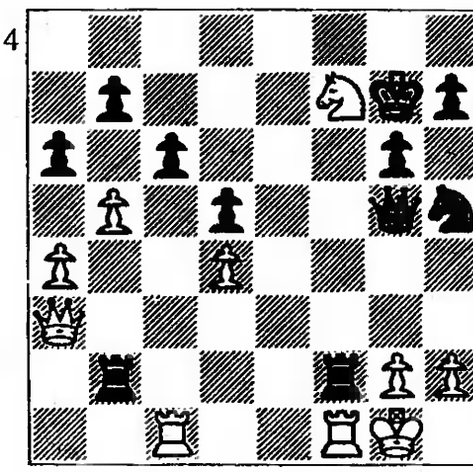
Damjanović–Lutikov
Sarajevo, 1969

White played 1 ♕e6? thinking he could get nowhere with checking the black king, whereas a little more examination of the checking sequences would have produced the forced win by **1 ♕g3+ ♔h8 2 ♕e5+ ♔g8 3 ♕g5+ ♔h8 4 ♖xf7 ♕xf7 5 ♕d8+ ♕g8 6 ♕f6+ ♕g7 7 ♕xg7** mate.

A master must keep a constant watch for the slight variance from the norm which often constitutes a winning solution and can distinguish the top-class player from the run-of-the-mill master. Consider our next illustration. (*See Diagram 314*)

Black has apparently created a winning position, since 1 ♖xf2 fails to 1 ... ♕xc1+ 2 ♖f1 ♖xg2+! winning the queen. However, White has seen the complete answer with **1 ♕f8+! ♔xf8 2 ♘xg5** and the mate in three moves by the two rooks is no longer available, because the rook on f2 is pinned!

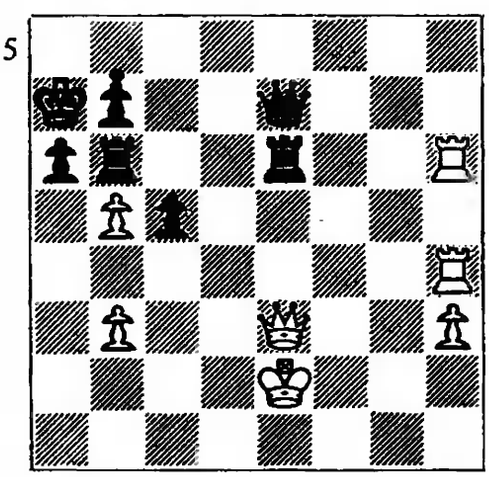
314



Bogoljubow–Becker
Zandvoort, 1936

It is vitally important to look beyond the obvious and refuse to take on trust all our opponent's calculations. In situations which appear lost there are on many occasions possibilities which our opponent, in his eagerness to finish us off, may not have considered at all or which he could have miscalculated. Here is a striking example of such a case.

315



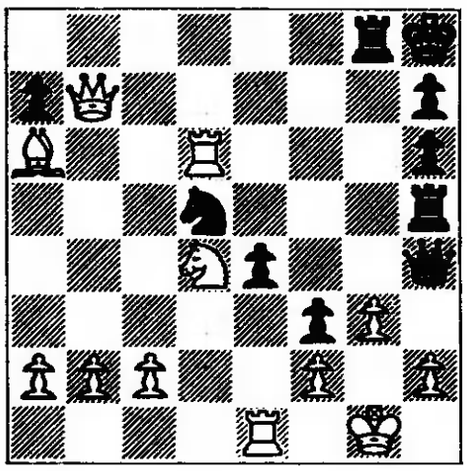
Horowitz–N.N.

Black's seemingly conclusive pin of the white queen rebounds on

him after **1 ♖xe6 ♖xe6? 2 b6+!! ♔xb6** (or 2 ... ♔b8 3 ♖h8+ and mate in two) 3 ♖h6! and the cross-pin wins material for White.

Our final example illustrates the same theme in even more striking fashion.

316



Oneskins–Gama
Switzerland, 1956

Once again it looks all over for White who is about to be quickly mated by the black queen which has just moved to h4, relying on the pin of the g3 pawn. However, there is a way out which White manages to find: **1 ♘xf3!** (opening the e file) **1 ... ef 2 ♕g7+!!** and here we have it, an astounding move whose logic is obvious with hindsight. After **2 ... ♖xg7 3 ♖e8+ ♖g8 4 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8** the g3 pawn is no longer pinned so can now capture the queen!

Unfortunately, it is now time to part from you, dear reader. It only remains for me to wish you every success in the fascinating realm of the combination.

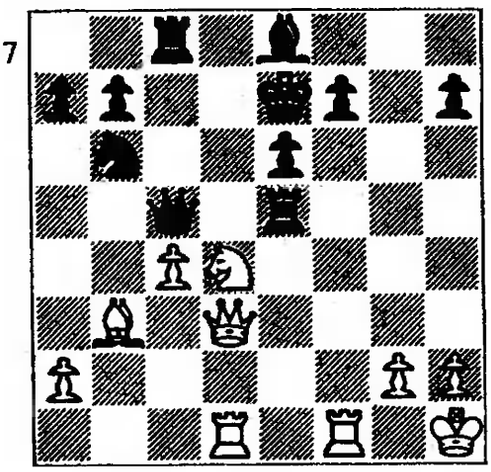
Translator's Note

In the context of this translation, Kotov's final words were to prove tragically prophetic. He is no longer with us, and since this is probably the last of his books to be published in English, it does not seem inappropriate to add a small tribute to the chess-player, writer and journalist I knew and admired from afar.

It has always struck me as sad that the younger generation of British players did not see Kotov visit this country until he was over thirty years past his prime, brought in as an ageing grandmaster to bestow dubious prestige on some ostensibly budding World Champion who managed to beat him during a simultaneous exhibition . . .

There are within this volume a number of excellent examples of Kotov at his tactical best (my own favourites are diagrams 195, 198, 266 and 294), so I will conclude with just one of his many celebrated finishes.

317



Kotov-Yudovich
Leningrad, 1939

By skilful play White has taken control of the d file (... ♖d8 allows ♘c6+) and the f file, has weakened the dark squares in Black's camp (d6 being particularly vulnerable) and is now ready to launch an attack on the black king which has had to remain in the centre. Meanwhile, Black has posted his pieces well to cover up the weakness of the dark squares and is both blockading and attacking the c pawn (if for example 1 ♕xh7 ♖h5 2 ♕g7

♕e5! Black would force exchange of queens and reach a winning endgame). Strangely enough, White's seemingly useless bishop will prove a vital part of White's attack, coming into play via a4, c2, d1 as well as on its own square (after c5) in the main line and sub-variations. Kotov now makes use of all his resources in splendid fashion as follows: 1 ♕g3! ♖e4 (if Black tries to prevent ♕h4+ by moving his rook to h5, the open e file can be exploited by 2 ♘xe6! ♔xe6 3 ♖fe1+ ♔f6 4 ♖d6+ mating or winning the queen; or here 3 ... ♖e5 4 ♖xe5+ ♕xe5 5 c5+! ♔f6 6 ♖f1+ etc.) 2 ♖f5!! (the key move, since the rook has to be captured in view of the variation 2 ... ♕c7 3 ♕g5+ ♔f8 4 ♕h6+ ♔e7 5 ♕f6+ ♔f8 6 ♘xe6+ or 2 ... ♕d6 3 ♖xf7+! ♗xf7 4 ♘f5+ ef 5 ♕xd6+ ♔e8 6 ♗a4+! ♘xa4 7 ♕d7+ and 8 ♕xc8+ winning material in both cases) 2 ... ef 3 ♘xf5+ ♔f6 (clearly 3 ... ♕xf5 allows 4 ♕d6 mate) 4 ♖d6+ ♔xf5 (or 4 ... ♖e6 5 ♕g7+ ♔xf5 6 ♗c2+ ♔f4 7 ♕g3 mate) 5 ♕f3+ ♖f4 (or 5 ... ♔g5 6 ♕f6+ ♔h5 7 ♗d1! ♖g4 8 ♕h6 mate) 6 ♕h5+ ♔e4 7 ♗c2+ ♔e3 8 ♖d3+ and Black resigned before being mated by 9 ♖d2+ and 10 ♕e2.

Let this be Kotov, the player, we remember. As for Kotov, the writer, he has left behind a rich legacy of chess experience which will always be with us.

Index of Players

References are to diagram numbers

Adorjan 70
Ahues 241
Alapin 18
Alden 13
Alekhine 3, 15, 93, 113, 124, 133, 143, 144, 152, 155, 160, 184, 194, 196, 203, 210, 224, 289, 293, 296, 303, 305
Alexander, C.H.O'D. 78
Alexander, F. 87
Alexeyev 66
Andreyev 217
Antuanz 25
Averbakh 123, 307

Babev 106
Bakulin 109
Balashov 69
Balshan 117
Barcza 195, 233
Batuyev 108
Bazan 14
Becker 314
Begun 98
Belavenets 122
Belyavsky 35, 249
Benko 50
Bergman 55
Berstein 85
Bogoljubov 113, 143, 144, 155, 247, 314
Bolbochan 41, 227
Boleslavsky 24, 173, 215
Bondarevsky 115
Botvinnik 27, 108, 120, 167, 173, 176, 185, 259, 309
Bouzi 140
Brinck-Claussen 279
Bronstein 30, 180, 223, 267
Broschait 137
Browne 146
Brühl 256
Burn 99

Capablanca 135
Chaude de Silans 182
Checkhover 23
Cherepkov 11
Chernishev 17
Cogan 258
Cohn 268
Csom 151, 189

Damjanović 313
Danielsson 138
Dely 151, 265, 290, 291
Diez del Corral 166
Diroiris 242
Dolukhanov 217
Donner 294
Duras 37, 251, 268, 273
Durst 250
Dyner 243
Dzhindzhivhashvili 215

Ekenberg 84
Eliskases 244
Enevoldsen 102
Engels 48
Eperjesi 79
Ermenkov 149
Euwe 64, 221, 224, 296

Firensch 207
Fischer 29, 50, 90, 227, 299
Flohr 285
Forintos 49
Foster 258
Freiberg 205
Friedman 222
Furman 61, 80, 225

Gadia 62
Gama 316
Garcia 40
Geller 46, 54, 58, 110, 188, 285, 299
Gereben 59
Gheorghiu 77
Ghitescu 189
Gik 56
Gligorić 30
Gliksman 216
Goban 68
Goglidze 27
Golombek 194, 255
Golzov 72
Goncharov 104
Gotthilf 2
Grigorian 74
Grigoriev 238
Grünfeld 179
Guimard 260
Gulko 307

Hamann 279
Hatjun 291
Hecht 60
Henneberger 244
Hodscha 264
Hofmeister 160
Holmstand 191
Honfi 16
Hörberg 206
Horowitz 315
Hort 168
Horvath 79
Hromadka 116
Hübner 25
Hünnefeld 178

Iliashov 69
Ilivitsky 47
Ilyustchenko 22
Ivanović 183

Janowski 174
Jansa 261
Jerostrom 55
Jimenez 105
Johansson 84, 252
Johner 15, 82
Jovčić 9

Kalmanok 263
Kamishev 71
Karakljaić 265
Karasiev 295
Karlsson 73
Kärner 53
Karpov 56, 86, 89, 102, 304
Kasparian 1, 94
Katalimov 28
Keene 60
Keres 31, 32, 58, 64, 91, 168, 180, 185
Kirilov 61
Klaman 295
Klovsky 186
Kloza 43
Kmoch 172
Konopleva 157
Kopilov 103
Korchnoi 21, 23, 40, 77, 166
Korensky 88
Kotov 85, 123, 153, 181, 195, 198, 206, 246, 259, 260, 263, 266, 275, 292, 294, 317
Kots 119
Krementsky 45
Krüger 150
Kupreichik 35, 106
Kuzmin 74

LaBourdonnais 165
Langeweg 92
Larsen 21, 33, 145
Lasker, Ed. 174, 197
Lasker, Em. 221
Lazdis 5
Lengyel 311
Levenfish 2
Lewitsky 75
Lilienthal 283
Lisvitsin 122
Litkiewicz 26
Lochmer 53
Lowski 281
Loyd 239
Lutikov 313

Mabbs 87
Malich 26, 38
Manvelian 94
Marache 214

Maranjunić 83
Marshall 75, 78, 99
Maryakin 98
Masić 70
Mason 234
Matanović 153
Matulović 309
Matz 205
Mc Donnell 165
Mecking 34, 171
Medina 171
Mendes 62
Miagmasuren 90
Mindeno 184
Mieses 245
Minić 16
Minkov 67
Miszto 43
Mnatsakanian 28
Moiseyev 72, 81
Moore 239
Morphy 214
Muratov 186

Najdorf 33, 118, 223
Nenarokov 238
Nezhmetdinov 1, 148
Niedermann 187
Nilsson 13, 138
Nimzowitsch 172, 305
Novotelnov 46

Olafsson 10
Olland 240
Olsson 191
Oneskins 316
Opočensky 116, 293
Oren 243
Ostojić 63
Ostrovnoi 17

Panno 32, 38, 41, 80
Panov 170
Perez 182
Petrosian 266
Philidor 256
Philippe 140
Pirc 283
Plachetka 36
Planinc 57, 83
Platonov 310
Podgayets 249
Polies 45
Polugayevsky 310
Popović 183
Portisch 54, 101, 107
Postler 207
Prat 3

Radulov 101, 107
Ragozin 100
Rantanen 91
Raud 31
Ravinsky 47
Razuvayev 66
Reggio 245
Reissman 76
Réti 124, 247, 303
Rey 252
Richter 95
Robatsch 261
Rokhlin 235
Römisch 96
Rossolimo 44, 76
Rubinstein 192
Rudakov 198
Rüster 240

Saigin 65
Sämisch 133, 179
Sampouw 12
Sax 149
Sazonov 11
Schlechter 201
Schmid 44
Schmidt 68, 95
Schöneberg 190
Schwarzschild 150
Sergiev 275
Shushina 22
Siegfried 178
Silalahi 12
Silich 235
Sliwa 311
Smitke 157
Smyslov 176, 188, 225, 267
Sofrevski 63
Sokolov 109, 216
Sokolsky 71, 81
Soldos 86
Souza Mendes 34
Spassky 88, 89, 92, 110, 145, 242

Spielmann 135, 210, 273
Stahlberg 223
Steiner 82
Stolberg 120
Strasduns 104
Ströbel 117
Suetin 105
Szabo 246

Tal 10, 111, 118
Tarjan 146
Tarrasch 237, 250
Tartakower 192, 281
Thomas 197
Thomson 222
Thorez 203
Tietz 96
Timofiyev 103, 148
Tomović 49
Treybal 196
Trifunović 255
Troianescu 59
Tukmakov 67, 190
Tulkowski 141

Ufimstev 24, 115
Uhlmann 39, 290, 298
Ujtumen 39
Unzicker 29

Vaganian 57
Vasyukov 97
Veresov 100, 298
Vistaneckis 65
Vik 37
Vukovich 42

Weigap 264
West 93
Westin 73
Wexler 14
Wickmann 9
Winawer 234
Wojciewski 141
Wolf 201

Yevseyev 97
Yudovich 181, 317
Yurgis 167

Zaitsev 292, 304
Zinn 36
Zucs 187

FOR CHESS... READ BATSFORD/AMERICAN CHESS PROMOTIONS

'Chess is 99% tactics' wrote Teichmann. This is something of an exaggeration, but tactics do decide a large number of games and many opportunities for combinational finishes are missed by the average player.

This book provides a systematic classification of tactical themes and Kotov selects the most interesting middle game positions to illustrate these ideas. Complete games are also given in the text and the author explains how the victim allowed a tactical finish to arise.

Alexander Kotov is widely regarded as one of the most profound writers on chess. His much acclaimed trilogy *Think Like a Grandmaster, Play Like a Grandmaster,* and *Train Like a Grandmaster* brought a new dimension to the way chessplayers think.

317 diagrams

For a complete list of chess books featuring Batsford/American Chess Promotions publications please write to:
American Chess Promotions
3055 General Lee Road
Macon, Georgia 31204

ISBN 0 7134 2562 8